MARITIME LITERATURE AND CULTURE

Hydrocriticism and Colonialism in Latin America

Water Marks

Edited by Mabel Moraña

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Maritime Literature and Culture

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Mabel Moraña
Editor

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CHAPTER 1

Introduction: Texts, Textures, and Water Marks

Mabel Moraña

Today the mythical Mediterranean is brutally vernacularized in the fraught journeys of anonymous men, women, and children migrating across its waters: Caliban returns as an illegal immigrant, and Prospero's island, midway between Naples and Tunis in the sixteenth-century drama, becomes modern-day Lampedusa.
—Iain Chambers

I

This book engages with *hydrocriticism* as a critical and theoretical approach that focuses on social realities and forms of domination in which bodies of water play a fundamental role, as the medium for reaching and controlling people, lands, and/or natural resources. As environmental variables, bodies of water generate specific strategies for the exercise of power and resistance, and for the sustainability of life. Concurrently, collective imaginaries

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integrate in multiple ways liquid and territorial spaces and develop creative ways to articulate these domains both in material and symbolic manners.

As indicated by Isabel Hofmeyr in *Dockside Reading, Hydrocolonialism and the Custom House* (2022):

> [*hydrocolonialism*] could include colonization by way of water (various forms of maritime imperialism), colonization of water (occupation of land with water resources, the declaration of territorial waters, the militarization and geopoliticization of oceans), a colony on (or in) water (the ship as a miniature colony or a penal island), colonization through water (flooding of occupied land) and colonization of the idea of water (establishing water as a secular resource). (16)

As this introduction and the following chapters will show, this perspective is particularly relevant for the study of territorial conquests in Early Modern times, and the correlative creation of Luso-Spanish empires in the so-called New World. At the same time, *hydrocritical* perspectives illuminate on aspects related to the development of colonial life; the management of water resources; the technology developed in dealing with irrigation, droughts and flooding; the uses of rivers as natural borders to delimitate territorial possessions, to transport merchandise, travelers, and missionaries, to evade enemies, to express transcendental conceptions, to develop an understanding of nature, and to relate with the world of the dead.[1] As Hofmeyr indicates, the clear separation of land and water only exists in the imagination. Both domains sustain and constitute each other, environmentally as well as socially, politically, and economically to the point of becoming an amphibious, unified totality, in societies determined by their dependency and interactions with maritime space.[2]

Obviously, the understanding of bodies of water and their material and symbolic significance has changed over the years in close correlation to the advancement of scientific knowledge but also linked to cultural interpretations, religious beliefs, and ways of life that integrated the connection of peoples and seas in different manners and degrees.[3] Lindsay Starkey's book *Encountering Water in Early Modern Europe and Beyond: Redefining the Universe through Natural Philosophy, Religious Reformations, and Sea Voyaging* (2020) provides an extensive analysis of the environmental connections between land and the oceans, and their representation in the Bible, among the Greeks and in the Renaissance.

Expansionism, explorations, and the development of mercantilism characterized a world in which previous figurations of time and space radically changed. Particularly after the sixteenth and the seventeenth centuries, human mobility increased and diversified, covering unseen trajectories on land and sea. Ports and coastal areas intensified their relevance and magnetism as much for merchants and scientific travelers as for religious and political officials. Concurrently, foreign fleets, pirates, smugglers, and buccaneers populated oceanic waters, adding a dose of danger and uncertainty to the natural risks of nautical endeavors.

Many narratives of maritime encounters have been produced in connection to the Spanish and Luso-Brazilian colonies, as analyzed by Nina Gerassi-Navarro and other authors, intrigued by the representation of new characters determined by the peculiarities of a liquid and mysterious environment that invited the emergence of unseen behaviors and intensified emotions. The sea was re-discovered numerous times, from very different perspectives, depending on the provenance of the protagonists, the goals of their actions and the magnitude of their entourage. To give just one example, these elements multiplied the image and significance of the Atlantic Ocean, identified in turn as the Black Atlantic, the Jewish Atlantic, the Catholic Atlantic, the British Atlantic, the Atlantic of the slaves, the missionaries, and the entrepreneurs. Also, the vision of the sea would change according to the positionality of the subject. The images of the castaway and the stowaway constituted for centuries allegorical representations of human beings abandoned by divine and natural foces to the turbulence of life and destiny.[4]

For the New World, crucial historical developments such as those of conquest, colonization, Christianization, enslavement, monopolist mercantilism, Westernization and, later on, modernization, nationalism, republicanism, and so on, would be unthinkable without the comprehension of colonialism and the role of transatlantic ventures, transpacific migrations, and inter-Caribbean fluxes of human beings, ideas, and commodities.[5] This highly politicized dynamics considerably enriches, in my opinion, the critical space opened by *hydrocriticism*, by adding to the ontological reading of bodies of water, the elements of economic interest and profit that were key for colonialist endeavors and also crucial for the early emergence of peripheral capitalism. At the same time, both the colonial(ist) and the imperial(ist) perspectives illuminate on the differential significance of water in a variety of geo-cultural and political contexts, where strategic locations, modes of domination, and forms of resistance

shape environmental connections and collective subjectivities. Of course, in the context of the world wars, the oceans will become battlefields, and their significance change depending on the political standpoint of the observer.[6]

In postcolonial times, the conceptual appropriation of the ocean is, then, inseparable from the notions of domination, submission, enslavement, territorial devastation, and genocide. For this reason, the ocean has always been approached with ambiguity and caution, thus becoming the source of anxiety and the inspiration of fantastic figurations. Hofmeyr observes that in a postcolonial context:

> [l]and is favored both as an automatic platform of knowledge and as a locus of the colonial and anticolonial nation. The ocean, by contrast, has been forgotten, first by the emerging settler colonial nation attempting to erase its origins and then by anticolonial nationalism turning its back on the ocean as a source of imperialism. In a postnational age, the rich and creolized meanings of the ocean, both precolonially and colonially, are starting to be more systematically explored. (*Dockside Rreading*19)

However, in specific geo-cultural contexts, such as the Caribbean, the relevance and omnipresence of the seas is so notorious that maritime reality is an essential element for the understanding of both the history of the region and the configuration of collective imaginaries. Together with the conceptualization of oceanic surroundings, notions associated to archipelagic formations and islandic interconnections have been continuously analyzed by historians and cultural critics. In his classic book *The Repeating Island. The Caribbean and the Postmodern Perspective* (1996, published originally in Spanish in 1989) Antonio Benítez-Rojo emphasizes the variegated nature of the region: "its fragmentation, its instability; its reciprocal isolation; its uprootedness; its cultural heterogeneity; its lack of historiography and historical continuity; its contingency and impermanence; its syncretism" (1). For him,

> the Antilles are an island bridge connecting, in "another way", North and South America. This geographical accident gives the entire area, including its continental foci, the character of an archipelago, that is, a discontinuous conjunction (the question of what?) unstable condensations, turbulences, whirlpools, clumps of bubbles, frayed seaweed, sunken galleons, crashing breakers, flying fish, seagull squawks, downpours, nighttime phosphorescence, eddies and pools, uncertain voyages of signification; in short, a field of observation quite in tune with the objectives of Chaos. (2)

Ontological dimensions become interpretive strategies, perceptions give way to ambiguous impressions, and natural and cultural elements constitute new realities, or new dreams of the real. Fragmentation incorporates the fluidity of meanings into the processes of knowledge acquisition, as if the liquid condition of the Caribbean region had been interiorized in its history and its temperament (2). Benítez-Rojo defines his literary and cultural critique (which spans from Christopher Columbus and Bartolomé de Las Casas, to Nicolás Guillén, Fernando Ortiz, and Alejo Carpentier) as an incursion into Chaos. The author attempts to find "passages into the labyrinth," "processes, dynamics and rhythms that show themselves within the marginal, the regional, the incoherent, the heterogeneous, or, if you like, the unpredictable, that coexists with us in our everyday world." According to the critic, the emphasis on *repetition* incorporates, in the discourse of Chaos, the idea of a constant insertion of *difference*, "a step toward nothingness" (3).

Other critics have developed studies on the Caribbean that establish a productive dialogue with Benítez-Rojo's book, expanding their scope to other areas of contemporary culture in which migration plays a fundamental role.

Yolanda Martinez-San Miguel has significantly contributed to new interpretations of the region. Her book *Coloniality of Diasporas. Rethinking Intra-Colonial Migrations in a Pan-Caribbean Context* (2014) analyzes inter-islandic migrations and other forms of human displacement that take place across "fragmented borders." For centuries, these ventures have been registered in multiple testimonial and fictional narratives where the sea seems to be the main character and, at the same time, the inescapably complex and deep scenario of human mobilizations. As mentioned by Paul Gilroy, the sea promotes the development of a *double consciousness* of belonging and foreignness, identity and alterity that chronicles and fictional texts represent through a number of aesthetic strategies.

In a more recent collection of studies, Martinez-San Miguel and Michelle Stephens have explored *Contemporary Archipelagic Thinking* (2020), where the notion of archipelago expands as a productive metaphor of disciplinary formations illustrated by the image of apparently self-contained critical and theoretical approaches that, like the Antilles, are "isolated above but connected below."[7]

Iván de la Nuez in *La balsa perpetua. Soledad y conexiones de la cultura cubana* (1998) [*The Perpetual Boat. Loneliness and Connections in Cuban Culture*] refers to the constant flux of migrants that followed the

implementation of the American blockade on Cuba, and that also resulted from internal social conditions such as repression of non-traditional sexualities and the like, which motivated the *sexile*.

In these heavy-traffic routes between the islands and continental lands, the threats and the promises of Caribbean waters produced a complex imagery, where history and imagination interweave. Time and again, the Caribbean is the scenario of necropolitical strategies and also a repository of strategies for survival through real and/or imaginary trips.

II

Mysterious and unpredictable, endowed at the same time with colossal material—aqueous—force and immense symbolic strength, oceanic bodies of water communicate the notions of monstrosity and sublimity, confronting humanity with the fragility of life, the incontrollable passage of time, and the futility of earthly matters. The liquid extensions of oceans and seas not only establish their own temporal and spatial dimensions but also determine the conditions of life in the surrounding territorial regions. Harbors, littoral zones, coastlines, riverbanks, seafronts, and beaches, as well as intermediate formations such as archipelagoes, islands, isthmuses, and peninsulas, are characterized by hybrid features and indeterminate borders, and owe to water at least half of their properties. Bodies of water define lifestyles (forms of settlement, physical displacements, commercial and cultural exchanges) as much as attitudes, preferences, and activities. They also generate particular genres of writing such as chronicles, diaries, logbooks, charts of navigation, maritime cartographies, and the like.

Shores give new meaning to the notion of limit because they signal the end and the beginning of complementary life spaces that expose, each in its own right, the diversity and richness of nature. Ports and coastal areas function as open doors for intercultural and cosmopolitan relations and are, at the same time, thresholds violently trespassed by imperial enterprises. Foreign intruders, invaders, colonizers, and plunderers of natural resources are the transgressors that both in land and water dismiss the notion of limit and redefine the concept of frontier. The actors on display in oceanic scenarios are uniquely linked to the liquidity of time/space coordinates: fishermen, sailors, passengers, buccaneers, stowaways, corsairs, pirates, castaways, smugglers, and marine merchants are transitory presences that intersect the permanent instability of seascapes.[8] Many of them have archaic resonances today; others still traverse, one way or another, the oceanic spaces of globalization.

As the scholars of maritime and oceanic studies recognize, seas and oceans are more than mere metaphors to express grandiosity, fate, and passion, or to make reference to the notions of transcendence and eternal mobility. While oceanic spaces are, to a great extent, cultural constructs, we are directly confronted with their concrete existence and ontological dimension. Oceanic reality mobilizes forms of cognition and feeling that differ from those usually applied to territorial experiences. At the same time, the study of oceanic and maritime dynamics relates to a great variety of disciplinary domains, whose methods and agendas overlap: ecological studies, oceanography, scientific explorations of oceanic life, maritime borderization, and so on. In addition, connections are being made between Atlantic and (trans) Pacific histories, without reducing the importance of these oceanic immensities to the relations between these two bodies of water. Rather, current studies emphasize the disparities that characterize them in terms of scale, demography, indigenous populations, commercial development, and other processes such as the militarization and nuclearization of the Pacific and the impact of climate change (Poppenhagen and Temmen 150).[9]

The knowledge of oceans' elusive materiality requires an understanding of their particular epistemology. The oceanic *mode* of being is captured by categories that, most of the time, would not apply to territorial occurrences. A myriad of actions, relations, and affective responses are only possible in the specific space of incessant movement, liquid immensity, and loneliness. However, the nature and qualities of the sea are often approached with territorial concepts that cannot grasp the singularity of maritime domains. According to Laura Winkiel, "the maritime turn, asks us to consider the textualization of the waters—the submerged histories, aesthetics, and ontologies of 'heavy waters' (DeLoughrey)—along with the altered temporal and spatial scales, geographies, and agencies of the nonhuman seas, and to imagine new ways of connecting the two" ("Hydro-criticism").

What Philip Steinberg and Kimberley Peters suggestively called "wet ontologies" has both cognitive and methodological implications. Firstly, this notion allows to recognize the singularity of *liquid* perspectives and to theorize change and mobility as permanent qualities of living creatures and nature's intricate constituents.[10] Secondly, and, in my opinion, more importantly, the concept supports the attempts "to destabilize the static, bordered, and linear framings that typify human geographical studies of place, territory, and time" ("Wet ontologies" 247). The critics emphasize

that their analysis moves not only beyond the "more-than-human" experiences inherent to oceanic worlds, but issues related to time, volume, and flow, as they manifest beyond terrestrial limits ("Wet ontologies" 250). Their perspective seeks to counterbalance the unidimensional notions of fixity and territoriality.[11]

All of the above points to the possibility to utilize alternative epistemic and methodological routes for the study of colonialism, nation formation, modernity, and globalization. In the exploration and analysis of these processes, oceanic studies unbind the limitations embedded in the perspective of territorial control and land domination, thus exposing a much larger and complex domain for the study of intercultural relations. An illustrative example comes from the historical analysis of slave trade, an epic development of devastating consequences, almost always analyzed through documental sources that inform about slaves' hardships and dehumanizing treatments on land, with less attention to details related to their calamitous transoceanic journeys, and to the feelings that the ocean itself inspired in captive individuals. Myths, religious beliefs, oral narratives, and testimonials mobilized, at that level, an intricate web of images, stories, and predictions related to the new spaces, oceanic and terrestrial, that extended beyond the limits of the motherland.

Influential works have already shown the impact of transoceanic encounters in the formation of collective imaginaries, and the need to incorporate a relational approach to the study of societies that incorporated the significance of maritime dimensions in their understanding of the world. Also, they have warned against the limitations of national and nationalistic historiography, which contributes to perpetuate the myth of both self-contained imaginaries and cultural purity. The following are just two well-known examples of studies that have opened new avenues through the valorization of oceanic factors in the making of contemporary history.

Edouard Glissant's *Poetics of Relation*, published in French in 1990, is a good example of this line of inquire. He analyzes aspects of the transoceanic voyages of slaves, the impact of these journeys on the memory of individuals and communities, their conflictive figurations of the homeland, and the feelings of objectification and existential uncertainty that dominated their lives. For Glissant, sharing knowledge (empirical information, cultural values, memories, etc.) constituted one of the important sides of an undoubtedly traumatic experience. The notion of *antillanité* derives from this mobility that finds in the constant variation of the ocean a new way to understand temporality, identity, and space. Reading Glissant, Iain

Chambers recognizes in "Maritime Criticism and Theoretical Shipwrecks" (2010), that "the centrality of sea to modernity promotes that adoption of a more fluid cartography in which the stability of the historical archive, together with the stability of its associated facts, territorial museums, and nationalist interpretations, is set afloat" (681), and he adds:

> Edouard Glissant reminds us that if, as Schmitt argues, the sea is the royal highway of the West, for the rest of the world the sea is more about depth than extension. On the invisible sea bottom we can follow an inconceivable passage marked by slavery, drowning, brutality, and the wrecked lives of ferocious migration today. (Chambers 681)[12]

In *Black Atlantic. Modernity and Double Consciousness* (1993) Paul Gilroy focuses on slaves' diasporic displacement as a social formation in itself, that broke its links with European domination, thus allowing African people to express their feelings and beliefs outside of the conventional models of metropolitan societies, and to project themselves, even under their terrible living conditions, beyond the constraints of national boundaries. Gilroy emphasizes the importance of social and cultural interactions that had in hazardous transatlantic journeys, such as the middle passage, one of the instances in which mutual recognition emerged. The British sociologist sees the "Black Atlantic as a Counterculture of Modernity," and as a *chronotope* that provides new parameters for the study of reterritorialization and transcultural exchanges. In his own words:

> I have settled on the image of ships in motion across the spaces between Europe, America, Africa, and the Caribbean as a central organizing symbol for this enterprise and as my starting point. The image of the ship—a living, micro-cultural, micro-political system in motion—is especially important for historical and theoretical reasons […] Ships immediately focus attention on the middle passage, on the various projects for redemptive return to an African homeland, on the circulation of ideas and activists as well as the movement of key cultural and political artefacts: tracts, books, gramophone records, and choirs. (Gilroy 4)

We can see, then, how from these already classic and groundbreaking studies that connect modernity and oceanic crossings, scholarship advances toward the transformation of critical paradigms that recognize and assume the debilitation of the nation-state and the proliferation of trans/post-national movements. These dynamics leave behind the most traditional

forms of national(ist) historiographical thinking and landlocked critical categories (sovereignty, citizenship, state governmentality) in order to analyze the changing role of water formations that in the present time are the object of environmental concerns, and the scenario of necropolitical repression. The study of *hydrocolonialism*, focuses, from this perspective, not only [in] colonization *by means of* water and colonization *of* water (the occupation of land with water resources, the appropriation of territorial waters, and the militarization of oceans) but also a colony *on* or *in* water (the ship as a floating penal colony and infamous penal islands such as Robben, Alcatraz, Rikers, Devil's, St. Helena, and Isabela) (Winkiel 4). The notions of "hydro-power," "hydro-imaginaries," "hydro-eroticism," and the like, utilized in the special issue on *Hydrocriticism* (*English Language Notes* 57, 1 [April 2010]), suggest the ample field of application of this critical direction, and the originality of critical and theoretical perspectives it opens at many different disciplinary levels.

The role of seas and oceans was so prominent in the consolidation of Modern Europe's centrality that the return to the bodies of water as a material and symbolic space of political, historical, and philosophical reflection should not be surprising. Imperial domination, mercantile economies, migratory movements, military encounters, and cosmopolitan exchanges had in Western oceanic and maritime extensions a strategic space that, until now, has not been appropriately theorized.

These are some of the reasons that explain the connections between hydrocriticism and postcolonial studies, well described by Iain Chambers:

> The idea of the sea as a potential "plane of immanence" proposes the laboratory of another modernity, in which the hegemonic time and space of capital are viewed askance, diverted, and subverted (Deleuze and Guattari). The sea becomes the countersite of heterotopia of modernity. As Cesare Cesarino argues, the centrality of the sea and the ship to the making of occidental modernity propels us to set modernity on floating foundations. (Chambers 679)

III

If the human right to movement and territorial relocation is, in theory, recognized as indisputable, restrictions and penalizations have been always applied to border crossing, trespassing, and other forms of spatial transgressions of traditional and/or official delimitations. Territorial stability is

assumed as a principle of order and defense of privacy, property, and sovereignty. It is also considered one of the pillars of individual and collective identity, a notion related to steadiness and permanence. Researchers that analyze oceanic environments from a sociological and epistemic perspective observe, however, that maritime regions transmit a different experience of space, since they constitute, primarily, "a dynamic field that—through its movement, through our encounters with its movement, and through our efforts to interpret its movement—produces *difference* even as it unifies' (Steinberg, "Of Other Seas" 161, my emphasis). This is one of the reasons why oceanic studies have been particularly welcomed by postmodern/postcolonial approaches, whose critique of identity politics, territoriality and *borderization* have occupied the center of debates.

The question of national limits often approaches the element of water as one of the constituting natural demarcations that defines territoriality in an undisputable manner, as if rivers, lakes, or seas were part of a political design that distributes lands, according to the principles of private property and sovereignty. Water appears, from this perspective, as the natural obstacle that seems to legitimize the compartmentalization of the world, by restricting human movement in a "natural" way.

In the context of colonialism, bodies of water oppose worlds of abundance from worlds of deprivation, spaces of privilege from areas of precariousness, power from submission, and, for this reason, function as frontiers that inevitably generate resistance and transgression. Both in pre-modern and contemporary scenarios, the biopolitical potential of oceanic extensions cannot be underestimated. As the element that sustains the implementation of imperial endeavors, maritime space also becomes the challenging obstacle for fleeing the oppression of territoriality. In "Oceanic Routes" Kerry Bystrom and Isabel Hofmeyr use the term "hydrocolonial" to refer to this new dimension of imperial endeavors focused on the strategic role of transoceanic actions and relations traditionally analyzed as territorial expansion and appropriation of human and natural terrestrial resources. In these scenarios, water constituted not only the challenging space to be conquered before the arrival to the new territories but also a key element for the further development of colonization, for incursions in the land and, later on, for the delivery of precious metals to metropolitan destinations. Given the belief in mythical elements, such as monsters of the sea, enchanted islands, and supernatural creatures that were believed to inhabit the oceans, transatlantic crossings were, without a doubt, an

emotional and psychological challenge, since it implied the conquest of fears, and the leap into mysterious and uncertain domains.

Reflecting about the actors in charge of imperial undertakings, Suvendrini Perera reflected on the racially and genderly defined *subjects of colonization* (mostly white males) who historically embarked on the predatory incursions of conquest, exploration and colonization.[13] Such operations led to the violent appropriation of lands, the devastation of indigenous cultures, the enslavement of subaltern peoples, and the seizure of natural resources. Contrary to the forceful and adventurous role assigned to men, "white women remain mostly shore creatures" (Perera 60).[14]

In this manner, while recognizing the naturally unifying quality of water, and its life-supporting role, Perera also perceives its antithetical potential as a dividing and life-effacing force. Such a duality becomes evident in the necropolitical strategy of "unmaking water," that is, of transforming its elemental nature (its fluidity, its unrestricted movement, its free and open being) into a politically manipulated medium that serves the purpose of enforcing territorial supremacy. As part of the border delimitation between Mexico and the US, the Río Bravo clearly illustrates this situation. In the same manner, the Mediterranean functions today as a *sea*metery between Africa and Europe, tragically reversing the connecting and productive role of the *Mare Nostrum*.[15]

Refugee bodies demonstrate, in their erratic and unpredictable displacement, the need to think about strategies that could transform water from obstacle and isolating element into a conducive medium toward survival and emancipation. According to Perera, "[t]hrough their movements, these refugee bodies enact new spatial and political materialities, and inscribe embodied counter-geographies and relations" (59). Their itineraries, as well as the stories that narrate their dislocated journeys, have renounced all totalization and resort to fragmentation, hiatuses, and juxtapositions to express their dramatic experience of marginal spaces and abandonment.

Perera adopts the term *geocorpographies*, coined by Joseph Pugliese (2007),

> to signify how the ocean, too, operates as an arena where bodies and stories are enmeshed with the geopolitical, as they also inscribe it in their own counter-mappings, poetics and suborn resistances of relations of territorial and imperial violence. (Perera 60)[16]

In most representations, the sea is shown as a superior, irrational, and challenging force against which human efforts are tested time after time. In present times, the fluxes of integration and intercommunications, as well as the necropolitical energies that traverse the global world, are often identified with the inexorable potency of oceanic dynamics, and their basically mysterious and ineluctable energy. At the same time, the proliferation of borders and the persistence of migration also convey the idea of the *unmaking of lands* through the impugnation of fixed boundaries and territorial distributions. Ratna Kapur states:

> The sovereign state and the sovereign subject are being laid bare through the challenges posed by the world's constitutive "Others". The liberal state and the liberal subject are based on the idea of fixed borders, with clearly identifiable interests and identities. They are imbued with the power to decide, choose, and act autonomously. Yet, globalization, which produces the challenge of migration and non-state actors to the legitimacy of the borders of the sovereign state and the autonomous subject, indicates otherwise. (Kapur 11–12, cited by Perera 64)

IV

In Latin American history, oceans have always been a decisive element, at economic, political, and cultural levels. It is well known that pre-Hispanic cultures attributed multiple and often also contradictory meanings to natural elements, particularly to water, which surrounded the land with its constant movement and the potential to advance over lands with monstrous strength. Flooding and droughts revealed the temperamental character of gods and the unsurmountable potential of nature, thus confirming the almost insignificance of humans in the big design of terrestrial and transcendent dimensions.[17] The multiple meanings of oceans, seas, and water in general cover an ample spectrum of seemingly contradictory significances, which depend on the worldview of each civilization, their beliefs, interests, and collective experience. From classic and European perspectives, the oceans have always constituted mysterious and mythical spaces, connoting the ideas of freedom, life, death, origin, fertility, and many others. Conceived in the Renaissance as a *final frontier*, a supposedly unsurpassable extension inhabited by monsters and characterized by danger, uncertainty, and loneliness, oceans also acquired a different value as the connecting medium that made possible the consolidation of

mercantilism, the appropriation of new territories and the transportation of wealth, obtained through the hard work of enslaved peoples. From the "territorial political economy perspective," Philip Steinberg refers to the specific meaning of maritime space in the context of colonialism, indicating that "this process of spatial construction occurs at sea as well as on land; [...] ocean-space is thus an arena of social conflict" (*The Social Construction of the Sea* 6).

On the logbook of the first trip, the day before the great discovery, Christopher Columbus indicated: "I sailed to the West southwest, and we took more water aboard than at any other time on the voyage" (Bergreen 1). Water was around them, outside and inside their vessels, in front of them, behind them, in their present, their memories, and their imagination, as the unavoidable and ever-present element against which bravery, skill, and loyalty to the Crown needed to be proven, once and again. Duty and adventure, ambition, desire and determination, were always connected to the unconquerable fluidity of the ocean, and to the divine designs that guided the journeys.

But, without a doubt, one of the most important resignifications of the ocean is related to what is called the Middle Passage, in reference to the forced journeys endured by Africans in their way to the New World, where they would become slaves assigned to work in *encomiendas*, *mitas*, *repartimientos*, domestic service, and even military work, for the benefit of their peninsular or creole masters in America. These journeys, which spanned between 1519 until mid-nineteenth century, constituted a voyage in space and time, which tormented bodies and imagination, affectivity, and intellectual understanding of reality, in which the water was, at many levels, the key bio-political element: for transportation, survival, suicides, disposal of corpses, as well as for phantasies of freedom, escape, return to the motherland, and so on.[18]

According to Elizabeth DeLoughrey, "the violent corporeal history of the Atlantic" constitutes

> a place where the haunting of the past overtakes the present subject. Édouard Glissant has described the Atlantic as a "beginning" for modernity, a space "whose time is marked by. .. balls and chains gone green" (Poetics 6): a sign of submarine history and its material decay. Thus, Atlantic modernity becomes legible through the sign of heavy water, an oceanic stasis that signals the dissolution of wasted lives. (703)

Taken from Gaston Bachelard, the notion of "heavy water" is used by DeLoughrey "to describe how Atlantic inscriptions rupture the naturalizing flow of history, foregrounding a now time that registers violence against the wasted lives of modernity in the past and the present" (704). In other words, attention to the sea, and what its *heavy waters* conceal, allows for an alternative reading of modernity, and for a reinterpretation of the Atlantic Ocean as some kind of marine cemetery where, from the journeys of the Middle Passage to the tragic developments of present-day migration, the corpses of slaves, refugees, asylum seekers, stowaways, and "irregular" migrants have not ceased to accumulate, in an anonymous and shameful testimony of transhistorical racism and inequality.[19]

DeLoughrey refers to Zygmunt Bauman's idea that "modernity is constituted by the boundaries erected between the normative and the disposable, resulting in an enormous surveillance industry dedicated to policing the borders between citizens and refugees. He characterizes our 'liquid modernity' as 'a civilization of excess, redundancy, waste and waste disposal' (Bauman 97), one that produces human refugees as 'the waste products of globalization'" (Bauman 66) (DeLoughrey 704). In this manner, DeLoughrey brilliantly emphasizes the other side of possible idealizations of the sea as inherently free space, impossible to own and to tame, reminding us of the processes of privatization, ocean governance, and militarization that have increased particularly since the end of the Cold War and that are proliferating around the world. If, as Steinberg indicated, in the industrial capitalist era "the sea was constructed as an asocial space between societies" (*The Social Construction* 208), this is certainly not true in the globalized world, where oceans are treated as disputable territories and, often, as private domains that create their own laws and declare their own *states of exception*. In this sense, "[t]he seas remain racialized and colonized" (Winkiel, "Introduction" 4).

Latin American history would be incomprehensible without the awareness of the significance of the forces that were imposed on "New World" territories through transoceanic voyages that incorporated to the complex pre-Hispanic cultures the barbarism of Old World's civilization. Against all odds, conquerors and missionaries, explorers and entrepreneurs, *encomenderos*, miners, and ecclesiastic authorities managed to relocate in virgin lands the logics of mercantilism, the predatory methods of colonialism, the ignominy of slavery, the dominance of capital, the impact of selective modernization, and the mundane interests of the Church. At the same time, the forceful introduction of European models of communication,

belief, socio-political organization, and economic exploitation of natural and human resources cancelled abruptly, with enormous cost in human lives, the connections of autochthonous cultures with their natural environment. Non-European civilizations were forcefully amalgamated with new social and cultural paradigms originated across the oceans, which intermixed, in asymmetric processes, with native populations. Oceans acted as connecting spaces that, simultaneously, united and separated metropolitan and colonial environments. Opposing realities existing on both sides of the oceans became engaged in continuous processes of syncretism, transculturation, miscegenation, and hybridization.

V

As a result of many of the challenges and concerns related to the relatively new field of oceanic studies, this book gathers a series of studies where water, oceanic spaces, maritime journeys, and symbolic representations of fluidity and constant liquid movement configure a *post-territorial poetics* aimed to opening alternative perspectives on a wide range of topics. The thematic areas approached in these chapters are of interdisciplinary nature and focus on a number of fields that have in common the essential importance of bodies of water in the comprehension of social, political, and cultural realities. The issues discussed here are related to the implementation of colonialism, the development of ecclesiastic and doctrinal pan-European circulation in colonial times, the importance of nautical narratives and the dissemination of oceanic knowledge, the methodologies and interpretation of discursive and quantitative information contained in nautical texts, the technological interventions on flooded lands in Mexico, the significance of the circumnavigation of the globe in colonial times, and the representation of the Middle Passage in contemporary literature.

The current book offers a multifarious critical approach to the study of the impact that oceanic environments have had in the conquest and conceptualization of the New World, and to the perspectives this viewpoint opens for a new understanding of the place the new continent occupied in worldwide imaginaries at the time of colonization. At the same time, the chapters reunited in this volume explore the advantages of hydrocriticism for an alternative and complementary interpretation of continental history and culture. Probably the main contribution of the volume is the analysis of multiple perspectives on the material role and symbolic significance of

oceanic spaces, seen from often antagonist loci of enunciation. Several chapters refer to the Early Modern period, when the direct effect of expansionism shows the crucial relevance of oceanic spaces and the need to conquer maritime environments as a prerequisite for territorial settlement.

From the maritime crossings focused by the first two chapters of this book to the perspective of Spaniards and Indigenous peoples analyzed by Ivonne del Valle, and the re-reading of Sigüenza y Góngora's *Infortunios* by Buscaglia-Salgado, the reader of this collection of essays will be exposed to a kaleidoscopic approach to the omnipresence of water in colonial times and the multiple functions it had in the development of political and religious power, social survival, and stabilization of daily life. At the same time, the studies included in this book will highlight the variety of characters activated in the context of maritime colonialism: conquerors, *adelantados*, missionaries, sailors, slave traffickers, scientific travelers, political officials, members of Indigenous communities, and peoples of African descent, together with Spaniards and Creoles in high and low ranks, *letrados*, and entrepreneurs, all involved in the process of making sense of the worlds opened and cancelled by imperial domination. Christian Supiot offers a fundamental study that proposes to consider the *central* role of the viceroyalty of New Spain in the context of Spain's *hydropolitical* domination, while Clayton McCarl proposes a methodological approach to the categorization and historiographical analysis of nautical texts. In the final essay, Miguel Valerio's critical piece will introduce the reader to a particular figuration of maritime myths and interpretations of Caribbean imaginaries through the display of Yemanjá's lyrical powers as depicted in *Mãe Sereia* (*Mother Mermaid, 2019*) by Afro-Cuban writer Teresa Cárdenas.

In spite of involuntary but unavoidable gaps, the present collection of essays will be instrumental in opening up new avenues of inquiry for scholars and students interested in the innovative avenues of hydrocriticism. The study of oceanic spaces prove the existence of new critical and theoretical horizons, while demonstrating that every type of analysis is necessarily tentative and provisional, and that unanticipated domains of exploration are yet to be discovered and developed in order to potentiate areas of knowledge that have remained dormant until now.

In order to guide the reader through the interconnected essays of this book, what follows is a brief reference to the central issues discussed in each chapter:

> Catalina Andrango-Walker and Stephanie Kirk analyze narratives produced in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, respectively, in which maritime crossings and religious missions played a key role in the development of imperial projects characterized by political and religious entanglements. In the first case, the central text studied by Andrango-Walker, *Verdadera descripción de la provincia y tierra de las Esmeraldas* (c.1589) (*True description of the province and land of Esmeraldas*), was produced by Spanish cleric Miguel Cabello Balboa as a narrative focused on the eventful military and religious expedition initiated in 1578 in Esmeraldas, a northern province of today's Ecuador, with the task of finding a safe and direct route from Quito to the Pacific Ocean. This expedition, which lasted for two years and ended up as a frustrated project, was conceived in the context of social and political unrest. Esmeralda's heterogeneous population included, as Andrango-Walker indicates, a variety of groups of indigenous and African ascend, which represented a constant and unpredictable challenge to colonization. At the same time, the ocean, that had been traversed by conquerors and slaves, also brought to Ecuadorian beaches the feared presence of pirate Francis Drake, thus adding another element to the already unstable regional situation. In her study, Andrango-Walker discusses the perceptions Spanish, Africans, and Indigenous sectors had about the ocean, and the contradictory values they assigned to it. If on the one hand the ocean represented for the conquerors the opportunities associated with trade and economic success, this body of water was also seen as a potentially dangerous route for the arrival of enemies that could be a threat to Spanish hegemony. For slaves it evoked the motherlands, the lost freedom, and the horrors of maritime journeys to the New World. For indigenous sectors it signified foreign penetration, threat to their ways of life, uncertainty, and danger. As the author of this chapter indicates, "in this regard, the Pacific Ocean both facilitated and challenged colonialism, by allowing the free flow of both people and capital."[20]

Kirk's critical piece is centered in the maritime journeys that Dominican friar Thomas Gage and Jesuit missionary Michael Wadding took from their homelands (England and Ireland, respectively), first to Spain, in order to receive Catholic education, and later on to the New World. According to Kirk, "examining [their journeys] through a maritime perspective helps shed new light on the missionary's role as agent of Empire, religion and Catholic masculinity." Gage's and Wadding's deterritorialization, and their direct experience of oceans as domains of uncertainty, danger, and instability, contributed to their worldview and, in particular, to their reflection on the intricacies of faith and the roles of religious men in

the advancement of imperial domination. As Kirk indicates, their very different and, at the same time, convergent experiences, also illustrate about the ways in which "Catholicism promoted cosmopolitan circulation of men and doctrine, in a Pan-European and transatlantic context."

Christian Supiot examines in his chapter a series of maritime narratives produced in the seventeenth century in the viceroyalty of New Spain by well-known Baroque writer Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora and Galician sailor Francisco de Seyxas y Lovera. These writings were commissioned by the Count of Galve, Viceroy of New Spain, and the Marquis of Los Vélez, President of the Council of Indies, in order to strengthen and protect the naval operation of the Spanish Empire in the Atlantic Ocean and the Caribbean, between 1688 and 1696. Through the analysis of these documents, the author of this chapter demonstrates the importance of maritime knowledge in the writers' trajectories and in the configuration of the imperial project as a whole. Supiot emphasizes the way in which these narratives depart from the binary model center-periphery and the land-locked perspectives that were dominant at the time, by perceiving the *hydro-power* displayed by the metropolis, in which the viceroyalty of New Spain was considered central (and not marginal, as it is usually assumed) to Spain's imperial project. This centrality allowed New Spain, according to Supiot's study, to exercise pressure on Madrid's Court "based on the fundamental oceanic nature of the Empire and the needs and dynamics of such structure." The examination of these materials also proves the importance of sailors' roles and perspectives, a point of view usually overshadowed by the priority granted to land-based agents of the Crown. Maritime knowledge is utilized in these narratives not only to consolidate individual positions within the power system of imperial domination but also to show the influence of the oceanic experience in the configuration of transoceanic networks. Supiot makes reference to the impact of maritime voyages on the types of communications utilized at the time, as well as on the definition of interests and alliances, both at individual and at institutional levels. "In sum, a corpus of works previously isolated by a land-lock gaze emerges as a collection of naval authority that reshapes our understanding of Spain as an oceanic empire."

Clayton McCarl's contribution to this volume deals with nautical texts, following Jimena Rodríguez's suggestion that these types of writings deserve much more attention than what they have received until now. According to both Rodríguez and McCarl, in addition to the technicalities contained in these writings, the reader discovers that they also hold a great

deal of narrative and historical appeal. McCarl's methodology approaches these materials as interrelated combinations of discursive compositions and data. His proposal constitutes an attempt to outline a model of analysis that could be applied to the study of individual texts as well as to collections of data that share similar features. In the chapter included in this book, and based on previous articles McCarl wrote on this topic, he suggests that "maritime texts are one such type or writing as they can be conceptualized both as sequential narratives built on place and time, and repositories of discrete facts about place and time that can be extracted and manipulated independently." In this study, the critic identifies units of meaning and categories that would allow the researcher to deal with vast bodies of writings as well as with individual texts, and to establish cross-textual relationships. At the same time, such relations could allow for visualizations of nautical space thus complementing the progressive dimension of writing, showing patterns in descriptive or narrative accounts, and inspiring interrogations on real and imagined geographies. According to McCarl, "such tools might allow us to better understand processes of exploration and conquest, arguing that while maritime texts are often linear accounts of journeys, their meaning is often not to be found in the lines they draw across maps, but in the circular, repetitive, overlapping ways they connect and return upon themselves."

In a different take on the connections between land and water, nature and power, Ivonne del Valle's study, titled "Pantitlán or *Desagüe*: Technology and Secularizaton in Colonial Mexico City," analyzes the different approaches Mexicas and Spaniards utilized to control and administer water in the flooded region of Pantitlán. While indigenous methods consisted of a combination of technological, political, and religious approaches oriented toward the contention of water levels, Spaniards would opt for systematic drainage, thus antagonizing indigenous populations whose survival depended on the natural characteristics of the region. The relationship between nature and humanity was understood very differently by each civilization, since water and natural environments had in both cases incompatible material and symbolic meanings. At the same time, as Del Valle demonstrates, technological modification of the environment was, as it always is, a political decision, also related to matters of interest and belief. In this manner, the dealings of conquerors and conquered peoples with water (its blessings, its excess, its mythical significance) defined, in many ways, the opposing worldviews confronted by colonial domination.

In his contribution to this volume, José F. Buscaglia-Salgado centers his analysis in the figure of Alonso Ramírez, traditionally known as the fictional character in Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora's narrative text, titled *Misfortunes of Alonso Ramírez* (Mexico City, 1690). The story, focused on the adventures and hardships of Alonso, written as an entertaining and informative tale by the prestigious Mexican *letrado*, was considered the product of Sigüenza y Góngora's vivid imagination, perhaps loosely based on real facts modified by fictional elaboration. After two decades of field research, José F Buscaglia-Salgado was able to establish the real existence of the protagonist of Sigüenza's work, and the extraordinary relevance of his story, as the first American known to have circumnavigated the globe. As Buscaglia-Salgado indicates, Alonso Ramírez' outstanding accomplishment also places America at the center of the modern world, showing the importance of oceanic endeavors as the domain of a newfound freedom conquered in spite of the limitations imposed by the colonial system. "As such, this story, that until very recently was not available to readers in the English language, is the first piratical and novelized narrative to document the deep impression made by life on the open seas and beyond the confines of empire on the American ideal of liberty." The sea becomes a symbol of liberty and an invitation to prove individual will against the odds of imperial subjugation, allowing to see the world from a very different vantage point, not subject to the determinations of territoriality.

Finally, Miguel Valerio's critical piece provides an appropriate closing to this book. It deals with the representation of the process of transportation and commodification of Africans across the Atlantic known as the Middle Passage, an instance considered by Rinaldo Walcott the founding and enduring trauma of Western modernity. But, as Valerio indicates, the impact of this trauma is only felt by Afro-descendants, who continue to reimagining the journeys and the torments imposed to the slaves. Based on the novel *Mãe Sereia* (*Mother Mermaid*, 2019) by Afro-Cuban writer Teresa Cárdenas, Valerio offers a reading of this literary work, written from the perspective of the enslaved. The narrative is centered on Yemanjá, the Yoruba *orisha* of the sea, represented as the *Mother Mermaid* in the text. She is the salvific figure that evokes water and movement, and also concentrates the power that belief and imagination could have during the devastating crossing of the ocean. This chapter analyzes the significance that water had for Africans as a conduit of life and knowledge, and the roles these meanings could have played during the oceanic voyage. According to Valerio, with this study he seeks "to take Middle Passage

studies overboard the slave ship, and into the polysemic water that surrounded it 'on all parts,' as Cárdenas puts it."

It is my hope that readers will appreciate and benefit from the diversity of critical approaches presented in this book, and also recognize the common traits that allow for a systemic reading of real or imagined experiences that find in the fluid materiality of waters and in its symbolic depth a connective space of social and cultural significance. If the routes traversed in these chapters lead to a better understanding of coloniality, environmental issues, and collective imaginaries in Latin America from the times of colonization to the present, the objective of this book would have been met.

I would like to express my sincere appreciation to the authors of these essays for their intellectual generosity, patience, spirit of collaboration, and professionalism during the preparation of this volume. These studies would have not been possible without the excellent interdisciplinary scholarship that precedes them, so we are all indebted to the colleagues who have worked on these topics before us. Also, my gratitude to the readers of the manuscript for their qualified suggestions for improvement, and to Palgrave Macmillan for including this title in the series devoted to maritime studies.

Notes

1. Hofmeyr also refers to the notion of water as "'an informed material' implicated in hydronationalism, struggles around citizenship, settler hydrologies, and hydrocosmologies" (*Dockside Rreading16*), concepts that could be used to analyze particular instances of national histories in countries like Mexico, Bolivia, the Caribbean nations and so on.
2. As indicated by Hofmeyr, "there is now an exciting repertoire of scholarship exploring these themes: critical oceanic studies, coastal and hydrocritical approaches, elemental and atmospheric methods" (17).
3. On the cultural history of oceans see Mack.
4. In this respect see Hulme.
5. Hofmeyr indicates that "Geographers and anthropologists have thickened understandings of water as an 'informed material' implicated in hydronationalism, struggles around citizenship, settler hydrologies, and hydrocosmologies" (*Dockside Reading* 16).
6. On the Atlantic Ocean and its role in World War II cfr. Faulkner y Patalano.
7. On disciplinary knowledge in the context analyzed in this pages, see Carter.
8. Steinberg indicates, after Massey, *For Space*, that "the space and time of the sea are inseparable from each other, as its space is continually constituted

through dynamic reformations in time, and vice versa" ("Of Other Seas" 165 n4).

9. In this respect, in addition to Poppenhagen and Temmen see Wilson. It is worth noting that this line of inquiry follows a more historical and political direction than the one present, most of the time, in hydrocriticism. However, Atlantic and Pacific studies share the interest in analyzing oceanic discourses (Poppenhagen and Temmen 152).
10. Such a perspective connects in many ways with the "mobility turn," a perspective that emerged in the field of the social sciences in the 1990s in order to incorporate critical and theoretical models for the interpretation of social movement, migration, tourism, transportation, voyages and so on, which were particularly prominent at the end of the century. However, this line of inquiry is mostly referred to territorial displacements. According to Cresswell, mobility lies "at the center of constellations of power, the creation of identities, and the micro-geographies of everyday life" (551). See also, for a sociological perspective on mobility, Sheller and Urry. For a more diversified critical approach, see Warf and Arias.
11. "We argue that the ocean is an ideal spatial foundation for addressing these challenges since it is indisputably voluminous, stubbornly material, and unmistakably undergoing continual re-formation, and that a 'wet ontology' can reinvigorate, redirect, and reshape debates that are all too often restricted by terrestrial limits" (Steinberg and Peters, "Wet ontologies" 247).
12. On Schmitt see Connery.
13. According to Perera, "In Western imaginaries from Homer to Conrad, the sea is overwhelmingly the domain of masculine endeavor [...] In foundational colonial narratives such as *Robinson Crusoe*, the ocean signifies as a borderless domain wherein the castaway and the sailor, as white heroic, masculinized figures, exemplify and assert the moral attributes of imperial racial virtue, to end by making for themselves new homes and new worlds, at the end of their voyaging (60).
14. As indicated by Allan Sekula, contemporary novels reproduce the same model by which "[white] men sacrifice themselves at sea so that [white] women can nurture civilized values, or even revive civilization itself" (Sekula 26–27, Perera 61).
15. Economic, political, and social histories continuously challenge previous perceptions of the land/sea connections. Fernand Braudel's *The Mediterranean World in the Age of Phillip II* (1949) is an indispensable book in the recognition of the importance of oceanic encounters and the consolidation of hegemony. Carl Schmitt *Land and Sea. A World Historical Meditation* (1954) is a key work for the exploration of Eurocentrism and ideological interpretations of this matter in the context of World War II

politics, and beyond. Paul Gilroy's highly influential *Black Atlantic. Modernity and Double Consciousness* (1993) constitutes a groundbreaking analysis of the crucial significance of the Atlantic Ocean in the consolidation of modern designs of the world, at economic, political, and cultural levels. He emphasizes the centrality of slavery, race, and diasporic movements in the modern world, and the cultural hybridization that takes place through oceanic journeys that facilitate human, material, and symbolic exchanges.

16. For Pugliese, the term "geocorpography" "bring[s] into focus the violent enmeshment of the flesh and blood of the body within the geopolitics of race, war and empire" (Pugliese 1, Perera 60).
17. The social and religious meanings of water in the pre-Hispanic world have been analyzed by historians and anthropologists alike. In the Inca Empire, aside from its inclusion in rituals related to the celebration of life, the sustenance of agriculture and the human life in general, water was also crucial in death rituals, offerings, and oblations, thus becoming a key element in community celebrations and social organization. The management of water was also one of the constant architectural challenges (particularly the design and building of terraces, aqueducts, bridges, reservoirs, etc.) As indicated by Bray, the management of water greatly contributed to define power relations and social identity among the Incas. In the case of the Aztecs, "As is well-known, the hills were the containers of water, shrines were also located at springs and other water features, and the control of weather and agriculture was crucial to [this] culture" (Umberger 110). The same is true in Maya societies, where hydraulic methods and the management of rain, flows, evaporation, drainage, and the like, speak eloquently about the awareness of the importance and communal relevance of water and the ability to gather it, redirect it, storage it, and utilize it wisely (Ertsen and Wouters). On these topics see Lucero and Fash.
18. "In the daytime, weather permitting, slaves were brought on deck for exercise or for "dancing" (forced jumping up and down). At this time, some captains insisted that the sleeping quarters be scraped and swabbed by the crew. In bad weather the oppressive heat and noxious fumes in the unventilated and unsanitary holds caused fevers and dysentery, with a high mortality rate. Deaths during the Middle Passage, caused by epidemics, suicide, "fixed melancholy," or mutiny, have been estimated at 13 percent. So many bodies of dead or dying Africans were jettisoned into the ocean that sharks regularly followed the slave ships on their westward journey. The Middle Passage supplied the New World with its major workforce and brought enormous profits to international slave traders. At the same time, it exacted a terrible price in physical and emotional anguish on the part of

the uprooted Africans; it was distinguished by the callousness to human suffering it developed among the traders" (*The Encyclopedia Britannica*).

19. On these topics see Moraña, *Liquid Borders. Migration as Resistance*.
20. With respect to the Pacific Ocean, see the important collection of articles edited by Christina H. Lee and Ricardo Padron, where contributors analyze the encounters and intermixing that took place in the region in Early Modern times between Europeans, Spanish Americans, and Asians, and the role of ethnicity and gender in social and cultural dynamics. On the history of the Atlantic Ocean see Bailyn, and Cañizares-Esguerra and Seeman. For an ample study on oceanic history see Rozwadowski and for an elaborated analysis of maritime social and political significance, cfr. Phillip Steinberg, *The Social Construction of the Ocean*.

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CHAPTER 2

The Pacific Ocean as a Space of Freedom, Danger, and Economic Success for the Colonial Project in *Verdadera descripción de la Provincia y Tierra de Las Esmeraldas*

Catalina Andrango-Walker

Several images depicting Columbus' voyage to the Americas are inextricably linked to the ocean. The most famous of these comes from a set of detailed copperplate engravings found in the sixteenth-century book, *Americae,* from Theodor de Bry's *Grandes Voyages* series, a collection which, according to historian John Elliot, gave many Europeans their first visual representations of the New World for at least 200 years (*America* 7). One of the most iconic images presents Columbus standing alone, facing the unfamiliar, and looking upon the turbulent and unpredictable sea, full of strange and mythological creatures, some monstrous, some half-human and half-animal. In one hand he holds an emblem with the image of Christ

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on the cross, and in the other he carries a sword. At one of the corners of the ship there is a display of the Catholic Monarchs' banner of arms. As he gazes calmly at the waters, the symbols he holds stand out as representations of the major principles of expansion: empire, religion, and masculinity, as if they were in and of themselves sufficient to protect him from any danger (*America* 161). Images such as these repeatedly represent Europeans crossing the ocean, and later, their encounters with the inhabitants of the New World. At the same time, however, depictions of the sea, whether prominently or in the background, reveal the extent to which audiences at home were anxious to live the adventures of these sailors through the narratives and images that provided them with glimpses of the new lands that would forever change the world.[1] These images portray the maritime world as "a frontier of capitalism and colonial expansion" (Cohen 657).

Yet, in spite of the importance of cross-ocean travel that changed the history of the world in Early Modern times, and the transcendental role of seas as routes that made possible the transit of people, economic goods, and knowledge within imperial projects, Early Modern discourse turned away from the oceans, and water in general, to favor land as the site of European imperial triumph and desire for expansion. In 2010, Margaret Cohen, reflecting on the disregard for the maritime world, suggested the term "hydrophasia," as a way to define this "forgetting of the sea" in Western discourse (658).[2] Cohen signals how scholars, and especially literary critics, have facilitated this suppression and seem to have only recently taken up studies that focus on the sea, specifically, and water in general. The scarcity of studies from the last century focusing on the sea, especially in the Humanities, contrasts with the many scientific investigations from scholars in the fields of "oceanography, geophysics, and evolutionary and marine biology." The effect of the knowledge that these scientists have acquired, as noted by Laura Winkiel, has served "to posit the sea as a material actant in a posthumanist world." In other words, with this statement she is establishing a close relationship between human beings and the seas, from which humans are not separated but grow together as part of a coevolution (1).

If the sea has been largely ignored, the attention paid to other smaller bodies of water that have also played an important role for imperial purposes has suffered a similar fate. Scholars of hydrocolonialism, an emerging critical and theoretical approach, have expanded this field of studies to make "visible relations of power that have been shaped around water and

its colonial appropriations" (Hofmeyr 13). Although Isabel Hofmeyer's study focuses on the ocean, she acknowledges the increasing number of literary scholars who are using hydrocolonial criticism and methodology "to comprehend the oceans and water more generally from a nonhuman perspective" (14). This tradition of thought "has produced a rich array of ideas, like amphibious aesthetics, littoral form, monsoon assemblages, heavy waters, hydropoetics, submarine aesthetics, transcorporeality, and sea ontologies—all concepts that push us closer to a material engagement with water" (14). This approach calls for the inclusion of rivers, lakes, bays, islands, and other aspects of the maritime world into imperial analysis, which becomes necessary since these smaller bodies of water were also part of the relationship of dominance and power that shaped Early Modern literature and culture.

A great example of the consideration of other bodies of water can be found in the work of Yolanda Martínez-San Miguel. In her study of the Caribbean archipelago, which she defines as a "groups of islands, with their corresponding networks of ports, fortifications, plantation systems and cities, as well as with their social, cultural and production systems" (23),[3] she conceptualizes the archipelago not from the vantage point of its insularity; rather, she incorporates the archipelago into the Caribbean continental zones, "in a multi-focal context, where islands alternate with connected coastal regions" (23). Martínez-San Miguel's approach to what she identifies as the atypical relationships that the colonial archipelago maintains with sovereignty and nationalism—its islands are the legacy of an unusual status as overseas imperial possessions (25)—is consistent with the scholarship that reveals the need to include the maritime world into "the imaginary geographies found in literature" (Cohen 658). In addition, Cohen mentions the influence that realist novels play in the creation of an image of the desired European nations as "imagined communities" (the term coined by Benedict Anderson). Similarly, hydropoetics and hydronarratives that "chart far-flung regions of the world" (658) would also have the potential to contribute to the debate of imperial domination and the construction of subjectivities during the Early Modern period.

Although scholars of hydrocolonial studies have prominently looked at the Mediterranean Sea, the Indian and Atlantic Oceans, and particularly at the Northern Atlantic circuit between England and North America, there are, in fact, fewer investigations dedicated to the Pacific Ocean, which is a body of water that connects Asia, Australia, and the Americas, and extends to over a third of the world's surface.[4] Alice Te Punga Somerville reflects

on the other names used for the Pacific Ocean, especially "el Mar del Sur," which is the name Vasco Núñez de Balboa coined upon glimpsing it for the first time from atop a summit on the Isthmus of Panama in 1513 and claiming its waters for the Spanish empire.[5] This act of imagination, as Somerville refers to Núñez de Balboa's characterization of the ocean, has had enduring consequences, because "[c]alling this new place South put[s] it in inextricable and oppositional relationship with the North" (25). As a result, "Pacific literary studies continues to be 'South' to the Atlantic's 'North,' à la Balboa" (27). Furthermore, because of this Eurocentric relational perspective, "in which the region itself is made to be an empty signifier of whatever is on its margins, the Pacific is emptied even of the specific language to which it is connected" (29). Somerville is referring to the contemporary uses of the term "Pacific" and in particular the term "Trans-Pacific," which "is widely used as a shorthand for the Americas, Australasia, and Asia; and much has been written about what 'Pacific' means in Australia's notion of the Asia/Pacific and the United States' demographic category of 'Asian Pacific Islander'" (29). Furthermore, Epeli Hau'ofa, in his investigations about Oceania, reminds us about the vast "difference between viewing the Pacific as 'islands in a far sea' and as 'a sea of islands'" (7); both of which are characterizations that help to explain the boundaries created by European and American men to "define the island states and territories of the Pacific." Hau'ofa instead uses the term "ocean peoples" "because our ancestors, who had lived in the Pacific for over 2000 years, viewed their world as a 'sea of islands', rather than 'islands in the sea'" (7). This explanation is key to understanding Oceania not from the vantage point of national governments and international diplomacy, but from the viewpoint of its ignored and belittled indigenous cultures (2–3).

While scholars have paid more attention to certain areas along the Pacific Rim, other regions have been neglected. For example, one particularly important area that is missing in Pacific studies is South America. In spite of the importance of the ocean to the history of this region, with few exceptions it has regrettably remained in the background. Most of the extant scholarship on the Pacific Ocean traces its emergence "in European consciousness, either as a geography emerging from empirical exploration or, more recently, as an object invented out of the complex interplay of the data of experience with culturally contingent expectations" (Padrón 2). While the majority of studies have centered on cartography and economics, it is important to study the Pacific Ocean as more than "a merely

instrumental adjunct—a source of food, a passage for trade and foreign conquest, a site of intercultural transport" (Chambers 679). Rather, this intercultural transport included not only European travelers but also slave ships that formed a network between Africa, Europe, and the Americas.

Chamber proposes that "[t]he centrality of sea to modernity promotes the adoption of a more fluid cartography in which the stability of the historical archive, together with the stability of its associated facts, territorial museums, and nationalist interpretations, is set afloat: susceptible to drift, unplanned contacts, even shipwreck. Histories and cultures are held in an indeterminate suspension in the sea, connected, rather than divided, by water" (681). As suggested by Chambers and also by Somerville, studies of the Pacific Ocean will benefit if scholars consider its history and role in the expansion of imperialism, rather than treat it only as an accessory to the general aims of the conquest. This requires a conceptual approach to the ocean not simply as a medium that facilitates transport, but more importantly, as a place that people have called home for centuries. Concurring with Hofmeyr's definition of hydrocolonialism, a study of the Pacific Ocean coming from this theoretical approach contributes to the understanding of both "colonization **by** way of water (various forms of maritime imperialism) [and] colonization **of** water (occupation of land with water resources)" (Hofmeyr 13, my emphasis). To explore these issues, this article focuses on a case in which the Pacific Ocean and other bodies of water within the territory of present-day Ecuador are the main protagonists, as a route to colonize other bodies of water and as the sites of colonization themselves.

In 1577, Spanish cleric Miguel Cabello Balboa (1535?–1606?) departed from Quito to the province of Esmeraldas (located in present-day Ecuador, which at that time was part of the viceroyalty of Peru) as a member of a missionary expedition that consisted of military and religious men.[6] Their task was to find a direct and more secure route from Quito to the Pacific Ocean (known at that time as Mar del Sur), in order to get to Panama without having to go through Guayaquil, which in time would become a more profitable way for the Spaniards to export goods and commodities.[7] Years later, Cabello Balboa authored *Verdadera descripción de la provincia y tierra de las Esmeraldas* (1583), in which he narrates details about this endeavor and the several obstacles that he and his companions had faced. The Esmeraldas province had been populated not only by a variety of indigenous tribes but also by a diverse group of Africans who, on at least two occasions having leapt from beached or foundered slaving ships, over

time had made Esmeraldas their home. Moreover, in the accounts of his search for the ocean, Cabello Balboa describes his travel along the rivers that were important to the indigenous local population not only as sources of food and communication but also as the principal sites for their religious and cultural rituals. In this way, *Verdadera descripción* illustrates how this mixed-race population of Esmeraldas province interacted with water. While black communities' lives were more centered around the ocean as a locus of freedom and, at the same time, foreign incursions, native populations and their ancestors relate to the region's rivers as a way to maintain their rituals and traditions. Furthermore, Cabello Balboa's expedition faced another challenge: the arrival of English pirate Francis Drake to the coast of El Callao, which was the most important port in the viceroyalty of Peru. In this way the study of imperial domination of water reveals the different levels of colonial control. In this essay I consider the far-reaching implication of hydrocolonialism, from not only the standpoint of imperial expansion and the advancement of geographical knowledge but also its role in maintaining racialized ideologies. I study the Pacific Ocean and other sources of water, focusing peripherally on the material richness, but more centrally on the relationship that Esmeraldas' inhabitants had established with the maritime world. For them the ocean and the rivers were home, passages, spaces of freedom and redemption, routes of danger and contamination, but most importantly, loci of power.

Searching for a Route to the Pacific Ocean: A Political Mission in the Trappings of Evangelization

Brian Lavery reminds us that, "[i]n the golden age of sail from the 16th to the 19th century, ocean-going sailing ships were central to world trade, empire building, and warfare, yet they remained entirely at the mercy of the currents and above all the winds" (10). Lavery's portrayal of the "conquest of the ocean" shows all the aspects and possibilities that characterized the colonization of distant shores. A study of the process of empire building and the expansion of knowledge around the world from the perspective of hydrocolonialism reveals the impact of foreign incursions into the sea. Isabel Hofmeyr reflects on the origin of the term hydrocolonialism and two of its most closely related uses, hydrocolonial and hydrocolonic. For the critic, both terms "capture metaphorically the waste-making systems of colonial rule, where certain people were rendered as waste,

whether through the slave trade, indenture, or penal transportation. Imperial border regimes fed off these imaginaries of waste as contamination, constituting themselves as quarantine ramparts against disease and 'undesirable aliens'" (13).[8] This is the status of the Pacific Ocean in the sixteenth century, which became a contentious and complex space of foreign incursion during an era of imperial expansion. First, the arrival of Europeans, mainly Spaniards, disrupted the natives' lives, but soon after, it was the venue through which to expand the slave trade by introducing people who, though deemed to be inferior, were at the same time essential for the continuing prosperity of the viceroyalty and thus the economy of the Spanish empire. Moreover, in this time of exploration, it was possible to prove that nothing separated one ocean from another thanks to the expeditions that circumnavigated the world. The arrival of Francis Drake to the shores of the viceroyalty of Peru shows how the Pacific Ocean also introduced the fear of religious contamination in the context of imperial rivalry. *Verdadera descripción* allows the reader to see not only the greed of the conquistadors in their goal to open a new and direct route to transport goods through the Pacific Ocean. The narrative also uncovers the stories of slavery and freedom, helping us to reimagine the importance of the sea as the viceroyalty became part of global circulation.

In 1553, just two decades after the Spaniards arrived at the Andean region, a ship coming from Panama with merchandise and a group of slaves destined to arrive in Lima was forced to stop along the coast of Esmeraldas province because of intense winds and high tides. After more than 30 days of confinement the marines decided to explore the shores to find some comfort and look for food. They took with them 23 slaves, 17 men and 6 women, to assist them in their search for the much-needed provisions. Within a short period of time a strong storm destroyed the ship, and amid the confusion the slaves found the opportunity to free themselves, running to an elevated area densely populated with vegetation (*Verdadera relación* 50). While the few remaining white sailors soon perished because of the hostile conditions, the former slaves flourished in their newly adopted home.[9] In Esmeraldas, they established their power among the native populations and most of all established a close relationship with the ocean, which became much more than a passage to freedom. In fact, water helped them consolidate different forms of political power even with viceregal authority because, taking advantage of their knowledge of the sea, the former slaves tried to find political legitimization by projecting the image of good Christian people.

Since the sea was a dangerous place, as the former slaves had already experienced, they capitalized on their own survival skills to help others escape shipwrecks. Cabello Balboa relates that Alonso de Illescas, the powerful chief of the aforementioned group that escaped to Esmeraldas, took control of the region by establishing his power among the natives, who he intimidated through repeated acts of violence. Illescas, of African ancestry, was born into a Spanish household in Cabo Verde and later was raised in Seville, was well aware of Spanish culture and traditions.[10] Therefore, he tried to portray himself as a charitable man to the authorities of the viceroyalty by being attentive to maritime traffic and disaster. On several occasions, when he and his people spotted a ship in trouble because of bad weather, or noticed Spaniard travelers that were lost at sea (both of which were rather common occurrences at that time), they set out to rescue the castaways. In this manner, they projected a friendly, and most of all, good Christian representation of themselves, while at the same time, trying to erase Illescas' fame as a cruel tyrannical leader.

Hester Blum states that "[a]s oceanic studies reveals, freedom from national belonging can make possible other ways of understanding affiliation, citizenship, mobility, rights, and sovereignty, all of which have been read in recent critical history as over determined by nationalism" (671). The association that the former slaves established with the ocean allowed them to see themselves as individuals dictating the terms of engagement with hegemonic Spanish power. As they did not want to fall back into slavery, they were also aware of the proximity of Spanish rule since the Esmeraldas province belonged to the viceroyalty of Peru. The sea then represents this space in between, a space of belonging and not belonging; in fact, Illescas and his people "transformed Christianization into a political tool of subaltern agency" (Beatty-Medina 96). As such, Cabello Balboa recognizes that without Illescas' help many lives would have been lost (57). The cleric exemplifies this affirmation by narrating a particular case that occurred in 1577. On that occasion, a ship that had departed from Panama with 13 passengers, among them men, women, and children, was destroyed by strong winds and tides. The captain, who did not have enough knowledge of the region, evidently had miscalculated the distance to a safe port. Leaving two almost empty-handed couples and their children behind, nine men undertook a long journey on foot to Portoviejo, in order to find Spanish authorities and help. Seven of the nine men died along the way. Meanwhile, Illescas had found the castaways and provided them with food and other essentials to survive for the 40 days they stayed

along the coast of Esmeraldas. Illescas and his people also provided a canoe to the desperate travelers so that they could navigate to the closest major port that was governed by Spaniards; their assistance also included advice regarding the best routes by which to safely traverse the Pacific's waters (57–58).

The strategy of treating misfortunate travelers with care and compassion paid many dividends, because after one of the couples had arrived safely in Quito, they told their story to the authorities, insisting on the pious and devote Christian nature of the former slaves. Consequently, the bishop decided to pardon Illescas and his people. Although Spaniards, such as Cabello Balboa, were well aware of Illescas' treachery, they also needed to establish alliances with the former slaves in order to succeed in their imperial projects. In fact, one of his tasks on this mission was to name Illescas governor of the region, following the orders of the bishop of Quito, under the condition that he and his people relocate their hidden settlement to the coast, where the Spanish authorities wanted to establish the town of San Mateo de Esmeraldas (67).[11] The distrust that Cabello Balboa showed toward the African people was mutual, because they did not accept the Spaniards' conditions, thereby putting an end to the authorities' desire to consolidate their power in the region.[12] Illescas' appointment, however, indicates that Spanish officials not only recognized him as the leader of the region, but also, they were well aware of his indisputable knowledge of the sea, which was yet another sign that he and his people had perfectly adapted to the region. This stands in direct contrast to the limited abilities of most Spaniards travelers, who lacked the expertise to survive on the sea and in the region in general. This vulnerability was put to the test on several occasions by the way in which many different individuals would use the ocean to gain a strategic imperial advantage.

Danger of Contamination

If the ocean had become a source of political power as well as a space that provided a change of status from slavery to freedom for the African men and women who had escaped the shipwreck, for European missionaries the discovery of a land route to the Pacific meant the economic success of imperial expansion. However, although Cabello Balboa tried to center his narrative exclusively on the Esmeraldas region, he had to divert his attention to larger problems that affected the viceroyalty of Peru amidst a very conflictive political and commercially imperial competition during a

frantic time of exploration. In this way, *Verdadera descripción* offers the opportunity to appreciate different levels of hydroimperialism through its inclusion of a brief account of the incursion of Spain's foreign enemies into the Pacific coast of South America. Cabello Balboa clarifies all of these problems while explaining the importance of his mission:

> The benefits that the pacification of this province brings are so many and such, that the least of them would be enough to pick the interest of any heroic heart, because in addition to the delight [of expansion], we must fear, as your lordship have already noted, that if the English enemy, Lutheran, were to arrive there and mingle with that Black man [Illescas] and the mulatto populations who reside there, they could stir the sea and the land of Peru and that territory would shelter and would become a den of thieves and bad Christians.[13] (34)

Sara Pritchard explains that the term hydroimperialism conveys "the ways that water, hydraulic knowledge, and water management practices both revealed and reproduced unequal power relations predicated upon an expansionist *mentalité*, whether political or economic in orientation" (592). I also suggest that the concept of hydroimperialism can be expanded to study the conflict among various political powers for the control of water within a colonial setting. Thus, when Cabello Balboa describes his political objective—covered as it may be in the trappings of evangelization—he is well aware of the danger that comes from a sea that would prompt Spaniards to defend their possessions in the New World.

After crossing the Strait of Magellan, having taken the same route as Jhoan Sebastián del Cano, in 1579 English pirate Francis Drake passed by the coasts of El Callao and Paita (104). The "Dragon of the Sea," as Drake would later be known, had already "caused terror and admiration in the coast of Chile" (104), by the time he had touched upon Isla Mocha and Valparaiso. Later, he continued to the port of Callao, the main port of the viceroyalty of Peru. He never attacked Lima, but continued directly to Panama (104). In fact, except for a port in Chile, Drake never disembarked at any other port of the Peruvian viceroyalty. Nevertheless, his mere presence near Spanish dominions caused a general panic among its population. In *Verdadera descripción*, Cabello Balboa dedicates his brief last chapter to the details of this unexpected event, describing the Lutheran English corsair as "reckless monster" (104).[14] Thus, in his characterization of Drake, Cabello Balboa affirms his own identity, setting up the English

enemy, the bad Christian, as the opposite of the good values and heroic hearts that the Spaniards represented.

In this way, as Paul Firbas observes, Drake's arrival not only stopped Cabello Balboa's expedition, but it also inserted the Antarctic world into Peruvian viceregal politics and in the author's cosmographic imagination (79). Drake's arrival along the coasts of Peru confirmed that "[t]here is no moment when one passes from the Atlantic to the India Ocean, or from the Indian Ocean to the Pacific. The ocean is a great unity" (Lavery 8). Rather, for Cabello Balboa, Drake's presence affirmed the necessity of establishing a relationship with Esmeraldas' inhabitants. The author's strategies to convince the authorities about the importance and urgency of his mission are the same that explorers since Columbus had been using to justify their adventures. First, he invokes patriotism, because the domination of all bodies of water would ensure Spain's prosperity; and second, the expansion of Christianity, in this case, endangered by the threat of Protestant pirates, who had the potential to contaminate the inhabitants with their religion. In addition, they could form alliances with them, and in this way harm the viceroyalty and the empire's economy.[15] Finally, these reasons are inextricably tied to each other through economic motivations as he points out the richness of the region in order to convince the viceregal authorities of its value. Besides offering a faster way to get to Panama, the region had gold, emeralds, and suitable timber with which to build ships (34).

Among the other advantages that this land offered, Cabello Balboa writes a detailed narrative about the rivers that they had to navigate to get to their destination. This account allows the reader to understand the connection that the indigenous communities had previously had with the ocean, having been displaced from the same by Illescas and his people. Consequently, now forced to occupy the highlands, the natives' contact with bodies of water was limited to the rivers of that region. This fact allows the author to highlight the heterogeneous populations that inhabited the region and the different relationships that each group had with maritime world.

Mystical Waters: Cabello Balboa's Encounter with Native Communities

> En la distancia que hay de la Playa y orilla del mar hasta la gran Cordillera habitan y viven muchas bárbaras naciones, cuyos nombres, de la mayor parte de ellas, son inotos por no estar visto y conquistados. Fue

> esta provincia, la primera tierra que se descubrió debajo de nombre de Piru.
> (*Verdadera descripción* 35–36)

Referring to travel writing, Joan-Pau Rubiés states that "[t]he description of peoples, their nature, customs, religion, forms of government and language, is so embedded in the massive amounts of travel literature produced in Europe after the sixteenth century that one is led to assume that ethnography is, almost inevitably, an essential part of the genre" (242). This statement applies perfectly to Cabello Balboa's narrative as well. However, the author's attempt to write about natural and moral history is insufficient with respect to the latter because in his description of the native inhabitants of the region, he only briefly mentions the heterogeneity of these indigenous groups, each one with different languages, traditions, ritual ceremonies, and even origin stories. More prominent is his emphasis on natural history, given that he carefully details several aspects related to the richness of the area. In light of the fact that travelers had to make a large portion of their journey by water, Cabello Balboa pays special consideration to the hydrographic aspects of his voyage. The author's strong desire to continue his mission is visible in the strategies that he uses, in which he recurs rather frequently to a discourse of abundance in order to convince the viceregal authorities of the economic value of the region, so that they will continue to support his endeavors.

When describing the location of the Esmeraldas province, Cabello Balboa states that it is surrounded by a bay and several rivers. According to the author, the province took its name from the abundance of fine emeralds, which are similar to the ones in Alexandria or Ethiopia, which are also located between two rivers (36). After depicting the province's geographic position, in a chapter dedicated specifically to the region's hydrographic diversity, the author states that:

> The first river that we describe, leaving others of lesser importance, is the Juani, this river is born in the Province of the Timbas' tribe, fierce, indomitable people and badly subject to the city of Cali […] Joined at this river, a branch, further inland, which rises from the mountain of the Paripasos and Cacachames people […] without other branches that make it bigger and powerful. It brings great quantities of gold that it steals from the lands through which it passes. (39)

In addition to emphasizing the abundance of precious stones and gold, the author also pays attention to the rivers' navigability and the other resources it offers, such as its great variety and abundance of fish. Moreover, he asserts that along the banks of these rivers there is plenty of excellent wood with which to build boats. The detailed discourse regarding the natural resources of the region are in clear contrast to the descriptions of its inhabitants, which most of the time are described as either peaceful or violent, such as in the case of the Timbas tribe, cited above, whom the author describes as a fierce and indomitable people.

Cabello Balboa is also able to associate the multiple rivers of the region with the native populations whose lives depend on them for food, transportation, and even for their religious and cultural rituals. So relevant is this human-hydrography relationship that on multiple occasions the author does not even mention the name of the tribe. Rather, he either provides geographical locations based upon their proximity to a particular body of water, or on a few occasions describes some of their rituals. Nevertheless, regardless of their origins he states that most of the groups are in agreement that their ancestors had come to coastal areas from colder highlands in search of salt. In order to avoid the long and difficult journey from the mountains to the coast, at some point they had finally decided to establish themselves near the ocean. Since then, these groups maintained a close relationship with water, especially with regional rivers. Cabello Balboa narrates a masculinity ritual that was a tradition of one of the tribes settled between the San Jhoan and Pati rivers. He describes that these inhabitants "have sanctuaries and secret worship places where they offer gold and collars made out of *spondylus* shells to their deities,[16] the sun and the moon, as well as to their late ancestors. Detailing these traditions, the author observes that, "[w]hen a baby boy is born, they take him to the river in the morning, before dawn, and they immerse the baby in the water until the sun starts rising. Their belief is that the water would make the newborn a strong man" (46). These types of stories show how the ocean, bays, and rivers of that region are closely associated with native populations to the point that they were even an important part of their origin legends and community rituals. Even though the author only very briefly mentions these rituals, they are nevertheless a recognition that those bodies of waters were not simple empty place-holders for uncharted spaces; rather, they were dynamic indigenous-centered spaces. Thus, this relationship and attachment to water was a key element the natives used to protect their waters from foreign invaders.

In spite of the centrality of the rivers and the sea in the lives of the indigenous inhabitants of the Esmeraldas Province, unfortunately, the ocean had also become a source of danger, mainly in the form of foreign incursions that oftentimes led to land invasion, dispossession, and violence. The disruption that the arrival of Cabello Balboa's mission provoked in the indigenous communities is apparent in the way in which the author describes these encounters. Hofmeyr points out that, "[t]he colonial condition is always nervous, both for the 'native' and the settler […] This condition was particularly acute on the hydroborder, where the 'normal' anxieties of the boundary were exacerbated by ecological uncertainty, health hazards of ships arriving in port, and paranoia about 'undesirable aliens' arriving by sea" (17).[17] For the natives, this anxiety manifested itself in the tactics they used to deceive the intruders regarding the best way to arrive to the ocean. Cabello Balboa asserts that when passing by different towns, each chieftain gave them a variety of confusing information. For example, they would warn them about the extremely long distance to the ocean as well as about the multiple dangers they would face along the way, starting with the great turbulence of the rivers, which they would have to navigate over the course of 12 to 15 days. They also warned them about the dangerous mountain roads and the thick, deep swamps through which the expedition would have had to traverse (88).[18]

The Spaniards took these warnings with distrust; as the author recognizes, they were well aware that taking Spaniards through difficult and long routes was a frequent tactic the natives used when they did not want to show foreigners their lands and waters. To this end, when the native guides gestured toward the river that would take them to the sea, the travelers would show the guides a nautical needle, warning them that this instrument would know when they had been given a wrong direction (88–89). In fact, all the warnings about the dangerous waters and mountainous roads did not deter the travelers, who, as soon as they started their journey, encountered several wide and easily navigable rivers. Moreover, they were even able to build canoes to continue their trip due to the great variety of trees they found along the way. The author describes these rivers in great detail, mentioning the calm waters and perfect breeze with such frequency that he affirms that it was not even necessary to continue rowing in order to advance down some of the rivers they encountered. His delight is all the more evident in his descriptions of the dense groves of trees that were easily visible from the water. Cabello Balboa determines

that all these facts serve as reasons to convince the authorities about the viability of opening a route from Quito to the ocean.

Furthermore, the "nervous condition" of cultural encounters affected the settlers as well. In addition to the episode about the nautical needle with which Cabello Balboa would trick the natives, he dedicates many narratives to the multiple occasions on which he sensed the danger of the unknown. For instance, the author recalls his fear every time he and his companions had to wait along the river bank until they could see Illescas' boat navigating the waters with ease. This image of the Spaniards observing from land the arrival of the imposing figure of the former slave presents a contrast with their own vulnerable circumstances, since they depended on the natives for food, guidance, help building canoes, and information about the particularities of the rivers and the region in general. This vulnerability is even more graphic when the author describes the final time they had to wait for Illescas to appear. The missionaries had no food; they were tired and were afraid of being attacked by the natives or the ex-slaves themselves. Sitting along the banks of a river while contemplating the water, one of them started to sing Psalm 137, which is also known as *Super Flumina Babylonis*. This psalm tells the story of Jewish slaves who are remembering Jerusalem, their distant homeland, as they sit along the rivers of Babylon. Cabello Balboa draws a parallel between the Babylonians and the natives as a way to highlight the idolatry and lust in which the latter lived. On the other hand, the image of the Spanish travelers sitting along the banks of a river in Esmeraldas Province, fearing for their lives, perfectly captures the vulnerability of the missionaries. After all, *Verdadera descripción* is a story of failure: a failure to dominate the native populations, a failure to reach an agreement with Illescas and his people, and most of all, a failure to dominate water and to reach the ocean, as they had originally planned.

Elizabeth Deloughrey echoes scholars' call for a "critical ocean studies," which would include hydrocolonial criticism in general, for the twenty-first century that gives more relevance to forgotten and fathomed aspects, among them indigenous epistemologies. Deloughrey welcomes this move "after decades of scholarship that positioned the ocean as an anthropocentric and colonial 'aqua nullius,' or a blank space across which a diasporic masculinity might be forged. In this new scholarship, an animated ocean has come into being as "wet matter" rather than inert backdrop" (22). As Cabello Balboa's narrative clearly shows, the area of the Pacific Ocean off the coast of Esmeraldas was never a blank space.

Noticeably, the native populations and the later arrivals that established themselves in that region had a strong relationship with the ocean and with other bodies of water that surrounded them. *Verdadera descripción* presents a glimpse of what the encounter was like for the natives, although we do not hear their voices directly narrating their own traditions, but instead only rely on Cabello Balboa's problematic ethnographic exercise. *Verdadera descripción* shows the complex dynamics of power, with different kind of mobilities, in which knowing and controlling water allows Illescas and his men to communicate with the viceregal authorities. At the same time, however, the Pacific also symbolized the danger of the penetration of impious forces that posed a threat to Spanish hegemony in the region. Nevertheless, it was with the interracial inhabitants of the Esmeraldas regions that the Spaniards fought, formed alliances, and also negotiated. My study of these transcultural exchanges through the lens of hyrdrocriticism highlights the significance of this maritime space as a site of human trade, political insecurity—as a place open to foreign incursion—and also as a space of colonial failure. In this regard, the Pacific Ocean both facilitated and challenged colonialism by allowing the free flow of both people and capital.

Notes

1. For more information about the importance of illustrations in the dissemination of knowledge about the New World to European audiences, see "The Traveling Illustrations of Sixteenth Century Travel Narratives."
2. Cohen follows photographer and theorist Allan Secula, who coined the phrase "forgetting of the sea" (658).
3. The translation is mine.
4. The most recent advances in the field of early modern Spanish Pacific studies have concentrated in topics such as "the cartographic invention of the Pacific World" (Padrón 2). Also see *The Spanish Pacific, 1521–1815* (2020), edited by Christina Lee and Ricardo Padrón for studies that center on the encounters that developed in the Spanish Pacific among Europeans, Spanish Americans.
5. Other names for the Pacific Ocean are Oceania, and Te Moananui-a-Kiwa (Somerville 28).
6. The details of Cabello Balboa's life are not very extensive. According to Jacinto Jijón y Caamaño, he was born in Archidona (Spain), probably between 1530 and 1535; it is possible that he arrived at the New World in 1566 (*Verdadera descripción* VI).

7. According to Cabello Balboa the direct distance from Quito to Panama was 150 leagues; however, there was not a straight-line route between these two points, and because of this, travelers had to take the only known option at that time which was going to Guayaquil first. However, the voyage was increased to 430 leagues (95).
8. One of the multiple cases that show the Pacific Ocean as a venue of contagion is exemplified in "Discurso de la enfermedad sarampion experimentada en la Ciudad de los Reyes del Peru" written by physician Francisco Bermejo in July 1694. Bermejo writes at the request of the viceroy, who is undecided as to whether to allow passengers, coming in a ship from the coast of Guayaquil to Callao Port, to disembark, knowing that several passengers have been infected with measles (see "Discurso de la enfermedad").
9. Cabello Balboa relates a similar story that occurred a little later about another group of slaves that escaped from a ship that had stop in the coast of Esmeraldas searching of food (52).
10. According to Cabello Balboa, Illescas played guitar and had good sword skills, thus demonstrating how well he had adapted to Spanish culture in the 25 years that he was a slave (73).
11. This appointment gave him authority over the several tribes and former slave groups that inhabited the region while at the same time putting him in charge of peace-keeping among all of the various inhabitants of that area (67).
12. Cabello Balboa narrates that he had met with Illescas two times; although these encounters were successful, Illescas did not show up for a third meeting and the mission failed.
13. All translations are mine.
14. The terror caused by Drake's arrival to the coast of the Peruvian viceroyalty has been the topic of several literary manifestations. See for instance José Antonio Mazzotti's article "The Dragon and the Seashell: British Corsairs, Epic Poetry and Creole Nation in Viceregal Peru" for a discussion of how creole members of Lima's society expressed their perspectives about foreign incursions in the Pacific.
15. The fear of contamination and alliances between the English pirates and the African runaways is based on experience as Drake had years earlier formed alliances with runaway slaves in Panamá. See Kris Lane's *Pillaging the Empire: Global Piracy on the High Seas, 1500–1750*.
16. These collars are called *chaquiras* according to the editors of the annotated edition of *Verdadera relación* (46).
17. Hofmeyr clarifies that the "nervous condition" is a reference to Tstitsi Dangarembga's novel *Nervous Conditions* (1988).
18. Illescas uses a similar approach while trying to get rid of Cabello Balboa and his companions. He swears to him by the Virgin of Guadalupe that there is a river, where when one stirs the sand it turns yellow because of the abundant grains of gold that it contains (74).

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CHAPTER 3

English and Irish Missionaries in New Spain: A Hydrocolonial Reading of Religion and Empire

Stephanie Kirk

Your well-built Ships, companions of the Sunn,
As they were Chariots to his fiery beams,
Which oft the Earths circumference have runn,
And now lie moar'd in Severn, Trent, and Tems,
Shall plough the Ocean with their gilded Stems,
And in their hollow bottoms you convay
To Lands inrich'd with gold, with pearls and gems,
But above all, where many thousands stay
Of wronged Indians, whom you shall set free
From Spanish yoke, and Romes Idolatry.
—Thomas Chaloner, "Upon this Worthy Work of his Most Worthy Friend, the Author"

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This chapter tells the tale of two early modern missionaries who represent a small but significant number of Irish and English men whose religious beliefs led them on a transimperial itinerary from England and Ireland to Spain and then to the New World. The one-time English Dominican, Thomas Gage (1603–1656), and the Irish Jesuit, Michael Wadding, aka Miguel Godínez (1591–1644), were English and Irish Catholic recusants, respectively, who left behind the religious intolerance and uncertainty of Protestant England and colonized Ireland in search of the Catholic education denied them at home. Crossing the English Channel in Gage's case and the Irish Sea in that of Wadding/Godínez to study in Spain and Portugal and take holy orders, they then each underwent a further sea voyage across the Atlantic Ocean to become missionaries in various corners of the Iberian New World. Despite the similarities of these experiences, their fates played out in radically different ways. After twelve years of living as a Catholic priest in New Spain and Guatemala, Gage returned to England, renounced Catholicism, and betrayed those who had been his friends and companions, sending them to their deaths by execution. Wadding/Godínez, for his part, never looked back over the Atlantic to the land he had left behind and served the Catholic Church and the Society of Jesus in New Spain in many ways until his death at the age of 53.

Given the development of European empires in the early modern period and their unique reliance upon water crossings, the era presents us with a privileged vantage point from which to examine imperial tensions within a hydrocolonial perspective. Such a perspective when applied to the crossings Gage and Wadding/Godinez, alongside many others, made from Europe to New Spain, allows us to reframe the missionary experience within a transnational context informed by inter-imperialism and Protestant/Catholic religious conflict. These crossings encompass not only the transatlantic voyages that took these subjects to the Americas but also the shorter and perhaps even more fraught crossings that these missionaries *in potentia* made from England and Ireland to the Iberian Peninsula to study in the English and Irish colleges founded there as a response to England's oppression of Catholics.[1] Thomas Gage's apostasy and Michael Wadding's exemplarity as manifested in their writings function as a suggestive point of departure and comparison from which to examine transoceanic crossings between England, Ireland, Spain, and Latin America in the seventeenth century to see how these watery journeys inflect the intersection of religion and empire.

The complexities of the quadruple relationship among these early modern territories (Ireland, England, Spain, and New Spain)—connected to each other only by bodies of water—are myriad. While England and Spain maintained a fraught relationship that lurched from enmity to delicate diplomatic tensions, Ireland and Spain had built a relationship developed through their shared hatred of England but also on the foundations of a common religion. At the same time, Spain's conquest of New Spain and other American lands ironically provided a model that England emulated not least in its attempt to colonize Ireland (Fuchs, "Spanish Lessons," 43). Barbara Fuchs explains that England's adherence to propagating the Black Legend led to a disavowal of any "resemblance between itself and Spain," which in turn led critics to not always understand the "many connections between the two nations as imperial actors" ("Spanish Lessons," 43). Fuchs asks of England: "Can its own colonial exploits and colonized subjects in fact be distinguished from that of Spain?" ("Spanish Lessons," 43). If we were to ask Gage, perhaps the answer would be no.

The book he wrote of his travels and experiences in the Hispanic world, *The English American or a New Survey of the West Indies*, functions as a blueprint to guide England under Oliver Cromwell in emulating Spain's conquest. The poetic fragment included at the beginning of this essay, by way of an epigraph, formed part of *The English American*'s prefatory and paratextual materials and echoes this gesture.[2] The poet, Thomas Chaloner, a staunch anti-royalist during the English Civil War and signatory to the death warrant of Charles I, claims that Gage has succeeded in penetrating lands where only Spaniards "to those Parts may go" this having been "established by severe Decree" (referring here to the 1494 Treaty of Tordesillas). But although it "Seemeth almost a miracle to me" Gage was able to go and obtain this intelligence—"had permission free"—despite belonging to the nation "they count their greatest foe." What Chaloner omits to mention is that, in the case of Gage, religion trumped nation, and it was in his capacity as a Catholic priest ordained in Spain that he went to New Spain. Gage dedicates the book to Sir Thomas Fairfax, Parliamentary Commander in Chief during the English Civil War, and explains in this dedication that he had been living in exile from his Native country partly "by reason of my education in the Romish Religion and that in forraign Universities; and partly, by my entrance into Monasticall orders." He mitigates this fact by presenting himself as an expert on the Hispanic world and proffers this information to the Earl, so that the English might build on their colonization of various Caribbean islands and move on to "the

firme land." The Spaniards, he explains, have no legitimate title to those dominions other than "force." While he recognizes that the atives are the only ones who possess "the just right and titles to those Countries," he sees no reason why they should not "willingly and freely invite the English to their protection" and "what title soever they have in them, no doubt but they may legally transferr it or communicate it to others." Moreover, in the ultimate gesture of Western imperialism, he claims, "why should my Country-men the English be debarred from making use of that, which God from all beginning no question did ordain for the benefit of mankinde?" Despite his hatred of Spain and his disregard for its religion, Gage's comments underscore Fuchs's description of the relationship between the two countries as "a chiastic relationship of vulnerability and aggression" in which their "colonial exploits and efforts to consolidate as nations remained intimately entwined" ("Spanish Lessons" 45).

Catholicism forged a natural bond between Ireland and Spain, and indeed some have spoken of a Gaelic Hispanophilism. A sense of a shared cultural or even ethnic identity existed. Declan Downey explains that, despite the geographical separation between Ireland and Spain, "a feeling of a pan-Iberianism existed" (224). As the English pushed into Ireland, Irish Catholics turned to Spain for both military and emotional support. This facilitated "an easy flow of Irish priests, scholars, professionals and military officials into important position in Spain between the sixteenth and the eighteenth centuries" and the Irish living in Spain, like Wadding/Godínez, were declared by the Governor of Galicia in a letter to Phillip III to be "nuestros hermanos del Norte" (qtd in Downey, 225). This closeness of course continued to make England very nervous, and Ireland was viewed by the English as a potential "base" for a Spanish invasion of England (Christopher Highley qtd in Fuchs, "Spanish Lessons," 45).

The Catholic connection between Spain, England, and Ireland allows us to glimpse the complex and even serpentine relationship in which religion, imperialism, and colonial ambitions played different roles at different times and came together in a myriad of ways, depending on the shifting political sands of the time. Viewed through a hydrocolonial lens, the education, travels, and life experiences of Gage and Wadding/Godínez, will help me elucidate some of these complexities while placing the question of the maritime at the center of these nations' religious and imperial ambitions. This hydrocolonial lens, as Isabel Hofmeyr identifies it, "makes visible the relations of power that have been shaped around water and its colonial appropriations" ("Provisional Notes," 13) allowing me here to

expose the colonial/global intersections present in the missionary routes my two subjects take, in one case, from England to Spain and then on to the Americas and in the other from Ireland to Spain and to the Americas. Along the way, I will show how hydrocolonial thinking facilitates a clearer understanding of this global Catholic network and the violent impact it had on the people and the lands whose conversion and submission it held as its ultimate evangelical ambition. As Hofmeyr makes clear, hydrocolonialism runs parallel to the concept of the "postcolonial" with the latter aiming "to understand a world shaped by European empires and their aftermaths" and the former signaling a "commitment to understanding a world indelibly shaped by imperial uses of water" ("Provisional Notes," 13). As Kerry Bystrom and Hofmeyr further explain, attaching the suffixes "colonial" or "imperial" to the question of the sea brings the Global South into sharp focus and allows us to "shift the intellectual center of gravity away from a purely land-focused one" (3). I want to visualize the bodies of water and the life changes they facilitated not as empty spaces merely to be traversed and withstood but rather as possessing meaning in terms of colonial and imperialistic mindsets. Taking this meaning into account, how can we view the role of the European missionary as he crosses the water to save souls and perhaps meet his end in glorious martyrdom? What can this hydrocolonial lens reveal about the overlap of national identities in an imperial and Catholic context?

Along with a theoretical approach informed by hydrocolonial thinking, Barbara Fuchs's concept of imperium studies will also be useful here for conceiving of the relationship between England, Ireland, Spain, and the New World as exemplified by the lives and travels of Gage and Wadding/Godínez. As Fuchs explains, imperium studies "challenges the self-sufficient histories of nations and empire by arguing for their imbrication and competition" ("Another Turn for Transnationalism,"412). It is only by thinking of these empires as offering a "plural history" can the "intersections among them" offer the full story ("Another Turn for Transnationalism,"412). While transnationalism (or perhaps even globalism) may seem like a tempting label to invoke, Fuchs explains that it omits "the crucial register of empire" which, I would add, underwrote all activities pertaining to sovereignty, religion, and culture in the period ("Another Turn for Transnationalism," 413). The fraught and deeply interwoven imperial/colonial histories of England, Ireland, Spain, and New Spain cannot thus be understood outside of the framework of empire, and empire itself cannot be fully comprehended without engaging with the

struggle for control of the bodies of water that connected metropole and periphery. The oceans, moreover, did not simply figure as a "commercial question" in imperial mentalities but rather must be seen as "part of the construction of power in the European state system" (Mancke, 233). Elizabeth Mancke describes oceans as "a fundamental part of European empire-building "and that the "politicization and militarization of oceanic space as much as its globalization" was a singular feature of European expansion (226). Oceans became scenes of attack by rival empires and eventually this "volatile" scene of multiple imperial powers contesting maritime spaces and the "ambiguity" of laws governing the sea led to the creation of "a new international order that could accommodate these empires" (Mancke 227).

Often omitted in our analysis of the lives of early modern missionaries and of the contemporaneous texts that tell of them is what Margaret Cohen describes as the "history and processes of ocean transportation" (658). As Bystrom and Hofmeyr assert, "ship travel foregrounds movement across national and linguistic boundaries, taking in experiences and ideas from diverse latitudes and longitudes" (2), and my goal in this essay is to evaluate the movement through these various boundaries to foreground it as integral to these men's missionary experience, connect it to the question of empire. My gesture is in no way celebratory nor does it "envision an Oceanic Studies based only on the free circulation, inversion of power, and mixing of peoples that the ocean seems at first glance to allow" (Bystrom and Hofmeyr 2). But rather, imagining Oceanic Studies through the prism of hydrocolonialism, we can see the violence inherent in the missionary project and the human and natural costs that it engendered. While bodies of water liberated Gage and Godínez from religious oppression in their countries of origin, they also facilitated the equally oppressive politics of conversion and the imperial incursions they themselves brought to bear on American Natives with their missionary activities.

The experience of missionaries at sea has not been given the attention it merits, as David Salomoni explains. Instead, apart from a few notable exceptions, historians and other scholars have treated it as "an inevitable and fairly obvious detail" of the missionary's trajectory (1). Salomoni highlights the work of Liam Brockey who, in charting the experience of Jesuits in the Portuguese empire, offers such details as the rules set out by the Society for onboard behavior and other pertinent information such as the astonishing mortality rate associated with missionary travel, which for those who went to Asia, or the Americas could be as high as 50% (Salomoni

2). In his article, which the author positions as groundbreaking in its focus, Salomoni brings together a bibliography of primary and secondary sources that attend to the experience of the religious missionary at sea. His focus is primarily the Jesuits since they played a role of "greater historical importance (…) in the processes of early modern globalization" and because they produced incredibly detailed documentation of all their activities (10). He includes mendicant texts alongside secular writings to present a point of comparison with the Jesuits as well as to look at the role of religious onboard ship from an outside perspective (5). The bibliography included in the brief article is of immense value from a historiographical perspective but Salomoni neglects to engage with the ethnocentric ramifications of these missionary crossings. Thinking hydrocolonially problematizes the idea of the neutral crossings of bodies and goods across oceans in the service of empire. Imperial agents such as Gage and Wadding/Godínez traverse the ocean with different ambitions but similar colonial designs in which cultural and religious violence would be visited upon those who became the subject of their evangelical attentions. While the texts with which I am working do not allow me to say a great deal, at least in the case of Wadding/Godínez, regarding these men's day-to-day life aboard ship, I highlight the two men's journeys in order to place their actions within a hydrocolonial framework that draws attention to them as operating within the dynamic of imperial power and colonial violence.

The ocean also operates as a frontier that separates the metropolitan religious power base from the colonial sites of potential domination. Scholars have long discussed the nature of the New World church within the framework of the frontier. Alison Forrestal and Seán Alexander Smith, for example, discuss the New World frontier church as one that provided both "opportunities and problems" for the Catholic hierarchy (10). The opportunity resided in their hope to increase the number of the Catholic faithful and the problems respond to the difficulties of administering sites that were so far flung from the imperial centers that controlled them (Forrestal and Smith, 11). Key to understanding these oceanic empires was the question of distance to the seat of imperial control, separated in the case of Spain from its American colonies by thousands of miles of water (Mancke 226–7). This distance created tensions in the establishment of the missionary church as the deep-rooted differences between the European model and the New World reality threw into sharp relief the difficulty of integrating missionary settlements into the "global church" (Forrestal and Smith 10). "Frontier areas" such as those in the Northern

reaches of New Spain were obviously areas of "experimentation and challenge" and recently and incompletely converted Native populations could not be seamlessly incorporated into existing models of worship creating difficulties for missionaries (Forrestal and Smith, 10). While missionaries made these dangerous oceanic crossings instilled with evangelical fervor and an unquestioned sense of the rectitude of their vocation, viewed from a decolonial perspective centuries later we cannot fail to see the violence "inherent in Spanish colonial missionary and evangelization processes" (Hernández García, 76). Narratives of martyrdom, such as Spanish Jesuit Andrés Pérez de Ribas *Historia de los triunfos de nuestra santa fe entre gentes las más bárbaras y fieras del Nuevo Orbe*[3] [History of the Triumphs of Our Holy Faith amongst the Most Barbarous and Fierce Peoples of the New World], serve to reveal the cultural violence in the practices the missionaries employed as they labored to save souls. As Luis Javier Cuesta Hernández and Alejandro Hernández García point out, "Violent acts by Indigenous peoples against the sacred and foundational labor of evangelization were often recast as "the slaughter of Spaniards" in seventeenth- and eighteenth-century Spanish historiography (76). They see this recasting as a "manipulation of historical discourse" and as "rhetorical resource to center the Christian sacred in narratives of martyrdom" (76).

The possibility of martyrdom frames the crossings of all missionaries who went to the New World to work in the conversion of the Natives and occurs in both Gage's and Wadding/Godinez's work. The concept of martyrdom is key to understanding the missionary endeavor and cannot be separated from imperialism (Cañeque 19). Alejandro Cañeque views the concept of the frontier church as relevant for understanding of martyrdom in the Spanish empire. He identifies England as the first Jesuit frontier for the Spanish Crown as they undertook, as we saw, to bring England back to Catholicism and assist the beleaguered Irish Catholics through the establishment of seminaries and colleges such as the ones attended by Gage and Wadding. The sixteenth-century martyrdom of English Jesuits—as well as some in Ireland—ignited the phenomenon of martyrdom in the Spanish empire where it had not previously existed (Cañeque 20). Because of their protagonism in the English mission, it was the Jesuits who, with their later arrival in New Spain (1572), were imbued with what Cañeque terms the culture of martyrdom flourishing in Europe in the late sixteenth century (21). The English theater of martyrdom would be replaced with the Japanese where, in the first couple of decades of the seventeenth century, many Japanese Christians and their evangelizers (Franciscans,

Dominicans, and Jesuits) would be martyred. All this led to an interest on the part of religious men in being martyrs[4] and a parallel interest on the part of the public in reading about them. Cañeque explains how the orders would frequently update the lists of those martyred in Japan and published what he calls an "extensa literatura polémica sobre los mártires del Japón, que circulará profusamente tanto por el mundo hispánico como por el resto de Europa" [an extensive polemic literature about those martyred in Japan, that circulates widely in the Hispanic world and in Europe] (24).

Martyrdom became a global Catholic phenomenon because of the maritime crossings in which the missionaries engaged and must be viewed within a hydrocolonial context. In an early study of the *Indipetae*, the Jesuit historian Ernest Burrus describes the letters written by young European men who wanted to go to the Indies as Jesuit missionaries.[5] He claims that the early missionary activity of the Society in places like Brazil and New Spain "set off among the youth of Europe an extraordinary chain reaction, inspiring many to enter the Society and firing others already in the order to volunteer for the foreign missions" (336). Burrus found evidence of some subjects writing several letters of application, so keen were they to go, and he mentions the case of one who sent 53 missives (336). The solicitants came from all over Europe although most were Spanish, Italian, and Portuguese. Burrus, however, found petitions from men in the Low Countries as well as Germans, Austrians, French, and Bohemians. Found in the *Indipetae* are examples of requests from England, Scotland, and Ireland but, as Burrus explains, these men were encouraged to focus their attentions "on the great need of apostolic workers in their own countries" (337). However, despite this, and despite the oath these men would swear while in Spain to return home after taking holy orders, some exceptions were made. According to Burrus, at least in the case of the Jesuits, if foreigners were given permission to go abroad they had to be sent to minister to the infidels and not be placed among the Creoles of the cities. But, he explains, this was "exactly what the petitioners had requested" and he cites the recurring phrases *inter infideles* and *ad barbaros* from the letters (340). He found letters requesting a position in "the East, whether China, Japan or India" and others that displayed a clear preference for "Malabar, Persia, the Americas, Canada, Mexico, Peru, Paraguay, the Philippines, the Marianas, and other regions where the Society was working or might soon open up new fields" (340). However, he clarifies, "commonest of all was complete indifference—*ad quamvis orbis partem*" (340). Michael Wadding did display a preference, however,

as while completing his studies he wrote to the Father General in Rome asking if he might be sent to Japan where, by 1597, twenty-six Christians including Jesuits and Franciscans along with local converts, had been martyred for their faith. In a kind and patient letter, Mutio Vitelleschi redirects him to a more local conversion target: the Native peoples of Mexico, explaining: "In the New World, where you now are, you will surely not lack opportunity of working among the Indians. May Our Lord guide us in coming to the best decision and give you, as I desire, generously of His blessings" (qtd in Burrus, 346). Not long after, eight of the Jesuits living among the Tepehuan people on the Northern frontier of New Spain were slain and Wadding/Godínez spent eight years in what is present day Sinaloa and Sonora attempting to evangelize the Natives there.

Gage had no desire to be a martyr and his decision to join the Dominicans, rather than the Jesuits, helped free him from the responsibility to minister to the beleaguered English Catholics at risk to his own life. Nonetheless and despite (and perhaps because of) his disavowal of this calling, the specter of martyrdom haunts his writings as he actively works to forestall any encounter that may lead to this fate beginning with an avoidance of a forced return to his home country. At the beginning of his book, he recounts that having boarded the ship bound for the New World and while still ashore at Cadiz, the governor of the city ordered Gage's arrest, having received information from Pablo de Londres "an old crab faced English fryer living in St. Lucar" regarding the illegal presence of an Englishman aboard the ship. The governor's order signified, as the author explains, "the King of *Spains* will and pleasure, that no *English* should passe to the *India's*, having a Countrey of their own to convert." Gage admits that he had received letters of this sort before embarking, explaining he should return to the English mission but decided to ignore the commands—"none of these letters could prevail with mee; nor the Governours searching stop mee"—and carried onto the ship while hiding in an empty sea biscuit barrel, he embarks for the New World with this ignominious beginning to his missionary endeavors foreshadowing perhaps how his journey would end.

Martyrdom in the context of early modern Catholic missionaries responds to the idea that Hester Blum develops of the ocean as a space that makes possible "other ways of understanding affiliation, citizenship, sovereignty, all of which have been read in recent critical history as overdetermined by nationalism" (671). The oceans and their many tributaries facilitated what Brian Lockey has called global Catholic cosmopolitanism.

He identifies this cosmopolitan identity as headed by a "muscular papacy" that "ruled above all nations and empires and that was truly a transnational imperium" (Lockey 72). It was under the banner of this global Catholic cosmopolitanism that missionaries from different parts of Europe—and eventually their descendants—sought martyrdom at the hands of the pagan, Native peoples. The many hagiographic texts that tell of these often gruesome martyrdoms recount the selfless and heroic acts of religious men as they labored under difficult circumstances to bring Christianity to these populations. The men who died for Christ in the hostile mission field offered the most perfect example of *imitatio christi* and early modern Jesuit martyrdom thus became a key instrument in holding together the Society's global project of conversion and salvation and a model for Jesuit masculinity. However, viewed through a hydrocolonial lens, the crossings undertaken by missionaries holding the potential for a martyr's death in their hearts, position the ocean not as a neutral space but rather as a facilitation of imperial violence.

The early lives of Thomas Gage and Michael Wadding offer compelling points of connection. They both left their homes as young men to pursue the Catholic education that was denied them at home and made dangerous crossings across European bodies of water to get there. These men came from similar family backgrounds and received a similar Catholic education in exile at Spain. They also left Spain not to return to England or Ireland as most of their countrymen who studied in the continental European seminaries and colleges did but chose instead a different and radically other mission field on the other side of the Atlantic. Having crossed the Atlantic Ocean, however, their experiences would diverge, however. Gage eschewed joining the Jesuits as his father desired and sought refuge as a Dominican in the comforts of low-stakes sinecures in different cities in New Spain. He used the luxury he encountered and enjoyed there as a weapon to critique the Church upon his return to England and disavowed his Catholicism becoming a virulent hunter of recusants. Wadding, on the other hand, wholeheartedly embraced the Spanish evangelical and imperial mission and transformed himself into the renowned Jesuit, Miguel Godínez who, after braving the dangers of the mission fields of the Northern New Spanish frontier, became the confessor of the famous mystical nun, Sor Maria Jesus Tomellin, and the author of the first theological work on mysticism in the New World: the *Práctica de la teología mística*.

Despite the differences in fortune, however, both men shared flawless Catholic pedigrees. A genealogy of Catholic martyrs preceded Thomas Gage who grew up with the concept fixed firmly in both his imaginary and his future. His uncle, Robert Gage, was executed for his role in the Babington Plot—the plan to assassinate Queen Elizabeth I and place her cousin, Mary Queen of Scots on the throne in her stead. The long-term goal of the plot was the invasion of England by the Spanish forces of King Philip II and the Catholic League in France, leading to the restoration of the old religion. The poet and Jesuit, Saint Robert Southwell, one of the Forty Martyrs of England and Wales, was Thomas Gage's mother Margaret's first cousin and she apparently risked her life to push through the crowd to ask for her cousin's blessing as he rode in a cart toward his death at Tyburn. Both she and her husband, John, Gage's father, had received sentences of death for attending a clandestine mass in 1591 but were pardoned two years later while mounting the scaffold (Brietz Monta). Thomas Gage's brothers also embraced the militancy of recusant faith with several taking holy orders (one became a Jesuit) and another fighting for Spain as a soldier on the continent. At first it appeared that Thomas would follow in their footsteps, and, like many other English Catholic young men, he went to study at the Jesuit colleges on the continent, first at St. Omer in what is now France but was then in the territory controlled by the Spanish, and then at St. Albans in Valladolid. From an early age, however, Thomas showed himself reluctant to join the list of illustrious martyrs in his family and instead of returning home to join the clandestine English mission and the Jesuits as his father wanted, he entered the Dominican order and embarked for the mission fields of the Philippines where he believed he could dodge the martyr's fate.[6]

Michael Wadding (1591) was from an old family in Waterford, Ireland, that had the most impeccable of global Catholic credentials. The Wadding sons had traditionally gone into the Church and among Michael's generation was his brother Peter who was the Jesuit chancellor of the University of Prague, his brother Ambrose who taught theology and Hebrew in the Jesuit college in Bavaria, his half-brother Luke who studied at the Jesuit novitiate of Villagarcía and went on to teach at the Colegio Imperial in Madrid and his cousin Luke, perhaps the most famous of the Waddings, a Franciscan who worked for the Inquisition in Rome. Michael, for his part, became one of the most "successfully integrated and significant" of the Irish clerical migrants in the "Spanish sphere" of his generation (O'Connor 99). Orphaned at an early age, he studied first at the Colegio Irlandés de

Lisboa and then, beginning in 1607, at the Irish College in Salamanca, the Real Colegio de San Patricio de Nobles Irlandeses, where he Hispanicized his name, becoming Miguel Godínez, and where his superiors immediately singled him out as someone with potential (O'Connor 99). After Salamanca, he pursued the rigors of the Jesuit novitiate at the Monastery at Villagarcía de Campos near Valladolid. Significantly, he gained permission from his superiors to go to the New World as a missionary,[7] a position which many men coveted and which represented one of the twin poles of a carefully constructed Jesuit masculinity, the other being that of instructor in the urban Jesuit colleges. Michael Wadding went on to hold both these positions.

Waterford was the Irish epicenter of Catholic resistance to England, known as "la pequeña Roma" in Spain and its inhabitants as "los papistas" (O'Connor 98). The port city's long-held mercantile relations with Spain and Portugal facilitated the incorporation of the "reforming energies of contemporary European Catholicism" (O'Connor 98). The city's chief trading partners were the countries of the Iberian Peninsula. Even when Spain found itself at war with England, Waterford's trade with Spain did not cease and merchants freely came and went (Lough 720). The Spanish presence in the port city had ramifications for both the English who gleaned information regarding Spain's naval preparations and for the Irish who made common cause with Spanish intolerance for the English (Lough 720–1). Like many Waterford families, the Waddings had their sights trained outward to Continental Europe as a site for the education of their sons and this opportunity would have been inculcated in Michael from an early age. This outward gaze across water owed much to their Catholic affinity but also with the fact that coastal zones like Waterford are "especially liable to human rearrangement" with the port city representing "the epicentre of such earth moving" (Hofmeyr, "Imperialism Above and Below," 2). As Michael Wadding and his brothers and cousins crossed the Irish Sea to France, Spain, Portugal, Rome, and other European Catholic centers, and then, in the case of Michael, to New Spain, we can see how, in the words of Hofmeyr, "the beliefs and practices of those in the port city spilled over into the ocean, filling it with both physical detritus and metaphysical entities" ("Imperialism Above and Below," 2).

Between the years of 1625 and 1637, Gage traveled through Mexico, Guatemala, and beyond and later recorded what he saw for posterity. In 1648, his book bearing the title *The English American or a New Survey of the West Indies* was published in England and stands as a stringent

denunciation of the Catholic Church in the New World. By the time the book went onto circulation, Gage had renounced Catholicism and embraced Protestantism with the zeal of the convert and consigned former friends to die as martyrs to the Catholic faith. Although many critics have focused on Gage's embrace of the tenets of the Black Legend, the indigenous American people receive scant mention in his text. Instead, he concentrates his efforts on denouncing the excesses he witnesses in the creole Church, especially in the convents of religious women. Gage's text functions as an indictment of Catholicism and Spanish imperial power, a report on the Spanish empire for England and its government, as well as a handbook providing strategic details of how easy it would be for the English to wrest control of Spain's New World territories offering an example of the imperial imbrication and competition Fuchs analyzes ("Another Turn for Transnationalism," 412). Gage uses his writings on Catholic excesses to inscribe himself into the austere Protestant rhetoric of Oliver Cromwell's England. Catholic nuns stand as emblematic of Catholicism's greatest perversions allowing Gage to perform a rigorous and dour Protestant masculinity based on his rejection of the Popish corruption the Catholic nun supposedly embodied.

Gage begins the autobiographical section of his narrative following a discussion of the different viceroyalties and provinces of the Spanish empire and the religious orders that travel there. For him, these men are no different than other types of merchandise that is shipped across the oceans. Describing the types of missionaries that are sent from New Spain to the Philippines, he explains how they are "conveyed thither":

> First they are sent in the ships that are bound for Nueva España and Mexico; and after they have rested two or three moneths in Mexico, they are sent to Acapulco, lying on the Mar del Zur, there they are shipped in two great Caracks which yearly go and come richly laden with China, Japan, and all East-India ware from Manila to Acapulco to enrich Mexico with farre greater riches then any are sent by the North Sea from Spain.

Thus, for Gage, the missionary slots neatly into the imperial traffic of goods across the ocean. Their knowledge of God and their ministry to the Indigenous New World inhabitants seems, for the imperial powers, to be a fair exchange for the riches they extract there. He himself was resident in a monastery in Jerez when he was persuaded to embark for the Philippines where, he was assured, life would be both lucrative and comfortable.

Having been disinherited by his father for refusing to become a Jesuit, Gage decides he has little to lose and so resolves to go. He proceeds to Cadiz where he embarks on a transatlantic voyage in a fleet of 41 ships—bound for different parts of the Spanish empire from Campeche to Jamaica—including eight galleons to defend them from pirates. Among the passengers was the future viceroy and archbishop of Mexico. Gage discusses how the boredom of the long journey was mitigated by theatrical performances aboard ship with the Dominicans on one ship striving to outdo the Jesuits who had previously performed aboard another ship as the fleet traversed the Atlantic. He describes the festivities aboard the ship, the *Santa Gertrudis*, on the feast day of St. Ignatius in which a group of 30 Jesuits who were aboard held a procession accompanied late into the night with songs, cannon fire, and paper lanterns hung on the masts. The Dominicans, not to be outdone, did something similar on the day of St. Dominic, followed by a lavish dinner and the performance of a play by Lope de Vega. Thus, we see how the ocean functions not as a liminal space that facilitated arrival in the New World but is instead an imperial forum upon which culture and ritual have been imposed.

Gage sailed from Cadiz en route for the Philippines on July 2, 1625, crossing the Atlantic Ocean and landing first at Guadalupe. While Gage recounts his journey on land from Veracruz to Mexico City and then to Guatemala in detail, it is the description of his sea voyages that interest me here and how he uses the ocean and the multiple imperial presences upon it to engage in a dismantling of the legitimacy of Spanish power and the religious ideology that underpinned it and to which he had once professed his allegiance. In addition, and not discounting the extreme prejudice with which he frames his representation of the Catholic Church and its personnel, through his descriptions we can glimpse the cultural violence enacted by missionaries as they encounter Native peoples they believe in need of salvation as they traverse the ocean. Landing on the island of Guadeloupe, they disembark to bathe themselves and wash their clothes. Gage describes how the Natives came out in their canoes "before our Anchors were cast" which curiously bore the markings of the different imperial fleets that had imposed themselves upon the Caribbean and its peoples. He describes the canoes, "round like Troughes some whereof had beene painted by our *English*, some by the *Hollanders*, some by the *French*, as might appeare by their severall Armes, it being a common Rode and harbour to all Nations that saile to *America*." Complicit in the anti-Spanish discourse of the English state and keen to use his text to propagate the Black Legend in

order to position England as a more suitable colonizer, Gage's description of the Natives reproduces Columbus's almost exactly in his description of them as both childlike and savage: "we [Dominican friars] wandred sometimes all together sometimes two and two, and sometimes one alone about the Island, meeting with many *Indians*, who did us no hurt, but rather like children fauned upon us, offering us of their fruits, and begging of us whatsoever toies of pins, points or gloves they espied about us." In the same paragraph he describes them as "rude and Savage indians" and their appearance as "people naked, with their haire hanging down to the middle of their backes, with their faces cut out in severall fashions, or flowers, with thin plates hanging at their Noses, like Hog-rings." Later that same day, he recounts how a group of Jesuits come upon a "*Mulatto*, all naked like the rest of the *Indians*." This man, a Spaniard born in Seville into slavery, escaped cruel treatment from two masters by absconding from a Spanish ship in Guadeloupe some 12 years previously. He had made a life for himself there and now had an Indigenous wife and children whom he loved. The Jesuits, according to Gage, explained that unless he went with them his soul and that of his family faced eternal damnation and he vowed to join them later that day. Gage explains how he instead betrayed them and brought what he describes as an army of Natives to the shore who attacked the Jesuits and the ships with arrows. Gage uses this to frame martyrdom as a fool's errand and one that instead of bringing glory upon those who seek it serves only to reveal their cowardice. Speaking of the Jesuits who had earlier expressed so much zeal to stay on the island and convert the Natives, he explains, "But now wee perceived their zeale was coole, and they desired no more to stay with such a Barbarous kind of People; but rather wished the Admirall would shoot off the warning Peece for us all to take up our Anchors, and depart from so dangerous a place." While obviously the reader must consider how Gage uses the Black Legend as a way to color all the Spaniards do in service of their Catholic empire, what the narrative clearly demonstrates is the explicit connection between the ship, the missionary, and the infliction of colonial violence upon Native peoples. Gage felt no zeal to convert them, as he tells his English reader. Another Dominican, an Irishman Thomas Lyons who went by the Hispanicized name of Tomás de León, had also succeeded in getting assigned to the Philippine mission. While he too finds himself gripped by fear as these events unfold, he nonetheless fulfills his duty and journey on to the Philippines as his friend, Gage, absconds during some time ashore in Mexico City and flees to Guatemala gripped with fear of being "forcedly

against our wills to be shipped to *Philippinas*" and left without hope "of returning ever again to Christendome."

We have no information on Michael Wadding's experience of crossing the Atlantic Ocean from Spain to New Spain and so we must imagine it based on the accounts of others. All we know about this journey comes from a brief note regarding his life in the eighteenth-century New Spanish Jesuit Francisco Javier Alegre's *Historia de la Provincia de la Compañía de Jesús de Nueva España*, where he explains that having completed his studies in Spain, Wadding/Godínez departed for Mexico City on June 29, 1609, in the maritime expedition led by Padre Francisco Báez, who had been designated Provincial of New Spain. Once in Mexico, he spent time at the Jesuit seminary of Tepotzotlán[8] and after professing his first vows in 1611, he taught letters in the Colegio Máximo while following the Jesuit program in philosophy and theology. After taking his final vows in 1619, Wadding/Godínez was sent to the missions in Sonora and Sinaloa whose Native peoples included the Tepehuan, the Mayo, and the Heave. The Jesuits had arrived in the area in 1617 and Wadding/Godínez counts among one of the early missionaries there, arriving with the group under Father Cristóbal de Villalta. For the most part, this new mission area flourished from the perspective of the Jesuits given its distance from Spanish mining areas and the violence and loose moral standards that reigned there and that operated as a counterweight to the Society's evangelization efforts (O'Connor 99). We have only scant details of Wadding's time in Sinaloa and most of that comes from the fleeting references to his missionary past in the pages of his *Práctica de la teología mística*. The information he presents there is not intended to be autobiographical and instead serves as a stepping off point for him to discuss the mystical theme of "desamparo" and how it might impact those who dedicate themselves to the difficult conversion and indoctrination of Natives. He seems reluctant, in some ways, to speak directly about his experiences and instead represents himself as someone who witnessed the missionaries in action rather than being one of them although, of course, he was. In Book III, Chapter VII, he explains that "muchos años me ocupó la obediencia en este ministerio de la conversión de los gentiles" (144). He describes that, as an eyewitness, he perceived the "inmensos trabajos de cuerpo y alma que padecían los primeros varones apostólicos" (144). He paints a terrible picture of the privations he says the missionaries endured in their vocation of saving souls. The greatest dangers came from those who refused to accept the word of God and clung to their own beliefs: "la vida estaba siempre

vendida entre hechiceros, que con el pacto que tenían con el demonio nos hacían cruda guerra, predicando el demonio en medio de ellos, en nuestro traje y hábito, lo contrario que nosotros predicábamos de día" (145). He tells of the martyrdom of two of his companions and of coming very close himself but that, while they killed his "mozo," he himself was saved (145). He portrays the missionary as a masculine figure who withstands the most terrible privations and who navigates the most dangerous of circumstances from lack of food and basic human necessities to inhospitable terrain. All the while they are "perseguidos" by, one must assume, wild beasts or the equally wild Natives whom they are attempting to save and whom he describes as "salvajes desnudos" (145). But despite all this inmense adversity, "se servía muy bien á Dios y se convertían muchos gentiles (146). Wadding/Godínez describes how once a year the missionaries would gather with the Jesuit Superior to discuss the progress of their missionary activities, including how many new Christians they had baptized and how many new dangers they had confronted (146). He recounts how the baptisms rose steadily over the years to reach the high point of 120,000 in 1624. Unfortunately, he relates that shortly afterward a great pestilence came and killed thousands of the neophytes.

Wadding/Godínez secured his fame among the Jesuit and religious community in New Spain and beyond through the treatise which was published in Puebla in 1681 and in two subsequent editions in Seville and Lisbon. At the time of writing, he occupied the position of Professor of Theology at the Colegio Máximo of San Pablo and San Pedro. In the preliminary materials that precede the text and in other Jesuit biographical writings Godínez is lauded as a man of great sanctity, purity, wisdom, austerity, and learning. The archdeacon of Puebla's cathedral proclaims that the mere printed inscription of his name in the text guarantees the probity and worth of his book. The combination of erudition and sanctity marks him clearly as conforming to the ideals of elite Jesuit masculinity. In Puebla, Godínez became the confessor of several religious women, most significantly the mystical nuns Isabel de la Encarnación of the Carmelite convent, and María de Jesús Tomellín of the Inmaculada Concepción convent in Puebla. Despite having fulfilled all the touchstones of Jesuit masculinity and exemplarity, he did endure a brush with the Inquisition, an institution he himself had served. His "exaltación espiritual" [spiritual exaltation] was deemed to be too excessive for the Society of Jesus and was not well thought of in Rome, and consequently the *Práctica* was not published during his lifetime (Pilar Gonzalbo Aizpuru 246).

As very young men, both Wadding/Godínez and Gage had been forced to leave their home countries to secure the Catholic education and preparation for the priesthood they could not attain at home owing to oppressive English laws that forbade this in both countries and traverse the dangers of a crossing to continental Europe that was fraught in so many ways. In a 1591 decree Elizabeth I had designated seminarians studying on the continent to be "traitors, fugitives and rebels" underscoring the terrible danger these men faced in leaving their countries and, in many cases, returning as priests. In a study of the Irish College at Alcalá de Henares, Patricia O'Connell describes the journey of students such as Wadding/Godínez from Ireland to Spain as one taking several months (113). While waiting for a ship willing to take them and for favorable winds, students faced arrest or interception. She describes how "spies and informants" lay in wait in the port cities "to detect priests or clerics coming or going between Ireland and continental ports" (O'Boyle qtd in O'Connor 114). Both Gage and Wadding/Godínez would have been subject to this scrutiny and the fear of discovery that accompanied it as they waited for passage to Spain. Their religion made them outcasts and, in the case of Wadding/Godínez, a colonized subject of an imperial occupier. Yet this same religion motivated them, to different degrees, to cross another dangerous body of water and participate in acts of colonization that while they may have been motivated by religious zeal and a sense of rectitude, must be viewed as cultural violence. In reading these journeys through a hydrocolonial lens, I hope to have shed some decolonial light on the complexity of imperial imbrications in which religion determined one's imperial allegiance. In crossing the Atlantic Ocean, Michael Wadding became Miguel Godínez, leaving no trace of his former national and colonial Irish identity as he assumed a new, imperial one. Gage was a man of many identities and, once he returned to England, pragmatically rejected his Catholicism to be fully received as a citizen of a militant Protestant republic. He nonetheless was able to retain his imperial identity, switching easily from one power to another, perhaps embodying what Blum, citing William Boelhower, describes as an Oceanic order that "holds all together in a common but highly fluid space" (92–3).

Notes

1. There are a large number of studies that focus on the Irish Colleges in Spain and Portugal. See for example Enrique García's Hernán's "Irish Clerics in Madrid," Thomas O'Connor's "Irish Collegians in Spanish Service (1560–1803)," Patricia O'Connell's *The Irish College of Alcalá de Henares*, and James O'Boyle's *The Irish Colleges on the Continent: Their Origin and History*. There is an equally extensive scholarship on the English colleges in the Iberian Peninsula including Berta Cano-Echevarría and Ana Sáez-Hidalgo "Educating for Martyrdom: British Exiles in the English College at Valladolid," Sáez-Hidalgo's "St. Alban's English College, Valladolid: Enclave or Doorway to the Reception of English Books in Spain?" and Michael E. Williams's *St. Alban's College Valladolid: Four Centuries of English Catholic Presence in Spain*.
2. Catherine Armstrong's careful reading of the text demonstrates Chaloner's inaccuracy in attributing Gage's comments purely to his own eyewitness observations. She describes how many of his descriptions rely heavily on previously published Spanish texts including those by López de Gómara and Fernández de Oviedo.
3. Pérez de Ribas spent decades in New Spain in both the missions and the cities before writing his extensive treatises on the New World Jesuit experience.
4. The Jesuit historian Ernest Burrus describes how the Jesuit Francis Xavier's initial missionary activities and the Society's subsequent missions to Brazil, Florida, Mexico, Peru, and the Philippines, set off "among the youth of Europe an extraordinary chain reaction, inspiring many to enter the Society and firing others already in the Order to volunteer for the foreign missions" (336).
5. Burrus explains how these documents are found in the Fondo Gesuitico. The word *Indipetae* comes from the fact that these missives were categorized as petitions to go to the Indies.
6. Both the English and Irish students at the Catholic colleges on the continent were expected to return home to minister to the Catholic faithful in their own country and convert those who had abandoned their faith. Phillip III offered each young man who returned to his homeland mission the sum of 10 pounds in the form of a *viaticum*. Not only was there a financial incentive embedded in the return home, but students were also obliged to swear an oath, promising that upon completion of their studies they would fulfill this obligation. The oath declared the following: "Mindful of the benefits that God our Lord has done me, first and foremost in having me removed from my homeland, which is so beset by heresies, and in having made me a member of his Catholic Church, wishing not to be ungrateful for so great a

mercy of the Lord, have resolved to offer myself entirely to his divine service, to the extent that I can, in fulfillment of the aims of this college. And thus I promise and swear by Almighty God, that I am prepared in my soul, in as far as his divine grace will aid me, to receive holy orders in good time, and to return to England to seek, win, and convert the souls of my neighbors as and when the superiors of this college, according to its institute, judges it good, commanding me so in the Lord" (*Pedro de Ribadeneyra's 'Ecclesiastical History of the Schism of the Kingdom of England': A Spanish Jesuit's History of the English Reformation*. Ed. Spenser Weinreich. Brill, 2017: 666).

7. In contrast to some of the other Irish migrants in the New World, Irish clerical migration was classified as legal. It was not easy, however, for Irish clerics to migrate since they needed both their superior's permission and that of the King and were supposed to have spent a "lengthy period" living in Spain before this permission could be granted (97). O'Connor explains that the network of Irish colleges established in Spain beginning in 1590 "provided means for Irish clergy not intent on returning home, to take up a ministry in Spain or the Empire (97).
8. Thomas O'Connor explains that in the seventeenth century "a diversification of the Irish presence in Iberia saw the Irish become increasingly mobile within the Spanish Empire" (87). In addition to missionaries, he mentions soldiers and other visitors of whom he has found traces in the Caribbean, Mexico, the Amazon River valley, and the Pacific coast of Peru (87).

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CHAPTER 4

On Paper Ships, Sailors, and Cosmographers: Spanish Maritime Narratives and Political Networks of an Imperial Project

Christian Supiot

In July 1692, the Galician writer and sailor, Francisco de Seyxas y Lovera, crossed the Atlantic to take possession of the Alcalde Mayor appointment in the city of Tacuba, near Mexico City. Seyxas, a former merchant sailor, privateer, and navy officer, got the appointment thanks to his ties to the Marquis of Los Vélez, the president of the Council of the Indies. Despite the alliance between Vélez and the Count of Galve, the Viceroy of New Spain, Seyxas would see his luck run dry, as he faced a hostile viceroy who welcomed him first with imprisonment and eventually forced him to exile in Paris. But before his ultimate exile, Seyxas attempted to gain the favor of the viceroy with the dedication of a book *Piratas y contrabandistas de ambas Indias, y estado presente de ellas*. This tactic had proven fruitful in the past (after all, it was the basis for the favor of Los Vélez) and he knew the viceroy and the marquis had common interests. Unfortunately for

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Seyxas, the book did not have the anticipated effect and he was forced to flee, first to Peru, and finally to France.

In the following pages, this article will examine how Seyxas failed to perpetuate his ties to the political network of Velez and Galve, and how such a failure is tied to the way the transoceanic passage reshapes even close political networks of a priori allies. In order to do so, we will analyze the works of Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, and the aforementioned Francisco de Seyxas y Lovera, as they intertwined their careers with the political network and naval agenda of The Marquis of Los Vélez (President of the Council of the Indies), and the Count of Galve (Viceroy of New Spain) between the 1680s and 1693. Through the examination of Sigüenza y Góngora's and Seyxas y Lovera's works and documents, this article analyzes how their maritime knowledge is utilized by these men as they insert themselves into the imperial project of Spain's naval authority. The present examination of their works and careers diverges from previous studies on both Mexican and peninsular Baroque literature that relied on a center-periphery model constrained by land-based models. Rather, these texts constitute a body of maritime narratives that act as a commentary on *hydro-power* in which New Spain is not peripheral but central to the Spanish imperial project and exercises political pressure over Madrid's court from a position of hemispheric dominance based on the fundamental oceanic nature of the empire and the needs and dynamics of such structure.

The study of these texts within a network of literature and scientific works on both sides of the Atlantic allows us to map out connections otherwise obscured by compartmentalized studies on the period, and to foreground the role of sailors such as Seyxas y Lovera, by "acknowledging the sailor" as Hester Blum says in "The Prospect of Oceanic Studies," over the traditional portrait of Spanish colonial agents and works as exclusively land-based subjects of study. These authors constitute a case study in which we not only have the opportunity to observe how expert individuals utilize their maritime knowledge for their own benefit as they engaged in the imperial system of *camarillas* and other political networks but also, such as in the case of Seyxas y Lovera, how the crossing of the Atlantic changes the fate of the individuals involved and the way the network itself operates across the ocean. Their stories show how an oceanic expansion not only shapes communications, but frames interests, imposes limitations and reorganizes alliances based upon a multitude of institutions whose common thread is the maritime nature of their power: the Viceroyal seat

as point of articulation between the Indies and Spain, the powerful influence of the chair of the Council of the Indies as head of the naval structure, sailors as validating authorities and producers of imperial knowledge, and the economic support of the maritime guilds known as *consulados*. In sum, a corpus of works previously isolated by a landlock gaze emerges as a collection of naval authority, a series of literary works like ships of a paper armada, that reshapes our understanding of Spain as an oceanic empire.

Political Actors: Infantado, Galve, and Los Vélez

In his edition for Sigüenza y Góngora's *Infortunios de Alonso Ramírez*, Fabio López Lázaro used archival documents to prove not only the veracity of *Infortunios*, but the role of the Count of Galve, Viceroy of New Spain, in the genesis of its publication. According to the documents unearthed by López Lázaro, the key to understand the reasons behind the publication of the account is the relationship between three members of the Spanish nobility: the Duke of Infantado, the Marquis of Los Vélez, and the Count of Galve. This political network is of vital importance to understand the maritime narrative constructed in the works of Sigüenza and the trajectory of Seyxas as he moved from Spain to New Spain and ultimately to France. Such networks were not limited by the constrictions of the royal court in Madrid or the Iberian Peninsula but extended across the ocean and used their temporary seats of power to advance their collective agendas. In Regina Grafe's words, in "On the spatial nature of institutions and the institutional nature of personal networks in the Spanish Atlantic":

> The study of Atlantic networks has also transformed how historians understand […] the Hispanic World. […] Spain's kings ruled through networks of royal administrators and contacts in urban, ecclesiastical and corporate bodies. The "King's Men" were the faces of a polity that had yet to become a fully sovereign state. Their immersion in local society turned them into the point of contact between powerful elites in historic territories and Viceroyalties in the Americas and Europe on the one hand, and the Monarchy on the other. The role of these individuals and their personal networks went far beyond the purely administrative. They advanced funds to implement royal policies from naval construction to military levies. (2)

These networks had not only a self-enrichment goal but more often than not they had a legitimate interest in serving the monarchy, and the well-being of the empire. Their actions were frequently costly to the individuals and their families, since they had to spend their own money and resources to implement different policies. We must be cautious to assume that their only goal was to benefit personally from their administrative positions.

The three men at the center of this network (Infantado, Vélez, and Galve) collaborated to boost naval reinforcements, as well as to convince the king to be cautious with their new British ally in their common efforts to curb French expansionism (López Lázaro 23–24). The Duke of Infantado (April 24, 1649–August 15, 1693) was the king's *sumiller de corps* from 1687 to 1693, as well as head of the Council of State from 1691 to his death. His unmediated access to the king allowed him to position his younger brother, Gaspar, the Count of Galve (January 11, 1653–March 12, 1697) as Viceroy of New Spain between 1688 and 1696, with "an early secret extension for a second term, a sign of preferential treatment" (Hidalgo Nuchera, my translation). Finally, Fernando Joaquín Fajardo de Zúñiga y Requesens, the VI Marquis of Los Vélez (1635–November 2, 1693) was the head of the Council of the Indies from 1685 to his death in 1693, and from his post, the marquis exercised an extraordinary influence in the imperial politics and projects such as fiscal reform, and military efforts in the American territories.

To magnify their cautionary tale against a close collaboration with the English monarchy against the French in the Caribbean, these noblemen did not limit themselves to the usual channels of personal favors and the positions of authority they held but they relied on the textual production of at least two authors (Sigüenza and Seyxas), and the distribution of such works at the court. Both Sigüenza and Seyxas were direct agents of Galve and Vélez, respectively, and participated in a mutually beneficial relationship in which the textual production was exchanged for favors and monetary retributions from their patrons.

Political Agendas and Court Writers

Rolena Adorno argues that "the lettered city is a labyrinth of relationships, dominations, subordinations, and collaborations, both external and internal" ("La *ciudad letrada*" 23, my translation). These relationships constituted the essence of a *clientelar* network in which families and lineage expand beyond the limits of blood bonds.

In *Familias, élites y redes de poder cosmopolitas de la Monarquía Hispánica en la Edad Moderna (siglos XVI-XVIII)*, the editors, Antonio Jiménez Estrella, Julián J. Lozano Navarro, and Francisco Sánchez-Montes González defined these extended "families" as a mirror that reflected society's contradictions and hierarchies "linked not only by blood but by others -of clientele, alliance, friendship, or patronage- in which the common interests used to trump those of the individuals" (1, my translation). Personal relationships established between patrons and their proteges were also intertwined with bigger family dynamics and networks, which connected actors such as Sigüenza or Seyxas not only to Galve and Velez but to each other. Both Sigüenza and Seyxas displayed similar strategies in order to establish a client relationship with their patron. They wrote books and dedications in such books to attract and maintain a sustained link with the colonial and court authorities. And both individuals succeeded in creating a mutually beneficial interaction where they exchanged favors and services within a frame of political collaboration.

But before we analyze how Sigüenza and Seyxas benefited, succeeded, and fell in disgrace within this political network, it is important to establish that the influential power the two patrons had came from their position both among the court and the territories where those posts were established. This idea is based on two fundamental concepts: the vision of Spain as a polycentric monarchy; and the idea of maritime state or network of individuals and institutions that operated with the goal of reinforcing the state's authority over the maritime landscape. This work also extends such interconnectedness and decentralization to the use of the colonial and baroque archive, and seeks to break the nation-state compartmentalization of the archive which has made the imperial archive less visible and has hindered our access to sociopolitical structures and dynamics of the past.

Traditionally, the Spanish monarchy has been seen either as a compound monarchy (under John Elliott's model) or as a system marked by a dynamic center-periphery based on the dichotomy between metropolis and the colonies. Elliot bases his model in the juridical theory of the time as described by Juan de Solozano Pereira in XVII, for whom there were two ways to annex a territory: the accessory union (with equal rights and laws across territories) or the "aeque principaliter" union in which the territory maintained a separate identity and "se esperaba del rey, y de hecho se le imponía como obligación, que mantuviese el estatus e identidad distintivos de cada uno de ellos" [it was expected, in fact it was imposed to him as an obligation, that the king would maintain the status and distinct

identity of each territory] (Elliot 33–35). On the other hand, the center-periphery model emphasizes the socioeconomic aspect of the territorial relationships, and the centralizing dynamics of the European monarchies, based on the supposition that those non-central territories existed in a servile and underdeveloped position in relationship with the European territories and those closer to the central courts. Both models have also cohabited with national histories based on the idea that contemporary nations have roots in their colonial past and their history can always be explained as a result of a dialectical process of national identity formation in constant struggle with the colonial center.

The polycentric model, as explained by Pedro Cardim, Tamar Herzog, José Javier Ruiz Ibáñez, and Gaetano Sabatini in *Polycentric Monarchies: How Did Early Modern Spain and Portugal Achieve and Maintain a Global Hegemony?* proposes the existence of "many different interlinked centers that interacted not only with the king but also among themselves, thus actively participating in forging the polity. Rather than national, proto-national, or 'colonial,' they were multiterritorial." The different centers competed with the central court but also among themselves and collaborated with each other to advance different policies. It is this polycentric model that provides a solid base to understand Galve and Vélez's network since they sat in two of the most influential courts of the time. México was not simply a stepping-stone in somebody's career but a place of power on its own right that allowed these men to influence the king.

The polycentric model also explains the difficulties Seyxas had to transplant himself from Madrid to Mexico despite his links to the powerful and Galve's ally, Vélez. As explained by Regina Grafe, the Spanish administrative structure was not of a pyramid or a chain of command where Oruro authorities followed the Potosi Audiencia, who followed Lima's viceroy, all the way to the councils in Madrid: "Officials at all levels and in all branches of the administration were involved in initiating, discussing, assessing and occasionally refusing to apply […] decrees."(3) Although Seyxas's appointment was the making of the Marquis of Los Vélez, the viceroy is not predisposed to yield an inch of his authority in the region. María Pilar Gutiérrez Lorenzo already saw Galve's rejection of Seyxas as an example of the opposing interests of Madrid's court and the viceroys (109). Such resistance wasn't motivated by personal profit, instead, as we will see in future sections, the appointment of Tacuba endangered Galve's tax-collection strategy to finance their maritime agenda.

This analysis also relies on the notion of the maritime state as coined by Marcus Rediker and Peter Linebaugh in *The Many-Headed Hydra: Sailors, Slaves, Commoners, and the Hidden History of the Revolutionary Atlantic*. Rediker and Linebaugh maintain that there is a process of reaffirmation of authority and systematization of state control over the maritime structure which is, according to the two historians, revolutionary at its core. Setting aside revolutionary interpretations of the maritime communities, the concept of the maritime state as an internal and external mechanism of power and control can be very useful to understand other processes of power consolidation like the one illustrated here while it also allows us to escape traditional portrays of the Spanish monarchy as defined by a landlock mentality. In *The Lettered City*, Ángel Rama presented the idea of the Latin American cities as organizational centers. But it has passed almost unnoticed how Rama linked the cities' power to their position within the transatlantic system and ultimately a maritime organization and not as a land-based stratification since for Rama, the American cities' order of influence was based on their stronger or lesser ties to the transoceanic power, with viceroyal courts followed by the port cities in the fleet circuit (18). It was their coastal location, their role in the naval organization, and the links with the armada that gave the different lettered cities a higher or lower position in the hierarchy of the empire. Sigüenza and Seyxas participated in Galve and Velez's efforts to consolidate this Spanish maritime state. The radical difference between the British maritime state as defined by Rediker and Linegbaugh, and that of the Spanish monarchy is that the Spanish model is based on a polycentric system of influential centers in which New Spain's viceroyalty had a significant role in their attempts to finance, reconfigure, and consolidate Spanish maritime power in the Atlantic.

According to López Lázaro, Galve showed in his letters, a particular attention to the coasts which he described as "the bridges connecting His Majesty's disparate dominions" (18), and "[he] was particularly concerned for the welfare of the coastal inhabitants of his jurisdiction, New Spain, who had suffered repeatedly at the hands of brutal pirates for two generations" (19). Galve was not only a victim of one such attack on his way to New Spain but was also greeted at his arrival with reports of the most recent attacks such as the one to Veracruz in 1683. Galve applied himself with zeal to the coast's protection (through an increase of patrols, a redistribution of the fleet budget, and fortification efforts), to the point that he gained praise from the court (and there is no doubt his brother in Madrid

as well as Vélez made sure it reached the king): "I am grateful for your dedication to dispatch the *galeotas* [small galleys] that serve as Veracruz coast guards, to accompany the frigate that you charter and raid the coasts of Honduras which are infested with pirates" (AGN 4349/51, Reales Cédulas duplicadas, vol. 39, 58r/60r.). This new attention to the re-articulation process of the Spanish control over its coasts and sea routes is of importance to counterbalance traditional visions of the Spanish empire as an eminently landlocked empire, and a tendency to forget the role of the fleet, sailors, and maritime law, as well as the truss of cosmographers and other officials involved in naval knowledge and operations. Maritime *letrados* [lettered men, aka liberal professionals] such as Seyxas y Lovera, and Sigüenza y Góngora participated in the textual production and expanded the lettered city beyond the limits of its neighborhoods, to the foaming coast and the ships' rocking decks. To reconstruct the Spanish maritime state is to move away from the canonical narratives of the imperial centers, and to retrieve the contributions of those individuals that formed the maritime state and operated beyond the viceroyal hallways.[1]

The Rise of Sigüenza y Góngora

The biography and work of Mexican polymath, Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora (1645–1700), have been widely explored in colonial and baroque studies. Despite the extensive work done on this figure, two aspects have been minimized in his career: the importance of his position as Royal Cosmographer and his relationship with Viceroy Count of Galve between 1688 and 1696. In this section we will explore how his position as Royal Cosmographer and his relationship with Galve significantly marked his textual production.

Throughout his life, Sigüenza sought out many positions of privilege to ensure his and his relatives' well-being. As part of his career he managed to be ordained into the secular clergy, named chaplain of the Real del Amor de Dios hospital, and he was appointed to the chair of Mathematics and Astrology at the University of Mexico from 1672 to his retirement in 1696. Even though, in *Infortunios,* Sigüenza famously complained that these positions carry more reputation than money (59), the chair provided him a salary and served as a stepping-stone in his public service career while giving him access to additional sources of income such as the position of University's Bursar, and the title of Royal Cosmographer in 1680 (Trabulse 67). Sigüenza y Góngora aspired to and maintained clientele

relationships with several powerful individuals in New Spain, mainly the Bishop Francisco de Aguiar y Seijas, and two viceroys: the Marquis of la Laguna, and the Count of Galve. In *Don Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, A Mexican Savant of the Seventeenth Century,* Irving Leonard stated that "of Sigüenza's relationships with the various viceroys there is little direct evidence available but there can be little doubt that they were cordial. […] To the Conde de Galve he seems to have been especially devoted and to have enjoyed the most intimate association with him" (39). Irving's analysis is common among those who have looked at the relationship between Galve and Sigüenza. While acknowledged, studies on the Mexican savant have always fell short in weighing the enormous impact that the collaboration between both men had on the body of texts produced, printed, and that have survived among Sigüenza y Góngora's production. Galve was the Maecenas and commissioner of *Infortunios*, *Trofeo*, *Relación*, and *Mercurio*, as well as the manuscript of the "Nueva demarcación de la bahía de Santa María de Galve."[2] Through this relationship, Sigüenza took part and influenced imperial policies in New Spain, giving his expert opinion on hydrological infrastructure, social engineering, native American control, military power in the region, and geographical information.

Despite Sigüenza's previous accomplishments, the arrival of the Count of Galve marks the most fruitful stage of his life. Of the 17 surviving works, 6 are a direct product of this collaboration. Nevertheless, to this date, the relationship between the writer and the viceroy has been consistently ignored or undervalued. Jacques Lafaye in "Don Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, cortesano y disconforme" briefly mentions the nature of *Infortunios* as a novel or a biography inspired by charity toward Alonso (14), but leaves out the role that Sigüenza himself attributes to the viceroy: "Since when the protagonist told it extensively, and gave, your excellency, pleasantries to your ears, now that I bring it to your eyes, how can I not receive similar attention?" (*Infortunios* 1–2, my translation). Lafaye turns the otherwise courtier act of writing as a service into an example of creole solidarity in the same way others like Lorente Medina or Carmen de Mora have tried to portray the Mexican author.

This consistent failure to acknowledge the depth of Sigüenza and Galve's relationship appears in other highly referenced works such as *The First America: The Spanish Monarchy, Creole Patriots, and the Liberal State, 1492–1867* (1993), where David Anthony Brading portraits Sigüenza's work as a failure of Mexican protonationalism, and relegates these works to the category of "pamphlets, prompted by public commemorations,

polemic or official commission" (363), and dismisses the collaboration between both men to a one-directional patronage: "he was favored by the Count of Galve […], who financed the publication of several of his works" (363). This selective gaze at Sigüenza's works was also the approach of Kathleen Ross in *The Baroque Narrative of Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora*, where she focuses on the *Parayso Occidental* as an example of a supposed specifically criollo subjectivity and local interests, but turns a blind eye to the viceroyal patronage and the imperial agenda in Sigüenza collaboration.

As previously mentioned, Antonio Lorente Medina also sees in Sigüenza a criollo solidarity in *La prosa de Sigüenza y Góngora y la formación de la conciencia criolla mexicana* (1996), but the author does analyze with certain attention the relationship between Galve and Sigüenza. Lorente echoes a certain disappointment among Mexican canonists that called Sigüenza a "collaborationist" but attempts to redeem the writer by proposing that Sigüenza's work for the viceroy was marked by Galve's ability to "interesar patrióticamente a Sigüenza en sus actividades" [interest Sigüenza patriotically in the Count's activities], out of common interest and the admiration that the criollo may have had toward the "muestras de piedad que el conde de Galve dio en sus primeras actuaciones públicas" [public displays of piety that the Count of Galve showed in his first public appearances] (122).[3] By framing the relationship in these terms, Lorente offers a totalizing interpretation of Sigüenza's work as a deliberate project of criollo conscience building severed from the contingent relationship or collaboration with the viceroy (201).

Finally, Anna More, in *Baroque Sovereignty: Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora and the Creole Archive of Colonial Mexico* (2013) proposes a new concept of the Baroque literary body as responsible for the creation of an archive of baroque sovereignty that seeks to cement local sovereignty beyond the Spanish imperial frame. More's work reconciliates Sigüenza's scientific, historical, and more literary works under an overarching archive and sovereignty-building effort. Although she does not address directly the relationship between Sigüenza and Galve, I will argue that, in light of the dynamics discussed in this chapter, her argument for these works as creators of local sovereignty is not incompatible with parallel efforts to reinforce imperial discourse as seen here. The search for stability that More ascribes to Mexican criollos such as Sigüenza can be also translated into a hybrid model in which local authority and imperial force coexist within the polycentric monarchy.

In order to understand how Sigüenza's work connects to the political network of Galve and Vélez, we must look at *Infortunios de Alonso Ramírez*, the true keystone in the collaboration between Galve and Sigüenza. In his study of *Infortunios*, Fabio López Lázaro was not only able to trace the movements of the real Alonso Ramírez, but the political impulse that prompted the publication of the narrative. López Lázaro attributes the inconsistencies of the story to a double purpose: an attempt to obscure Alonso's real identity by his own initiative (and therefore avoid a piracy sentence)[4] and to facilitate the story's use as a political tool in Madrid's court. The archival document that supports this argument is a letter which López Lázaro found in the Nobleza section of the National Archive of Spain, in Toledo (AHN Osuna ct. 55, d. 61). The letter, dated July 1, 1690, was sent by Galve to Infantado, his brother, and describes the genesis of *Infortunios*:

> My dear brother, […] attached to this letter you will find twenty [printed] relations of the voyage [of] Alonso Ramírez […]. I have had it published so that many copies can be forwarded to You in the eventuality that You should desire to distribute it amongst our friends, for I have only remitted it to the Marquis of Vélez. (López Lázaro 6)

This document proves that Sigüenza's prologue is not a literary device designed to give the narrative a veil of truth but an accurate report of the events leading to *Infortunios* publication. Galve ordered Alonso Ramírez to testify in the court, and after hearing his testimonial, commissioned Sigüenza to write it down. Then, the count procured the printing of several copies and sent them to Madrid to be distributed by his brother and the Marquis of Los Velez, and serve as propaganda to influence the court in their favor. *Infortunios* emphasizes the threat of European piracy at a transoceanic level. European piracy in the Pacific was relatively new and *Infortunios* served as a cautionary tale on the new perils faced by the Philippines and Asian routes (Lopez Lazaro 21). Piracy would greatly damage the crown in general and New Spain in particular, as the viceroyal region was the articulating center between the Pacific and Atlantic routes. Finally, as pointed by López Lázaro, *Infortunios* may have served to support tax-collection efforts since the text legitimates Alonso Ramirez's shipwreck as a legal salvage. According to López Lázaro, the version of the story that effectively receives the sanction of the viceroy by way of its printing hides the real possibility that Ramirez was in reality a pirate

himself and not a captive, and that the ship that he ultimately used to return to Mexico was a ship originally captured by pirates (35–46). By accepting Ramirez's version, the viceroy granted the sailor a way out, but also made it possible for him to claim legal dibs on its cargo: "Galve protected Ramírez from local prosecution for piracy and contraband because he cared more for the fortunes of the king of Spain's monarchy than for the legalities of the king of Siam's treasure," to whom the ship cargo would have been returned otherwise (85). López Lázaro concludes that "Galve needed bronze for guns [...], so he saved a Puerto Rican who collaborated with pirates from a legal downfall for a higher purpose" (85). As we recontextualize *Infortunios* within a frame of maritime policies and relationships, the text becomes a map of maritime imperial relationships between the sailor/pirate that seeks to escape imprisonment, the state's learned cosmographer, and the official that seeks to strengthen his influence from one court to the other. By returning this story to its maritime context, López Lázaro reveal us that *Infortunios* is a tool of political influence designed to advocate for maritime authority in the region and to provide a legal argument for the seizure of specific resources.

This new reading of *Infortunios* invites us to take a second look at other works by Sigüenza, particularly those produced "by special orders from the excellent lord Count of Galve" (*Obras históricas* 77),[5] for which the paratextual sections are of vital importance: prologues, dedications, licenses, and imprimatur. These texts reveal an effort to serve the imperial agenda as part of Sigüenza's position and ties to the court. Sigüenza himself saw his literary work as a service to the crown as stated in his *relación de méritos* [merits account] preserved in the Indies Archive in Seville where he lists his works as a service under the orders of "the viceroys and the university," and includes in the same category his books of religious topics as well as his "histories on the victories gained by the Spanish Crown in the Indies," inferring that his work is of great interest to the crown and his presence in New Spain court would be "of much interest to the King" (Laske 121–22). Sigüenza does not discriminate his work based on the themes he covers but values them as a whole and presents them as a service to the crown, particularly those that echo—maritime—victories in the Indies.

Infortunios marks an intense collaboration between Sigüenza and the viceroy. In the next two years he produces all his work for Galve. In 1691, he produces *La relación de lo sucedido a la Armada de Barlovento* [Account of the events of the Windward Armada] and *El Trofeo de la justicia*

española en el castigo de la alevosía francesa [Triumph of Spanish justice in the punishment of French treachery] covering Windward Armada operations against the French settlements in La Española (nowadays Haiti and Dominican Republic), and the Port of Guarico in particular. Although the attack did not have a lasting effect on the control of the region (forcing a new operation in 1695), for Sigüenza, it was of vital importance, since it took place in the zenith of the viceroy's political campaign and it resulted in the capture of four ships that reinforced the available forces in New Spain.

Sigüenza was aware that the viceroy's lack of physical presence in the naval operation required a constant reminder to the readers that Galve was the mastermind and ultimate artificer of the operation. Therefore, he made sure the reader knew from the very first page that the victory resulted from the "influxo, y providentísimos órdenes del excelentísimo señor D. Gaspar de Sandoval, Cerda, Silva, y Mendoza, conde de Galve, virrey, gobernador y capitán general de esta Nueva España" [influence and providential orders of the most excellent lord D. Gaspar de Sandoval, Cerda, Silva, and Mendoza, Count of Galve, viceroy, governor and general captain of this New Spain] (203). The text also reminds us of his commanding role by describing how the naval officers ceremoniously opened his orders, "handed by his excellency himself to the General" (211). Furthermore, Sigüenza underscores how the success of the military operation is providential, and so is the viceroy, whose actions "necessarily have to be correct, because his piety does not allow him to fail" and they are divinely inspired (207). Sigüenza also makes clear that the goal is to exalt the viceroy in both courts, so people would "admire him not only in Mexico City, but even in the most distant provinces" despite Galve's limited resources (207). Such admiration must reach the Mexican public but also the distant provinces. Knowing how the viceroy had Madrid court in mind, it is remarkable how Madrid is thrown in the basket of "distant provinces" and highlights how both courts are each other's peripheries in a polycentric model.

Sigüenza is also aware that these texts do not and cannot exist in a vacuum but as part of a program of propaganda: "justo es se publiquen, a beneficio de la imprenta, los que ya digo, para que se nos dé ocasión el año siguiente de referir otros que sean mayores" [fair is that they should be published, to benefit of the printing market, these episodes, so there would be occasion next year to refer other that would be greater] (208). This programmatic awareness is proven with the publication of the *Trofeo*

some months later, a text that reinforces the notion that Galve's successful policies have stabilized the region.

The *Trofeo* is not just a copy of the *Relación* but extends the propagandistic program by incorporating the latest military operations in Carolina, Texas, and an operation against pirates in Términos. Términos is particularly important because it demonstrates the need for a permanent fleet in the area and not the seasonal presence of the Windward Armada: "Determined his excellency to expel the pirates from the area" and "gave orders to activate two *galeotas*, a *falua*, and some war canoes in Veracruz" (182–183, my translation). Once again, we see a reflection of Galve's agenda. These *galeotas* of Veracruz, functioning as patrols and coast guards, would be of importance in the following years, and, as mentioned early, they will even earn Galve the praise of the king once more on February 10, 1693. Sigüenza mentions these ships not only because of their importance to the count's agenda but because Galve charted them without royal approval, although it was retroactively authorized.[6]

As royal cosmographer, Sigüenza traveled with the fleet that mapped Santa María de Galve Bay (aka Penzacola) on May 15, 1693 (Rodríguez-Sala 56). The expedition was part of a bigger project to establish a new fortification in the area and Galve joined these efforts in 1689. This project shows the internal division of Madrid's court that Galve and his group faced, since only one member in the Council initially supported the project, while the main politician against it argued that "England, France and the Netherlands didn't constitute a threat to the Mexican territories" (Rodríguez-Sala 4). The Bay fortification was therefore an example of how the two factions in the councils were divided along the issue of the foreign presence in the Americas. Nevertheless, with the approval of the fortification in March 1691, Galve's party demonstrated the importance of their respective positions of power when the king, convinced by their allies, gave his consent to the project. The expedition was meant to cement the information needed for the fortification and Sigüenza made sure to include in his report the arguments already laid out by Galve's faction: that if not for the Spaniards' defense, other foreign nations would establish themselves in the area of the bay to the detriment of the Spanish control over the whole region (Rodríguez-Sala 8).

Even when Galve was not particularly involved, Sigüenza did not miss the opportunity to introduce him in his narration, as in the case of the *Mercurio Volante* (1693) which describes the expedition of Diego de Vargas y Zapata and Lujan Ponce de León to New Mexico in 1692.

Sigüenza attributes the printing of this text to the viceroy ("por especial orden del excelentísimo señor conde de Galve", [by special order of the most excellent lord Count of Galve] *Obras históricas* 77) and mentions him as part of the chain of command and omnipresent authority in the area.

In her study of *Parayso occidental*, Rolena Adorno asked what concept of a nation informed Sigüenza's writings. As we have seen, Sigüenza worked extensively on Galve's project of maritime authority. This effort does not sever Sigüenza's links to Mexico but emphasizes the role of New Spain as a center of political and economic influence of the empire.

Seyxas y Lovera, from Court to Jail

In July 1692, the Galician sailor and writer, Francisco de Seyxas y Lovera, crossed the Atlantic to take possession of his appointment as Mayor of Tacuba, arriving to Mexico City in January 1693. Seyxas, merchant sailor, privateer, and navy officer, was offered this appointment thanks to his ties to the Marquis of Los Vélez. Nevertheless, despite the political alliance between Vélez and New Spain's viceroy, the Count of Galve, Seyxas's trip to Mexico became a turning point in his lucky trajectory: from his arrival to New Spain, Seyxas faced an adversarial Galve who sent him to jail first and forced him to run away into exile later. But before he left New Spain, he attempted to appease the viceroy and gain his favor by dedicating a book to him: *Piratas y contrabandistas de ambas Indias, y estado presente de ellas* [Pirates and smugglers of both Indies, and present state of both]. Seyxas's attempt was based on a practice that had proven successful in the past (the very reason he was in Mexico was the several books he dedicated to Vélez) and he probably knew that Galve, as Vélez, had a use for individuals such as him and the viceroy was employing Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora. The similarities with Sigüenza are obvious since, like the Mexican, Seyxas wrote a multitude of nautical works, he dedicated them to a figure of authority (the Marquis of Los Vélez), and his work was compensated with different appointments and financial support within the administration.

In this last section, we will explore Seyxas's relationship with Vélez and what could have been the reason behind his failure to maintain a similar relationship with Galve. A close reading of some passages of *Piratas y contrabandistas* will show how this work, despite sharing some of the necessary features that aligned with Galve's and Vélez's political project, lacked

an understanding on the specific players in Mexico's node of the maritime state, and failed in its sociopolitical function with terrible consequences for the author.

From Sailor to Courtier Writer: Seyxas and the Marquis of Los Vélez

Francisco de Seyxas y Lovera (1646–1705) was a Galician sailor, in both merchant and war vessels formed in the vessels that travel between New Spain, the Philippines, and the coast of Africa, as well as in privateer ships in the North Sea. Although scholars such as Clayton McCarl in his edition of *Piratas* and Pablo Pérez-Mallaína in his introduction to *Gobierno militar y político del reino imperial de la nueva España* [Military and political government of the imperial kingdom of the New Spain] have worked to expand our knowledge of his life, it is far from clear how much we will ever know. On one hand, his origins and life did not leave a great deal of documents for us to study; and on the other hand, Seyxas himself gives contradictory information on the autobiographical fragments that he included in his works.

Around 1686, Seyxas moved to Madrid where he started courting members of the administration. Although he claims that he had already written and published several books by then in Ambers and Colonia, the first work we know about is the *Theatro naval hidrographico* [Naval and hydrographical theater] (1688). This is also the first instance where we see Seyxas specifically courting the Marquis of Los Vélez by way of the dedication: *Dirigido al Rey Nuestro Señor, en su Real Consejo de Indias, siendo presidente en él, el Excelentísimo Señor marqués de Los Vélez* [to the King our Lord, in his Royal Council of Indies, being president the Excelent Lord Marquis of Los Velez]. Furthermore, in the introduction, he appeals to the administration in seek of a favor, but also criticizes the lack of attention that the "good sailor" receives from the crown:

> Although here is barely any that esteems sailors and their works in this kingdom, there may be someone that would appreciate my work, especially when Kings, Princes, and Republics must esteem sailors and professionals in Geography, and cosmography […] In these times, you barely can find people that will dare to sail off the routs of the *Carrera*, which is a product of the lack of rewards of such work, and the little praise that good sailors receive. (*Theatro naval hidrografico A5–A6*)

Seyxas presents here a constant in his work: his books as a service to the crown that must be valued and rewarded on the basis of his practical experience; and it seems that it did receive some attention, since the *Theatro* printing costs were assumed by the Council of the Indies, and Seyxas will repeat this strategy several times. In fact, in the "Prologue to the reader" he also mentions that he has other three books pending for print: "Theatro general, y mercantil de los comercios navales" [General and mercantile theater of naval commerce], "Descripción geographica de la región austral magallánica" [Geographical description of the austral and magallian region], and "Atlas universal" [universal atlas]. According to McCarl, this "Theatro general, y mercantil" could be the DIG/II/1800_E manuscript "Theatro real del comercio de las monedas […]" (McCarl xxxi, n.60). This manuscript, dated in 1688, also calls for the attention of Vélez, as mediator between the Council and Seyxas. Although it is unclear what the role of the marquis on its conception was, Seyxas comes back to the idea of the unheard sailor, though this time to praise Vélez for listening to those expert subjects:

> I saw convenient to request [Vélez] mediation to transmit to Your Majesty what I have done in the past 21 months in this court […]; For all these reason, and knowing that the Marquis listens and comforts all who want to serve Your Majesty, I determine not to interact with any other about the work I have done. (McCarl 213–14)

Seyxas has great ability to praise his patron and to present him as the sole channel to Seyxas's knowledge, in a way that both benefit Vélez and himself. This prologue is a call to "be Heard" but also a declaration of loyalty because he has become determined not to service any other. In the eyes of Seyxas, it is a mutually beneficial relationship from which the marquis obtains vital information to his position.

Of the other two books mentioned in the *Theatro naval*, I concur with McCarl (230) that it is probably the *Taboas geraes de toda a navegaçaõ dividedas e emendadas* […], by Teixeira Albernaz, which Seyxas probably stole from Portuguese Archives in 1681, and to which he added an introductory note.[7] The last book mentioned, the *Descripción*, was printed under the title of *Descripción Geográphica, y Derrotero de la Region Austral Magallanica* in 1690, and in this text, Seyxas also dedicates his work to the marquis and aligns himself with Vélez's political goals and positions; the cautionary tale about foreign presence in the region, and the need to

reinforce the fleet: "For all these reasons, because they dared and dare to cross the magellian region to raid Peru […] your majesty must protect those territories and subjects and order to settle them again, to defend those and Peru's coasts, with a fleet" (McCarl, 229–31). This paragraph positions the *Descripción* as a geographical tool and a source for future naval operations to reinforce the imperial control over the strait, the protection of the Indies, and Peru. Seyxas presents his works as political tools and strategical sources of knowledge that help the marquis to attain his personal goals (and of those of his party) and benefit the realm. But as revealing as they are of how systematic Seyxas was in his pursue of a patronage relationship with the marquis, they do not guarantee that the Council men would have listened to Seyxas's pleas. We know that these types of works were often presented to powerful individuals and most of them never reached their intended audience or they were summarily dismissed. Fortunately, a few documents from the Archive of Simancas shed light into the fruits that Seyxas was able to reap from the marquis.

In September 1690, Seyxas wrote to the Council requesting the position of captain in the ship en route to Santoña for repairs.[8] As part of his petition he detailed that from 1683 to 1685 he was employed by the marquis of Los Vélez "assisted with some help," on the account of his past experience in the navy and the "several manuscripts" that he has offered to Vélez, and that the marquis "arranged the payment of the print run."[9] This letter sheds some light on the extent of Vélez's involvement by facilitating the publication of the *Descripción*, and economically supporting the residency of Seyxas in Madrid.[10] Accordingly, the Council decided to appoint Seyxas on the basis of his technical experience "as demonstrated by the works that he has distributed to the council," and with the goal of "incentivize him and occupy him in the navy"; although they ruled against the specific appointment he sought and they granted him instead a lower commanding role since he did not have proven practical experience. [11]

Despite his work for the admiral Gregorio,[12] in charge of the repairs at Santoña, Seyxas grew uneasy. He did not have a vessel under his command, yet this position produced some expenses and the salary was not enough to cover them. Therefore, Seyxas requested to be transferred to the fleet in Cádiz in 1691, mentioning also other books in preparations or ready to print for which he requested a raise.[13] Seyxas was granted the relocation but not the raise, and left Santoña. We do not know how Seyxas ended discarding Cádiz for Tacuba but it seems that on his way to Cádiz he found himself in Madrid around April where he got the appointment

for Tacuba (McCarl xxxii). Most probably, his presence in Madrid was serendipitous and he was able to gain the favor by an in-person plea to Los Vélez. In any case, he left Cádiz in July 1692, and arrived at México in October.

From the Court to Prison: Seyxas and the Count of Galve

Seyxas y Lovera officially held Tacuba's position between 1692 and 1694, when he renounced after several stays in prison and a tense relationship with Galve. According to Seyxas, Galve had a personal interest in positioning one of his own men in Tacuba (McCarl, xxxiii–xxxv), but it is more probable that Galve saw Madrid's mandate benefitting Seyxas as a lost opportunity to extract a much-needed revenue from the appointment to finance his naval operations. Despite the bad blood between both men, in 1693, Seyxas attempted to gain Galve's favor with an old trick of his: the dedication of the manuscript *Piratas y contrabandistas de ambas Indias, y estado presente de ellas*. Seyxas knew of Galve's relationship with Vélez, as well as the relationship that the viceroy maintained with Sigüenza y Góngora, since he had used *Infortunios* as a source for *Piratas*, [14] and based on previous experiences, he could have had hopes to ease the tensions with the viceroy and made himself a space as another writer at his service.

It is unclear if Seyxas wrote *Piratas* specifically for Galve or he had the manuscript already written when he arrived at Mexico (it could have been one of the works mentioned in his previous letter to the Council requesting his transfer to Cadiz), but he dated the dedication to the viceroy as April 28, 1693, and aspects of the text suggest that the current year was 1693 and the place of writing New Spain. Regardless of how much he had finished beforehand, in his dedication he also mimics some of the tactics he used with the marquis: "For the sole benefit of serving His Majesty […] is my duty as a subject to print these stories through the greatness of Your Excellency, so they will see the light, guided by Your Excelency's own bright knowledge" (3). As we can see, Seyxas mimics the dedication of the *Theatro Real del comerzio*, in which he declared his intention to communicate exclusively with Vélez. In this case, he trusts the distribution of his work to Galve with the additional effect of increasing the impact of both his work, and Galve's own "light." But he also states that he is

writing this book under the orders of "lords that govern the Council of the Indies" (4). As stated before by Pérez-Mallaína, it is unlikely that he had such orders and there are not documents that support it (16–17), but in any case, it does link this text to the Marquis of Los Vélez who governed the Council of the Indies. The dedication hence has a triple intention: to praise the viceroy, to establish a mutually beneficial relationship, and to remind him that they both are part of the same political alliance.

Unfortunately for Seyxas, the book did not accomplish what Seyxas expected. His inability to connect with Galve shows how Seyxas failed to adapt to a new geographical situation within the maritime state. While he was able to maneuver the intricacies of the naval authority around Spain, he does not understand that by transplanting himself into the Viceroyal court, he is now also in a different part of the maritime network with specific dynamics, and that the viceroy, despite being an ally of the Spanish court, is not naturally predisposed to favor him. Both courts operate in tandem, and the members of the political network collaborate on the maritime project, but their sides of the networks demand different dynamics.

A priori, *Piratas y contrabandistas* seems to align with the goals of Galve: to highlight the negative influence of foreign subjects in different regions of the empire, and how their presence undermines the legal legitimacy of the Spanish control over the Americas and the West Indies, all while denouncing the lack of technical knowledge of certain officials and the need for individuals such as himself to provide accurate information. *Piratas y contrabandistas* also shares with Sigüenza's work the attempt to contextualize the current maritime weakness through the careful review of the history of foreign incursions in the Spanish territories in the Americas. The similarities are such that *Piratas y contrabandistas* could be almost read as secondary literature to *Infortunios.* If *Infortunios* focuses in one episode of piracy, *Piratas y contrabandistas* is a monography that provides historical background on "the origin and permanency of pirates and smugglers in both indies" (9). This contextualizing effort, common to the works of both men, implies that they were aware of the political positions of their patrons' network.

Despite its efforts, the book was a failure. Seyxas ended up in exile and out of favor. It is possible that Galve never saw the manuscript, although Seyxas remained in Mexico one more year, but the book also fails to understand the nature of the maritime state and the needs of Galve in New Spain. In her thesis, Leonor Taiano Campoverde who doubts of Galve's imperial agenda and attributes Sigüenza's work to an attempt to clean the

viceroy's failures and image (337), interprets *Piratas* as an accusatory book of his corruption and ineptitude. On the contrary, the problem resides in Seyxas's inability to *read the room* of the political network he was in, and of the Mexican dynamics.[15]

According to López Lázaro, the relationship of Galve and Vélez was deteriorating since Vélez accused Galve of prioritizing American initiatives to the detriment of European strategies in a letter from March 1691 (164, n.5). Meanwhile, Galve had advocated to restructure the financial system of New Spain and give more control to the Viceroys over the naval operations (López Lázaro 48). In this context, Seyxas's mention to some reporting orders would have been perceived as an intrusion or even a sign of mistrust from Vélez. Moreover, Galve had plans to appoint somebody to Tacuba and the order from Madrid trunked his plans. This could have been an insult, but it was probably also an inconvenience since Galve was desperate for fiscal relief. In that same year of 1693, Galve ordered to oversee all "sellable" positions in the administration and strip of their jobs to those who lacked appointment letters.[16] With the new vacancies, Galve opened a new line of temporary revenue to finance local activities.

Seyxas also failed to understand another aspect of Galve's finances of his maritime plans: the consulates. *Piratas y contrabandistas* includes a section on commercial organization of the territories in which he decries the Spanish system of consulates in the tradition of *arbitrismo* (51). But Seyxas failed to understand or he was unaware of how Galve relied on New Spain consulates' support to take action and influence Madrid's court. As noted by Escamilla González y Mues Orts, Galve courted New Spain's merchants and even gave nobility tittles to some of them (184). His courtship was rewarded when in 1690, the consulate of Mexico collaborated with a hefty sum to combat piracy, donation that Galve was quick on reporting to the king and granted both the gratitude of the monarch.[17] Later, in 1693, Galve came back to the consulate to seek another donation for the fortification in the Bay of Santa María de Galve (Rodríguez-Sala 60), showing how the viceroy valued and understood the importance of this organization in the maritime state, and how much he relied on their collaboration. In this context, Seyxas's criticism only showcased his lack of understanding of how New Spain network operated.

Finally, Seyxas differs from Sigüenza in his defense of the expert subject. As we saw in the *Theatro* he did not shy away from stating that the administration was not paying the appropriate attention to the sailor whose expertise they needed at such dire extremes. In *Piratas*, he doubles

down on this issue when he complains of a lack of rigor in the enforcement of the law on both sides of the Atlantic (138), or corruption in customs (47), or the waste of certain resources such as ships under embargo in Cadiz (126), or a lack of navigational knowledge from the administrators (163), or the lack of experience of some appointed officials (56), but also the tendency of some to rely on theorists over the individuals with practical knowledge (156). These attacks although probably intended to show a common goal to Galve also were incredibly tone-deaf to the reality of the power that Galve or Velez yielded, which was contingent on the collaboration of every moving part. Furthermore, the last attack on the relevance of practitioners over theorists has almost a personal connotation, since looking at the differences between Seyxas and Sigüenza, it is easy to realize with whom each would identify.

In the *Theatro naval*, Seyxas had already complained about the "poco premio del trabajo, y de la poca estimación que se hace de los buenos marineros," but there is a fundamental difference between both works: time and place. When Seyxas wrote the *Theatro*, he was a suitor to the crown's favor, a courtier writer in the making; but in 1693, he had become a member of the administration that he criticizes. Furthermore, he not only changes geographically within the empire but also abandons the area of influence of his patron and becomes part of a new sphere of control. Seyxas was unable to adapt to the new game rules forced by the different maritime ecosystem and the influence of the consulate.

Conclusion

Sigüenza and Seyxas, Galve and Velez conformed a network of authority and textual production created with the common goal of reinforcing Spanish maritime state and the imperial control over the transatlantic routes and coastal regions to and around the American territories. Both authors were positioned in a geopolitical frame that was decentralized and in which the Viceroyalty of New Spain played a fundamental role. This political network, originally formed by individuals in the highest spheres of power, expanded beyond the two individual courts and attracted actors connected to the maritime state such as the cosmographer Sigüenza and the sailor Seyxas.

As a result, we witness how these individuals interacted through their texts and adapted (alas unsatisfactorily) to the changes imposed by the positioning of the centers of power within the maritime framework. While

Sigüenza y Góngora consolidated his position as imperial agent at the service of a maritime reinforcement agenda, Seyxas y Lovera complicates our vision of such networks with new levels of depth and contradictions. Their expertise as sailors and mathematical savants grant them a role in the political machinations of the nobility. By retrieving these connections, we acknowledge the sailor, the cosmographer, the privateer, the mathematician, and the writers, in sum, that participated in the construction of a political agenda aimed to change and reinforce the Spanish maritime state.

Notes

1. This textual production effort and narrative of urgency that Galve and Vélez distribute through the court is not an isolated case in the Spanish empire. In her intervention at Lasa 2019, María Ximena Urbina Carrasco highlighted the role that news and rumors had in pressing the court to reinforce the Spanish maritime power in the Chilean area. Urbina Carrasco defines this as a "mechanism of dynamism and influence to the court" and according to her, it explains why even though they were never heavily attacked, they benefited from military investments.
2. The complete title of the document is "Nueva demarcación de la bahía de Santa María de Galve (antes Panzacola) que por orden del exmo. Sr. conde de Galbe, virrey de la Nueva España hizo el año de 1693 don Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, cosmógrafo del rey, nuestro señor y su catedrático jubilado de Matemáticas de la Academia Mexicana." [New demarcation of the bay of Santa María de Galve (before Panzacola) that for order of the excellent lord Count of Galbe, viceroy of New Spain, made in the year of 1693, don Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, cosmographer of our lord the King, and his retired chair of Mathmatics in the Mexican Academy] María Rodríguez-Sala offers the archival reference: Real Academia de la Historia, Madrid, Colección Muñoz, Vol. 1, fols.116–134v; y en AGI, México, 617, documento 13 (Rodríguez-Sala 56).
3. Lorente Medina, in his 2017 edition of *Infortunios*, following López Lázaro and Buscaglia-Salgado, recognizes now Sigüenza's participation in the political agenda of Galve, although he just summarizes the arguments from both authors without revisiting the remaining of Sigüenza's works.
4. On the identity of Alonso Ramírez, López Lázaro has not found any document that proves the existence of an individual with that name, hence there is the possibility for the name to be a pseudonym. Nevertheless, José Buscaglia-Salgado has found the marriage certificate of an Alonso Ramírez with a Francisca Javiera Ribera de Poblete in the metropolitan cathedral of Mexico City, dated November 8, 1682. Buscaglia-Salgado maintains that

Ramírez is in fact a real name and that this individual from the marriage certificate is *Infortunios* protagonist (161).

5. Tittle page of the *Mercurio volante* in its facsimile edition in *Obras históricas* reads: ESCRIBIOLA | POR ESPECIAL ORDEN DE EL EXCELENTÍSIMO SEÑOR CONDE GALVE, | VIRREY, GOBERNADOR Y CAPITÁN GENERAL DE LA NUEVA ESPAÑA, |(Wrote it by special orders from the excellent lord Count of Galve, Viceroy, Governor, and General Captain of New Spain).
6. AGN 4349/9, 8r–8v.
7. Library of Congress, G1015.T4 1630, web.
8. AGS *Guerra y Marina*, Parte de Mar, Decretos, legajo 3799.
9. Ídem.
10. Another of Seyxas's letters specifically mentions 50 shields of silver per month, ordered by Vélez, and paid from the Council of Indies's own budget. (AGS *Guerra y Marina*, Parte de Mar, Memoriales y peticiones de partes, legajo 3799).
11. AGS *Guerra y Marina*, Parte de Mar, Decretos, legajo 3800. The appointment is also mentioned in AGS, *Guerra y Marina*, Libro de Decretos 414, páginas 156–57; As well as his salary of 30 shields, pg. 166–67.
12. AGS *Guerra y Marina,* Parte de Mar, Cartas, legajo 3804.
13. AGS *Guerra y Marina,* Parte de Mar, Memoriales y Peticiones de Partes, legajo 3815.
14. "Y del viaje de Alonso Ramírez parece expresamente que Vel y Donkin pasaron al Mar del Sur." [And from the travels of Alonso Ramírez it seems clear that Vel and Donkin crossed to the South Seas](McCarl 159). Leonor Taiano also notes that Seyxas confirms Ramírez's tale with his own experience as witness of the departure of Vel y Donkin ships from the London port, what would corroborate López Lázaro's thesis that *Infortunios* is based on real events (357). Independently of the veracity of Seyxas statement, this gesture proves that the Galician author gives a non-fiction status to Sigüenza's work and that, through the inclusion of the witness statement, he was establishing a reciprocal connection of authority argument and validation.
15. On the issue of accusations, *Piratas* actually throws a safe line to Galve when discussing the Mexican mutiny of 1692, and blames the insurrection of *indios* to the influence of the "great number of foreigners among the Spaniards" (137).
16. AGN 28642/4, oficios vendibles, vol. 10, 175–184.
17. AGN 23366/31, Histórico de hacienda (1ª serie), volumen 640, expediente 31.

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AGN Archivo General de la Nación
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CHAPTER 5

Imagining a Multi-Modal Digital Corpus of Early Modern Maritime Texts

Clayton McCarl

Introduction

In the introductory study to her 2018 edition of a text detailing the expedition of Hernando de Alarcón, Jimena Rodríguez points to the lack of critical attention that traditionally has been paid to nautical texts. She notes that such writings have been considered overly technical and therefore of limited interest (115). Rodríguez argues, however, that nautical texts are characterized by types of discourses that hold broad appeal, supporting her position with examples from the Alarcón narrative.

In this chapter, I seek to build upon Rodríguez's argument for engaging critically with maritime texts. I do so by imagining a model for a digital resource that could support the study of textual production related to Spain's overseas empire. This model sits at the intersection of corpus computing, scholarly editing, book history, and bibliography, and aligns with the "oceanic turn" (Winkiel 2) that has taken place in recent years across

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various disciplines. The tool that I imagine would facilitate the examination of both material and rhetorical aspects of maritime writing. It would allow users to discover nautical texts, interrogate them as discourse and data, locate them within the history of European publishing, and consider the role they play in the construction of the geographical, political, and ideological configurations of today's world.

In designing this model, I build upon several previous studies. In a recent book chapter ("Discourse or Data"), I suggested an approach to understanding certain types of textual objects as both linear objects and collections of randomizable data. In another study ("Hacia un modelo"), I proposed a model for the semantic markup of texts dealing with Early Modern European maritime expansion. Research for other projects ("Ghost Journeys," "Transmission"; Seyxas y Lovera) made evident to me the need for more scholarship on the publication and transmission of such texts.

This study is theoretical, not practical, in nature, and I therefore set aside all matters related to implementation. I do not discuss specific technologies, nor do I consider questions about resources. I likewise do not contemplate the issues around hosting, maintenance, and sustainability that digital projects necessarily face. I avoid such topics out of a desire for the texts and their circumstances, not pragmatic concerns, to shape the ideas expressed here.

I use the term *maritime texts* to refer specifically to works that recount voyages undertaken by sea, either as journals written during the expeditions or as narratives composed afterward. While the former category almost by definition consists of first-hand accounts, the latter could involve texts constructed from the observations of others. Both types are generally heterogeneous in nature, containing discourses that might be regarded variously as scientific, anthropological, autobiographical, and strategic.

As diverse as they may be, these writings generally share certain characteristics. They are, on a fundamental level, about movement through space and time, dimensions that are subject to both objective measurement and interpretation based on perspective and individual experience. They are also united by shared geographies that are, likewise, simultaneously reflections of physical realities and expressions of personal or collective imagination. They generally present themselves as authoritative narratives of events that are, in many cases, subject to dispute or contested by differing accounts.

Limiting consideration to such texts means omitting other types of writing that we might consider maritime in nature. These include official documentation related to the seafaring world, as well as historiographical works. Likewise, the criteria I employ here exclude writing that is primarily literary in nature, such as fictional narrative, theatrical works, and epic poetry dealing with the sea.

At the same time, another factor necessarily expands the hypothetical corpus outlined here. The Iberian maritime world was a space of competition and conflict, and as a result, the body of relevant texts is not composed only—or perhaps even primarily—in Spanish. Writing in French, Dutch, English, and other languages, Spain's maritime rivals produced much of the material that must be taken into account—texts that address the geography of the Spanish overseas world and document activities that shaped Spain's decision-making.

Oceanic Studies, Maritime Textuality, "Hydro-Imaginaries," and Digital Methodologies

In recent years, scholars have positioned the sea as a space from which to observe the forces that shape our realities in new ways. As Kimberley Peters and Philip Steinberg explain, this work is built on the idea that "the ocean provides a fertile environment for re-conceptualizing understandings of space, time, movement and experiences of being" (293). In such scholarship, according to Hester Blum, "the sea [is] central to critical conversations about global movements, relations, and histories" ("Introduction" 151). Work in this area—referred to variously as *Oceanic Studies*, *Hydro-Criticism*, and *Critical Ocean Studies*—cuts across disciplinary lines, engaging with diverse topics within the humanities, social sciences, and natural sciences. Hydrocolonialism is one important theoretical framework within this larger paradigm, analyzing—as Isabel Hofmeyr explains—processes of colonization by, of, or on expanses of water (*Dockside*, 15–16; "Provisional" 12–13).

Among the many areas of inquiry within Oceanic Studies, scholars have asked questions about relationships between the sea and written texts. Some have examined material aspects of the production of maritime texts, studying processes involved in writing, publishing, and circulation. For example, Blum considers the role of sailors as authors and the centrality of writing within the context of maritime labor ("Prospect" 671–672).

Hofmeyer examines possibilities for understanding the history of the book "in a hydrocolonial context" ("Provisional" 14–17), looking specifically at the role of government functionaries in "occasioning redefinitions of what the book could or should be" through their interactions with those objects in colonial ports (*Dockside* 15). Adriana Craciun considers "the convergence of exploration and book history" in the eighteenth century (170), and Adrien Delmas examines the policies of the Dutch East India Company regarding daily log-keeping and the textual genre that emerged. Fariha Sheikh studies the on-board periodicals that nineteenth-century British emigrants produced during the voyage to Australia.

Such work intersects with scholarship about the Spanish maritime world that predates Oceanic Studies as a field, or that has been produced by researchers working outside that paradigm. Irving Leonard's *Books of the Brave*, a canonical study from 1949 of the movement of books between Spain and the New World, examines the role of print culture in the conquest and colonization of the Americas. A more recent example is Idalia García's 2017 examination of the book trade between Europe and New Spain in the seventeenth century. Though not focused exclusively on writing at sea, Miguel Martínez's 2020 study of the authorial practices of soldiers in the Spanish empire necessarily connects with that topic.

The long tradition of bibliographic work on the Indies in Spanish also has a direct relation to contemporary work on nautical textualities. León Pinelo's *Epitome de la biblioteca oriental i occidental, nautica i geografica* (1629), generally considered the foundational text of Americanist bibliography, is a repertory of books about, or resulting from, Iberian expansion by sea. Later works that built upon León Pinelo include Andrés González de Barcia's expanded second edition of the *Epítome* (1737–1738), Antonio de Alcedo's *Bibliotheca americana* (1807), and—articulated from within an Anglophone tradition—Joseph Sabin's *A Dictionary of Books Relating to America* (1868–1927).

In addition to studying the connection between books and oceans in material terms, scholars have examined the role of the sea as a conceptual framework. In a recent collection edited by Laura Winkiel, the figurative realms built around the sea in cultural production are termed "hydro-imaginaries." As Winkiel asserts, the study of them reveals "how what we know about the oceans is partial, situated, and shot through with imagination and desire" (5).

Various scholars have considered the role of such imaginaries in the production and analysis of literature. Margaret Cohen has posited a

"literary studies on the terraqueous globe," pointing to "new paradigms and concepts of critical and cultural analysis" which, she argues, correspond to oceanic, or planetary, dimensions (658). Cesare Casarino has studied the role of the sea in prefiguring modernity in the works of Herman Melville, Joseph Conrad, and Karl Marx. Jimmy Packham and David Punter have applied such ideas in the analysis of Gothic poetry about the sea. L. Katherine Smith has read *Moby Dick* against the cartographic work that the US Exploring Expedition (1838–1842) carried out in the South Pacific.

Scholarship of this nature also addresses the Early Modern Iberian maritime world, though again, not necessarily under the rubric of Oceanic Studies. Leonard's *Books of the Brave* is relevant here also, as a study not only of the movement of books but their role in the imaginaries of conquest. In a recent article, Ana María Laguna looks at narratives of shipwrecks in the writings of Miguel de Cervantes. Joan Oleza has studied the role of maritime tragedies and the route to the East Indies in the work of Lope de Vega and Tirso de Molina.

Within both categories—scholarship on Early Modern maritime textualities and the rhetorical uses of the sea—work focused specifically on texts written during navigation or by navigators themselves is scarce. Instead, scholars have more commonly addressed works that are understood as literary in nature. Likewise, few studies address specifically these questions in relation to colonial Latin America, beyond the scholarship on prominent texts like the diaries of Christopher Columbus and the *Naufragios* of Álvar Núñez Cabeza de Vaca.

The study of Early Modern maritime textualities, therefore, represents an area of opportunity for Oceanic Studies. Nautical voyages and book publishing were intimately connected, with implications for geographically dispersed peoples. In the same way, examination of the Early Modern nautical imagination holds promise for Oceanic Studies, offering ways to discover how the sea has organized our understanding of the world.

From the perspective of colonial Latin American studies, in particular, the intersections between writing, publishing, and the maritime world are critical. As various scholars have emphasized, the Spanish empire was a fundamentally maritime enterprise. For Spain and its colonies, the physical, textual, and imaginative incursions of foreigners into that global space were matters of existential importance.

Likewise, the possible implications for Oceanic Studies of the Digital Humanities (DH) have gone largely uncontemplated, despite the

overlapping space occupied by these two areas of scholarly activity. Like Oceanic Studies, DH facilitates shifts in perspective, allowing us to access familiar scholarly topographies from new points of view. Both are invested in destabilizing traditional frameworks and generating new knowledge through shifts in critical approaches. Both grapple, furthermore, with the material and the abstract, seeking ways to reconcile and better understand both.

Oceanic Studies and DH can also be thought to converge on questions of potential scale. Scholars within Oceanic Studies frequently seek to make sense of vast spaces and unmapped, or unmappable, realities (Steinberg and Peters 260–261). Digital methods are particularly well suited to approaching work of such magnitude and impenetrability, facilitating ways to analyze and visualize large amounts of data and offering ways to impose order, identify patterns, and discover hidden narratives.

This project seeks to contribute to conversations within Oceanic Studies maritime textualities, the rhetoric of the Early Modern seafaring world, and digital methods. Many of the ideas are expressed from the perspective of colonial Latin American studies or Early Modern Iberian studies more generally. At the same time, they reflect concerns that correspond to other fields, as well as opportunities those areas might exploit.

A Typology of Corpus Tools

I am proposing the creation of a corpus tool, a type of resource that gathers texts united by some common factor. Such projects pursue ends that often involve analysis, transmission, and/or curation. Corpus projects have been a basic component of humanities computing for decades and were, in many ways, foundational to the field.

To establish context for the model I propose, I attempt here a typology of such projects. The categories I outline do not have clear boundaries and many projects fit into more than one, and some perhaps into none. I also discuss here some types of work that may not generally be referred to as *corpus projects.* These endeavors nonetheless meet the criteria I employ, as they bring together disparate items on the basis of some commonality, in order to facilitate the development of scholarly products.

In thematic terms, corpus projects frequently focus on writings that correspond to a particular time period or tradition based on such factors as nation, culture, or language. Some examples include Biblioteca Virtual Miguel de Cervantes, Corpus of Colonial Texts, Biblioteca Digital del

Pensamiento Novohispano, Nahuatl/Nawat in Central America, and Ticha: A Text Explorer for Colonial Zapotec. Others are organized around the life and work of a specific author or group of authors, like Biblioteca Digital Soledad Acosta de Samper, Delis Negrón Digital Archive, and Colección Escritos de Mujeres Novohispanas. Some endeavors focus on a specific category of text, such as Colección de Textos Caballerescos Hispánicos, and others on materials related to a particular event, such as A Colony in Crisis and Carlos Enriques Clerque and the Narborough Expedition (1669–1671) to Chile.

In the tradition of corpus linguistics, projects that assemble texts primarily for purposes of computational analysis often take language itself as a primary object of study. The Corpus Diacrónico del Español, for example, collects at least 250 million items for executing queries focused on lexical and grammatical matters (Real Academic Española). Endeavors of this nature may even gather materials that are not originally of a written nature, as is the case with the Corpus Oral del Instituto Caro y Cuervo (Rubio and Bernal).

Not all projects focused on computational analysis of texts are concerned principally or exclusively with the study of language itself. Instead, some are oriented toward developing data-based approaches to extracting meaning from written texts. Digging into Early Colonial Mexico, for example, seeks to design a new approach that can "facilitate the exploration, identification, and analysis of linguistic, semantic, geographic, and historical patterns in textual corpora at different scales" with the broad goal of changing "the way we study historical documents" (Murrieta-Flores et al.).

Other projects gather texts primarily to make them available and accessible, not to carry out machine-aided inquiry. They function as spaces in which to curate and disseminate published and unpublished writings, along with, potentially, other materials. These projects often include in their names the words "archive" or "library," terms that point to their purpose as repositories of texts and other resources, not necessarily data against which to run queries. They are often built primarily around processes of textual editing, and frequently involve the type of critical apparatus associated with scholarly editions.

Another type of corpus project may gather metadata and other contextual information about texts, without, in some cases, containing internally the full text of the objects themselves. Such endeavors are often focused on the material history of authorship and publication, including the

circulation of books. An example of such an endeavor is Primeros Libros de las Américas, which identifies digital facsimiles of books printed in New Spain in the sixteenth century, drawn from numerous geographically dispersed libraries and collections. Another is Catálogo Colectivo de Marcas de Fuego, which studies the firebrands used to indicate ownership in printed volumes in early New Spain and correlates those markings to items in institutions around the world. A third example is the Digital Bibliotheca Americana, which will present an interactive version of Sabin's *Dictionary*.

Discourse and Data

The model I propose would combine the three paradigms I have described. It would prioritize the creation of accessible, high-quality, reader-oriented texts, while also providing facilities for accessing those objects as repositories of information. In addition, it would incorporate functionality for exploring the publication history and larger bibliographic context of the writings.

In pursuing the first two objectives, this project would position texts as interrelated collections of discourse and data. This would, on the one hand, involve a large-scale editorial undertaking. It would also entail enhancing those editions with a structure of metadata to optimize their ability to be treated as collections of discrete bits of information. Creating such capability would require a process for identifying and isolating types of data that are shared among the constituent texts. In the case of maritime writings, many such categories of information exist. For the purposes of this study, however, I will consider a limited number: dates, names of places, and names of people and ships.

As writings that document movement, maritime texts usually emphasize chronology and duration of time. References to specific moments can be explicit and expressed in a variety of possible combinations, such as *month, day* and *year*; *month* and *year*; or *year* alone. Such allusions can also be implicit or indirect ("two days later," "the following month," etc.) but allow for a precise moment or interval to be calculated based on context.

In the same fashion, place names are an essential component of maritime texts. References can correspond to places that are canonical in the cartography of the era and that reference empirically verifiable places. They can also be names that are standard and commonly mapped, but that refer to places that are imagined ("estrecho de Anián," "Tierra Incógnita austral," etc.). They could likewise point to entities that the cartographic

work of the period never registered, and whose existence is in question, but which nonetheless comprise threads that run through various texts (e.g., "isla de la Roche").[1] As with dates, the references may not always be explicit—and thus invisible to a simple full-text search—such as would be the case of *viceregal capital* in place of *Mexico* or *Lima*.

The names of people and ships are also basic markers in maritime texts. They may point to the individuals and vessels involved in the journey being narrated, but also to earlier expeditions. In many cases, they refer metonymically to expeditions themselves. A mention of *Nao Victoria*, for instance, will often point to the voyage of Ferdinand Magellan and Sebastián Elcano (1519–1522), just as a reference to the *Golden Hind* will do the same with regard to the circumnavigation of Francis Drake (1577–1580). In a similar fashion, an allusion to Jacques l'Hermite will likely refer to the journey of the Nassau Fleet (1623–1626) and possibly the blockade of El Callao (1624) that occurred during that voyage.

By isolating and standardizing references to these items—dates, names of places, and names of people and ships—we could create opportunities for interrelating the texts on their points of contact. For instance, a user might query the corpus using a potential value or range of values within one of these categories, and use the results to find and navigate into specific documents. From within an individual text, each instance of one of these items could likewise serve as a node by which to identify and access other objects.

As an example, one might search with the term *Lima*, producing a list of texts that reference that city. This enumeration might be sortable by language, author's nationality, date of publication, the earliest or latest dates mentioned in the text, and other factors. That list might also show the frequency with which the search term appears in each text. By selecting an item, the user might then access an enumeration of the various instances of the term throughout the chosen work. The user might subsequently navigate into that text at any of those points.

Upon reaching another term—for the sake of this example, *Joris van Spilbergen*, the name of the Dutch navigator—the reader could then repeat the process described above, accessing a list of all the texts that mention that individual and view all instances within each. The reader could also take a higher-level look, accessing a list of all nodes within Spilbergen's journal. These would include all names of places, people, and ships, as well as the range of dates covered in that text, along with individual mentions

of specific dates. One might select *Philippines*, for instance, which would lead to another list of texts, again sortable on the basis of various factors.

Studying such intersections might offer ways to see individual texts from new perspectives. It could also help us to perceive more clearly the connections between objects across time. One might trace the relationships, for instance, among writings such as those produced by the expeditions of Magellan and Elcano (c. 1625),[2] Olivier Van Noort (1602), Jacques Le Maire and Willem Corneliszoon Schouten (1618), Bartolomé García Nodal y Gonzalo de Nodal (1621), Pedro Sarmiento de Gamboa (1768), Thomas Cavendish (1625),[3] and John Narborough (1695).

Such navigation via textual intersections is only one way we might exploit the possibilities that this metadata-enhanced canon would present. Indeed, while the largely serendipitous mode of reading I propose here may open new opportunities for discovery, other more deliberate analytical activities can be imagined. By applying various tools to the marked-up corpus, for instance, we might visualize the geography and chronology of the voyages narrated, and construct interfaces that allow users other options for navigating the corpus, such as through maps and timelines.

We could likewise undertake parallel readings of passages that have spatial characteristics in common. These could include multiple journeys that follow similar routes or that pursue common geographical objectives. We could examine the frequency with which places, people, and ships are mentioned across the corpus or in specific subsets of texts. We might also analyze the use of such terms over time, a process that could be useful in charting the influence of particular texts on others, as well as their imaginative geographies. We could study systematically the uneven relationship between physical space and narrative length in maritime texts, in which vast expanses can be transited in a matter of words or sentences, and movement across short distances can be detailed at great length.

Additionally, we could build a contextual apparatus for the corpus, establishing canonical entities for people and places, and providing standardized annotations for each. In the case of geographical references, these might reference contemporary maps. They might also refer to prose repertories, such as Alcedo's *Diccionario geográfico-histórico de las Indias occidentales* (1786–1789).

Beyond the simple semantic model established here, numerous other categories of information could be useful in analyzing maritime texts. Discourses of discovery and encounter, for instance, are often central to such texts. Passages that refer to contact with new geographies and

peoples might be isolated. Likewise, the presence of Indigenous terminology might be flagged, along with descriptions of non-European peoples and their traditions, or instances of their interactions with Europeans. Interrogating texts on the basis of such factors could facilitate new ways of thinking about languages and cultures in contact within the Early Modern maritime world.

Discovery and Context

The tool I envision would go beyond making maritime texts available as discourse for reading and data for computational analysis. It would also serve as a platform for discovering those texts, which generally are little known today. Likewise, this resource would help users to understand the authorship and publishing of those writings within European textual traditions.

This project would achieve the first of these objectives by allowing readers to identify texts by such factors as overall geographical focus or individual places mentioned, date or date range, language, and date of first edition. As a collection that crosses borders and languages, this tool would offer a transnational directory of such texts in the tradition of León Pinelo's *Epítome* and other works of New World bibliography.

This tool could interrelate texts on general characteristics, such as the geographical categories that León Pinelo and other bibliographers often utilized. It could also generate groupings through the more granular metadata with which the corpus has been enhanced. In an interactive fashion, the user could organize and filter the texts based on the values we have marked up.

We could also enable the identification and sorting of texts based on factors that relate more to their material history than their contents. We might, for instance, allow the user to identify all texts originally published in a specific place or within a particular range of years. This would involve making the texts findable on information beyond what is contained in the in-line metadata or in the full text of the items themselves.

Such information could form part of the bibliographical metadata attached to each text. It could involve standard fields, but also items that might be particular to maritime writings. For instance, an ability to sort texts based on the role of their author (captain, crew member, passenger, etc.) could be useful. The same is true of their type of sponsorship (private, private with state support, entirely government-sponsored, etc.),

their places of departure and return, the size of the expedition in terms of ships, people, etc. We might record the dates of the respective voyage separately from the date of first publication of the text, enabling us to ask questions based on the distance between those two points in time.

We could also include data that would locate the text within traditions of bibliographic practice. We might correlate each text to the corresponding entries in León Pinelo and Barcia, Alcedo, Sabin, and other repertories focused on the Americas, as well as in more general works. We could, likewise, note the absence of a given text in those collections.

By facilitating the discovery of texts based on both realms of information—full text and in-line metadata on the one hand, item-level bibliographical metadata on the other—we could enable the assemblage of texts based on at least two different types of connections. The first would be internal aspects, such as shared references to people and places. The second would be factors that are mostly external to the texts, dealing instead with the circumstances of their creation and existence as written objects.

In addition to such atomized metadata, this project could locate the writings within a larger context by providing a narrative explanation of each. This could be an additional element of the bibliographical data that would serve as a starting point for reading the texts and analyzing them in a computational fashion. That description could also provide an overview of the subsequent editions and translations.

Those later versions of the text could also be created as individual items within the project's internal data structure. This would allow a text to reveal, in essence, its own publication history, with the subsequent versions sortable on factors such as language, place of publication, and the manuscript or prior edition on which they are based. These records might refer to digital editions or facsimiles of the texts in question, as contained in other systems.

The project could additionally gather references to secondary scholarship about these texts. These items, too, could exist as a type of bibliographic record within the tool's internal system. In the case of items available electronically, those records could also refer out to the studies themselves.

In this model then, an object within the system would connect to others in various ways. Relationships could be established based on high-level bibliographic information as well as detailed in-line metadata. A text could also relate to any number of subsequent versions as well as to the scholarship that addresses it.

Through the creation of such functionality, this project would expand beyond being a resource constructed on the texts themselves. It would become a corpus of narrative objects, a repository of data that is internal to those objects, and a catalog of bibliographic items that contextualize and reveal much of the material history of those objects. This would, therefore, be a *multi-modal* corpus, allowing at least three different ways to approach the texts: as discourse, as data, and as objects within a larger bibliographic context.

Texts, Not Voyages

The resource I envision is a corpus of texts, not a catalog of voyages or a repository of facts. It would function as an instrument for considering specific writings in context and discovering what they reveal when viewed in aggregate. As a tool for understanding the maritime history of the era in a comprehensive fashion, however, this corpus would necessarily be incomplete. This would be true for a variety of reasons, but two stand out.

In the first place, not every voyage left the type of textual evidence I discuss here. In some cases, we may have texts that cover part, but not all, of an expedition. In others, there may be no such document at all.

Secondly, for some voyages we may face a different problem—having multiple, potentially conflicting accounts. In order to make assertions about historical fact, we would need to somehow account for such divergence. The problem goes further, as even for the voyages for which we have only one account, we cannot know that such versions can be regarded as veracious. This may be true even in cases in which the texts have served as the basis for the historiography of the expeditions in question.

We might remediate the first situation by inserting placeholders into the corpus that contain not textual material, but rather merely the randomizable data considered here: information about people, ships, places, and dates. These would be phantom records that would allow us to include voyages for which we do not have narratives. They would be, in a sense, an affirmation of what the texts would say, if they existed. We might even create such records in response to the second situation, providing an authoritative register of facts to reconcile any competing versions or provide a variant that reflects the historiographical consensus.

Such an approach, however, would be problematic in many ways. Most importantly, it would require us to insert ourselves into the textual record as arbiters of truth, both with respect to the facts of individual voyages and

the overall shape of a canon that does not completely exist. Rather than representing a realistic way to remediate the shortcomings of the corpus, the idea of creating such ghost data points to the essential instability of the corpus as a whole, as well as of the individual texts that comprise it.

This corpus, then, as well as the tools we might build to exploit it, would be limited in its ability to provide irrefutable information about the past. Such a circumstance might be seen to undermine the potential of this hypothetical project, but it also may highlight precisely the value such a model offers. Rather than positioning maritime texts as historical evidence, this project would instead bring them into focus as discursive acts. It would emphasize the way in which those objects are both self-contained and interrelated, and would provide a means of exploring, within a chronological and geographical framework, the rhetoric of the Early Modern maritime world.

Conclusion

My objective in this essay has been to imagine a tool for studying maritime texts related to Spain's overseas empire. I have envisioned a model built on processes of scholarly editing, data design and curation, and bibliographic research. The result would be a multi-modal paradigm that would allow users to approach such texts variously as pieces of discourse, repositories of data, and objects within larger histories of publication and dissemination.

Such a tool could present opportunities across many fields, and would hold promise in particular for scholars of colonial Latin America. The model described could facilitate the study of the individual texts, many of which are largely unknown. It could also create opportunities to understand these writings through their participation in an aggregate, interconnected corpus. Such a resource could bring new critical attention to the complex textual production generated in and about the maritime world during the period of Spain's colonial empire, an era of vast shifts in power and culture on a global scale.

The model in this study is articulated from within a space for imagination unrestrained by practical concerns. In reality, digital projects face a myriad of challenges that would urge us toward greater simplicity in scale and design. The goal of these reflections, however, has not been to outline a model that is unquestionably realizable, but rather to explore possibilities, as a way to discover new ways to think about, interact with, and value Early Modern maritime texts.

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Notes

1. For this example, see McCarl "'Tosco e imperfecto,'" pp. 151–157.
2. I refer here to the narrative by Antonio Pigafetta. For all texts mentioned here, I give year of first publication.
3. First printed in Purchas, vol. 1, pp. 149–185.

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CHAPTER 6

Alonso Ramírez's Circumnavigation of the World (1675–1689) and the Universal Claim to the American Spirit in the Open Seas

José F. Buscaglia-Salgado

> Neither do I know how a thing can be universally true when perhaps, as he states, it is falsified; nor am I able to fathom how he can employ it as a reason in an attempt to move my understanding when I used it as proof upon which to secure my opinion.
>
> Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora's response to Eusebio Kino, *Libra astronómica y filosófica* (1690)[1]

The finding of the document certifying Alonso Ramírez's marriage to Francisca Javiera Ribera de Poblete in the Metropolitan Cathedral of Mexico City on Sunday, November 8, 1682, which I first made public in my introduction to the 2009 Cuban edition of Sigüenza's historical works dealing with the Caribbean, established for the first time, directly and

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without a doubt the existence of Alonso Ramírez, the protagonist of Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora's *Infortunios de Alonso Ramírez*, published in Mexico City in 1690.[2] It also brought to an end a century of debates concerning the possibility that the interwoven histories and conflicting stories collected in the pamphlet could have been entirely the product of Sigüenza's imagination. The long-awaited finding of the marriage certificate also places Ramírez boarding the Manila galleon in 1684 and not in 1682, as Sigüenza reports.[3]

I had located the site of Ramírez's shipwreck on Herradura Point in 2004 and, after a series of successive expeditions, I was able to identify the wreckage of the ship and carefully document every single step he took while stranded on the old coast of Bacalar, known today as the costa Maya in Quintana Roo, Mexico. Years of research in the Archive of the Indies in Seville allowed me not only to prove and thoroughly document J. S. Cummins and Alan Soons's suspicion that Ramírez's frigate had been captured by the Cygnet of London, the pirate ship where William Dampier figured as an officer,[4] but also to discover that Alonso Ramírez spent his entire two years and seven months in Manila working as a sailor, master builder, and eventually a sea captain under the alias Felipe Ferrer. In the Mexican archives, I discovered that by marrying into the Poblete family, young Alonso had been an accomplice to the biggest and longest running scam in the history of colonial Mexico. These and the many other findings that appear both in the Spanish (2011) and in the first bilingual edition of the *Infortunios/Misfortunes* (2019)[5] are overwhelming proof that we have in our hands an account that, though hardly transparent, tells the story of the first American[6] known to have completed a full circumnavigation of the globe.

As a maritime epic the *Misfortunes* is moved by the interaction of shifting winds with surface and deep-water currents. Nothing in it is stable or permanently fixed. Indeed, this short narrative is complex to the point of being almost indecipherable. At its genesis, it is the result of Sigüenza's attempt to record and make sense of Ramírez's oral testimony. Yet, immediately upon casting off, the story begins to take on water. Ramírez's cunning as a consummate impostor aims to turn his own convoluted version of events into a tragedy that Sigüenza cannot resist but to recast as a Spanish picaresque narrative making the *Misfortunes*, among other things, the earliest example of a Latin American novel.[7] The further it drifts into a sea of uncertainty and peril, the more convoluted the story becomes as Sigüenza's ultrabaroque prose attempts to bring it under control while

Ramírez, as the fearless captain he was, jams the rudder to render the vessel ungovernable. As such, the *Misfortunes* has remained inaccessible to most readers and practically unclassifiable in scholarly terms. Beyond the label of the "curious" narrative, the fact is that the *Misfortunes* is both a type of novel as well as some sort of treatise on what was then a nascent type of modern subjectivity. Indeed, the story of this first American to claim universal standing is an invitation, born in the midst of the open seas or *mare liberum*,[8] to partake in a novel sense of freedom and social possibilities, beyond the old feudal forms and against the new colonial institutions, by questioning all authority and taking nothing at face value. Contrast this most critical, highly unstable, and ontologically indomitable American maritime epic with the sense of grounded certitude and moral high ground that has been historically assigned to the landing of the Mayflower (1620) as the symbolic event that marks the foundation of Usonian civilization in its Anglo-Protestant and, ultimately, White-supremacist modality.[9] As we will see, these competing claims to the American spirit mark the end to a continuum running between a quasi-religious and self-exonerating appeal to Christian piety in the context of a colonial enterprise founded on Native American genocide and plantation slavery, and a less than honest and much veiled acceptance of a secular and socially plural tradition of liberty born out of piracy.

Drifting into Americanness

The story of Ramírez´s travels, reordered and refashioned by Sigüenza in the *Misfortunes* begins in San Juan de Puerto Rico, from where Alonso, a boy of almost thirteen years old, sets out to sea in search of the way "to spend life without having to work for a living."[10] Bad luck will follow him in Mexico City and all along his tortuous path through New Spain forcing him in a moment of extreme desperation to exile himself to the Philippines aboard the Manila galleon. There his luck turned around until the day he fell into the hands of English pirates. They would carry him on a path of pillaging, rape, destruction, and alleged cannibalism through the South China Sea, to present-day Vietnam and Taiwan, and into Sulawesi, Timor, and Australia before reaching Madagascar to round the Cape of Good Hope and cross the Atlantic. He would then be set free by his captors to go forth, in the words of Sigüenza in the title of the work, "by sailing on his own and without a course until running aground on the coast of Yucatan, in this way having managed to travel around the World."[11] The

unusual story would reach the viceroy of New Spain, Gaspar de la Cerda Silva Sandoval y Mendoza, Count of Galve, who, wanting a firsthand account, ordered Ramírez to appear before him. Immediately after that audience, the viceroy charged Sigüenza with the task of constructing a written chronological account of Ramírez's exploits.

Since, by definition, all narratives of circumnavigation establish the point of departure and return of its protagonist as a modern *omphalos*, in the sense of the Roman imperial notion of the *Umbilicus Urbis*, or navel of the world, Sigüenza's text is also the first modern-colonial narrative to displace Europe as the *axis mundi*, or the point from where all power and knowledge emanate. In 1522, Juan Sebastián Elcano completed the first voyage of circumnavigation, a feat that served to confirm the ambitions to universal rulership of the young King Charles I of Spain who had just been crowned as the Holy Roman Emperor. In 1580, Francis Drake would carry through the second circumnavigation, thereby putting Elizabethan England on the map of imperial contenders on a global scale. Fully aware of these precedents, Sigüenza attempted to commandeer Alonso Ramírez's figure in the *Misfortunes* to extol the greatness of American civilization on a planetary scale.[12]

This should be sufficient proof that this brief work is not to be taken lightly and least of all reduced, as the first reprint of the work in 1902 suggests, to some sort of rare and curious book dealing with America. This is not to say that this work, which is full of intrigues and subversive machinations, is not rare in the context of a burdensome colonial heritage that three centuries after the original publication of the *Misfortunes* in Mexico City continues to hold sway over vast zones of American subjectivity. Nevertheless, the work should not be treated like an American curiosity—as has been so often the case—to be savored like an exotic fruit guided by the rules of etiquette of the perverse discourses of racialism and alterity. Rather, what is truly curious about the *Misfortunes* is that it is a critical exercise of clear American provenance while at the same time also the product of a world where what I call the European Ideal had not yet attained the level of universal projection it came to enjoy during the heights of modern North Atlantic imperialism in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries.[13] If the process that would lead to the crowning of the European subject as the measure of all things human was well under way during Ramírez's times, the truth is that there was then in the world of the *mare liberum*, or open seas, much more room for critical movement and the contestation of the emerging Ideal than there was to be two centuries

later in the *mare clausum* or "closed seas" period, when maritime law came under full enforcement.

Patent proof of this was the extensive treatise published by Sigüenza in January 1690, just six months before the printing of the *Misfortunes*, responding to the frivolous critique by the Jesuit missionary Eusebio Kino of Sigüenza's treatise on comets and to the resulting accusation that he was a man incapable of reason. "Never with greater repugnancy than on the present occasion did I grab the pen,"[14] he stated in the first sentence of the work as he set out to dispel "the prejudice carried by everyone, thinking that only because he had just arrived from Germany to this New Spain the reverend father [Kino] had to be a consummate mathematician."[15] Sigüenza, who was otherwise of the opinion that he had been born in "our Creole fatherland"[16] to "Spanish parents by chance,"[17] felt that the calumnies of Kino were directed "not only at me, but at my Fatherland and at my Nation,"[18] and consequently he was moved to put forth on their behalf his copious argument countering the accusation that he and, by corollary, all his Creole countrymen, were inherently people of "unsound judgment."[19]

Clearly, Sigüenza considered himself a European born in America more than an American of European lineage. He was proud of his Spanish ancestry and especially so of the Góngora name. Thus he was not contesting the European Ideal but rather denouncing the unilateral manner in which it was being increasingly appropriated and apportioned. When he thought of himself as being born in America "by chance," he was implicitly denouncing the casual manner and irregular practices of dispensing Europeanness. At this, he was an early critic of racialist ideology.[20] Still, rebutting with all his cosmological knowledge and cosmopolitan spirit Kino's accusation that American Creoles were people of unsound judgment and thus imperfect individuals for whom the Ideal was unattainable, he was always ready to behave in similar fashion to Kino when looking down upon those around him whom he considered plebeians, blacks, Indians, or mestizos "of all kinds."[21]

Given the intellectual anxiety and sheer passion that the intellectual duel with Kino provoked in him, there is no question that Sigüenza was more than ready to receive the visit of a man—an American-Creole Spaniard like him, although not of the same social extraction—who claimed to have completed what only the most capable, daring, and well-financed Europeans since Juan Sebastián Elcano had been able to pull off: a full voyage around the globe.[22] For this proud Spaniard from America,

here was a man who could now stand next to Elcano, a peninsular subject from the Basque country, showcasing the greatness of Mexico to the rest of the empire. More important perhaps for this devout Catholic, Ramírez's story gave Sigüenza firm support to rise to a higher moral ground above the feat, the stock and the religion of the Protestant pirate Francis Drake, who completed his voyage of circumnavigation a little more than a century before Ramírez in 1580. No doubt, this consummate astronomer received the story retold in the *Misfortunes* as the most fulminating comet that could ever cross the skies.

The European (English) Cannibal

In the *Libra*, Sigüenza had stopped short of asking Kino to go back to whence he came, taking his airs of superiority back with him to Germany. In this sense, the arrival of the castaway in Mexico City must have been a dream come true, as Sigüenza came to find in Ramírez the very embodiment of his philosophical argument concerning the universal validity of the American (Spanish Creole) subject. As a Spaniard born in Mexico by chance, which, as we know, was the station where he most fancied to place his person, Sigüenza also found in the captive's story a way to defend his nation's honor precisely at the moment of the most obvious and dramatic imperial decadence of Spain.

By then, it was clear that Protestant England, perceived in the West Indies and New Spain as a country of sea rovers, looting and rapist pirates, was rapidly turning into a formidable imperial rival. The quintessential example of this was Henry Morgan, the pirate who had used Spanish priests and nuns as human shields in his sacking of Panama in 1671. For this and many other services to the English crown, Morgan would be knighted and named, by Charles II of England, lieutenant governor of Jamaica, the Caribbean island that was England's largest and richest colony at the time. But if he owed his reputation to the rape of Porto Bello in 1668, perhaps the most remarkable thing in his trajectory was that he died in 1688 not as a pirate but as a pirate catcher and a planter owning upward of one hundred slaves. As Morgan's example clearly showed, looting Spanish treasure had given way to the more profitable business of human trafficking and enslavement, a rapidly expanding economic sector that was to propel the meteoric rise of the British Empire and of the structures of modern capital formation.

So it was that Ramírez gave Sigüenza the perfect alibi to set up a carefully plotted moral censure and invective against the English, whom he characterized as a most heretical, depraved, and barbarous people. More important, based on what Ramírez allegedly witnessed during the rape of Pulau Condon and following in the American tradition of Bartolomé de las Casas, Sigüenza was able to develop a powerful counterdiscourse that threw the much-abused story of the black legend of Spain back upon its principal sponsors by casting the English as the very embodiment of the modern European cannibal:

> If they had celebrated this abominable victory going through cases of rum as they always did, it hardly would be worth noting. But after the incident that I saw, how could I fail to mention it without suffering the pain and the moral unease of concealing it? Among the spoils they brought from the village—and they went to take back all they had given them in exchange for their women and provisions—was a human arm from one of the victims who perished in the fire. Each one cut himself a small piece from it, and praising the taste of such good meat, repeatedly toasting to each other's health, they finished it off. I looked upon such bestial action with scandal and dismay, when one of them came to me with a morsel urging me with annoying persistence to eat it. Owing to the repulse I showed he told me that, being a Spaniard and consequently a coward, I would do well to match their bravery by not being finicky. He pressed me no further proceeding to respond to a toast.[23]

The seventeenth century had opened in England with the mise-en-scène of *The Tempest* (1611), allegedly the most original work by William Shakespeare. Through the character of Caliban (whose name is an anagram of cannibal), one of the two inhabitants of the island wherein the shipwreck that gives way to the plot takes place, the comedy projects an image of the inhabitants of the West Indies—and, by extension, of slaves and most colonial subjects—as monsters of deformed bodies and unsound minds. Moreover, Caliban is a character of malicious intentions whose most disturbing impulse is to possess Miranda, the female character who is the representative embodiment of human perfection and European beauty.[24] Shakespeare's work is well known, and that characterization has given rise to a broad debate in the twentieth century around the relationship between master and slave, colonizer and colonized. What is practically unknown is that the seventeenth century closed in New Spain with a published eyewitness account of another type of shipwreck. In the

Misfortunes (1690) it is a Caribbean islander who describes the English as morally depraved man-eating pirates.[25] It is impossible to obviate that this description paints another type of island world where the rising imperial power of Europe appears as an abnormal and malformed nation that assumes the very shape of barbarity and dystopia.

Taken in the context of Sigüenza's answer to Kino, the *Misfortunes* can be read as an early antidote to the detrimental effects that the vision of alterity to the European subject contained in *The Tempest* has had on the perception of Caribbean subjects and other peoples in the modern-colonial world ever since. A reading in parallel of both texts would show that the invention of the "other-to-the-(White)European" was not the whimsical act of an all-powerful creator or the result of spontaneous generation as some may assume. Here, the *Misfortunes* is the rare yet irrefutable proof that the process that engendered the discourser of White (European) supremacy was checked from the very beginning by a movement in the opposite direction, through which the would-be others-to-the-Europeans fashioned and actively redefined the terms of their own approach to the doctrine of the European Ideal, putting forth a critique of the rising power in Europe, and of its expanding mercantilist/colonial agenda overseas, as the very embodiment of cannibalism. In a throwback that contravenes the spirit of Shakespeare's calculations in *The Tempest*, the accusation of cannibalism in Sigüenza's work can be considered a sort of anagram to capitalism.

The implications of this are enormous, as we can state that, already in 1690, a vision had emerged in Mexico City that turned on its head the entire compendium of the most fantastic accusations that had been made by European travelers against the peoples of the New World over the previous two centuries. Taking full advantage of the mechanics of discourse in the narratives of circumnavigation and writing from a newfound and all-empowering sense of authority in Mexico City, Sigüenza placed himself as judge of the human condition using Ramírez's clay to shape the figure of the new "vile race"[26] of modernity in the very image and likeness of the English man of action. In the process, somewhat unwittingly, early capitalism and modern-colonial oppression came to be characterized as a people-eating machine of sorts.

This is more significant if we consider that the *Misfortunes* was published three decades before Daniel Defoe's *Robinson Crusoe* (1719), the novel that would give countless generations a bold vision of the colonial enterprise, based on the notion of the "white man's burden," which placed

upon the imperial nations of Northern Europe the supreme obligation to impose their "civilizational" model on a universal scale. Defoe's work is an apologia of Protestant morality and the mercantilist economy where the English man of action is elevated to the rank of *generalissimo*[27] and master of the *ingenio*,[28] or the slave plantation in its version of the sugar factory. The first title was conferred on the merits of the moral outcry of Crusoe's character against the Spanish imperial enterprise in the New World. His rabid promotion of the black legend elevates the civilizational standard of the English while hiding the terror-filled practices of enslavement and colonization that propelled England's own imperial project. The second was bestowed by providence itself and embodied in the figure of Friday, the island cannibal who was Crusoe's "man," or servant. The contrast with the *Misfortunes* demands a parallel reading of both texts. Here Defoe reflects through Crusoe's character:

> That this would justify the Conduct of the *Spaniards* in all their Barbarities practis'd in *America*, and where they destroy'd Millions of these People, who however they were Idolaters and Barbarians, and had several bloody and barbarous Rites in their Customs, such as sacrificing human Bodies to their Idols, were yet, as to the *Spaniards*, very innocent People… and as such, as for which the very Name of a *Spaniard* is recon'd to be frightful and terrible to all People of Humanity, or of Christian Compassion. [29]

Foretelling the End to Empire

The circumstances that led to the printing of Sigüenza's work, as ordered by the viceroy, open two major tracks of critical possibilities. On one side is the question of the political advantage that could be derived from Ramírez's story at the royal court in Madrid and that Fabio López Lázaro has thoroughly studied.[30] On the other is the matter of the subversive nature of this very complex and indomitable narrative. On this second point the *Misfortunes* is in line with earlier critiques of the Spanish Empire in canonical texts of the American tradition, such as Bartolomé de las Casas's *Historia de las Indias* (1561) and Guamán Poma de Ayala's *Nueva crónica y buen gobierno* (1615). Yet, this controversial work also marks a significant departure from tradition by looking well beyond Spain and its overseas dominions. In this way, it was unique in its day as a visionary critique of the hegemonic model of economic expansion and capital

accumulation that was then on the rise and that set the foundations of the world economy as we know it today.

This portentous book was the product of experiences collected by Ramírez on the margins of society in a water world that lay beyond the control of land-based empires. These experiences were later recounted with certain malice aforethought and assiduously reworked by Sigüenza before being printed and dispatched to the royal court in Madrid. In its final and ever unstable form, the display of valor and the American craftiness in Ramírez come together with the defense of Spanish honor and the intelligence of Sigüenza, resulting in a work whose modest size holds no relation to the far-reaching critique of colonial modernity that it contains. It is significant enough that by characterizing the English expansionist enterprise as the true measure of anthropophagy, the work is an open challenge to the models of economic exploitation and social vituperation that were being constructed at the time and would come to form the basis of North-Atlantic White-supremacist ideology. What is more, the account of the trials suffered by Ramírez and his crew when marooned on the coast of Bacalar opens the possibility of exploring the spaces where the European, in his guise as the modern man of action—in this case Ramírez as a Spanish (Creole) patron and *pater familias*—is overtaken if not defeated by the realization of the ultimate futility of the colonial project.[31]

This is, of course, much more than Sigüenza set out to do. The credit for somehow having brought into this narrative the presage to the end of empire goes entirely to Ramírez whose surreptitious ways gave this story the constitutive versatility and foundational instability that are the source of all its power and ultimate glory. We may never know the details of what exactly happened when by order of the viceroy Sigüenza received Ramírez and, just as he confessed to have done previously with Kino upon his arrival in Mexico City, "I took him to my home, I hosted him in it, [and] I introduced him to my friends."[32] The story of circumnavigation in the *Misfortunes* conferred upon Mexico City the title of *Umbilicus Urbis.* But if Mexico was now the center of the world, the original and very unruly narrative that made it so also set in motion a large number of strange bodies in arguably indescribable orbits around it that the consummate astronomer could not fully calculate. These obscure movements would have mysterious effects on the minds of Ramírez's interlocutors, on the readers of the *Misfortunes*, and on the colonial institutions. Both Sigüenza and the censor, Francisco de Ayerra Santa María, would apply themselves with expert curiosity to these mysteries before going through great lengths in

trying to conceal them or somewhat naively hoping to bring them under control through the writer's pen and the censor's seal of approval.[33]

A first reading of the *Misfortunes* reveals that Ramírez's survey of the most far-flung areas on the map of the enterprise of European colonial expansion gave Sigüenza and the viceroy a way of calling attention to the inability of the Spanish Crown to protect the integrity of its dominions near and far. Everywhere, from San Juan to Manila, English pirates sailed Spanish waters with impunity.[34] A deeper reading would show how his testimony also brought back to Mexico City not just the presage of the end of empire which had become patently obvious during the reign of the last Habsburg king of Spain, Charles II, but also a spirit critical of the social order, the Catholic Church, the military and the political authorities. Keep in mind that we are not dealing here with a confession. Rather, this work is a game of mirrors, a subterfuge set up by a consummate impostor who, as a modern-colonial subject, had grown to become a true master of the confidence trick and also, as an early American, had received by birthright and had been able to cultivate as an art form the vocation to subversive intrigue.

Pirates Tell the Tallest Stories

The first question anyone could have asked of Ramírez upon his return to Spanish territory is why, if he and his crew were captives of and servants to the English, the pirates let them head back home with one of the captured ships instead of throwing them overboard in the middle of the Atlantic during the final passage back to England. A satisfactory answer to this question—that is, an answer that would have saved them from hanging in the middle of the plaza as pirates—is hardly possible if we consider Ramírez's claim to all that was left back at the shipwreck site. Partially enumerated in the book, the list included nine cannons and more than 2000 cannonballs. Given the considerable price that such ordnance could fetch and the unfavorable conditions under which Ramírez's men were allegedly set free, there was plenty of reason to believe that Ramírez was lying.

This is even more obvious when we consider that Ramírez and all his men were fully armed with blades and shotguns when they were found wandering along the coast of Bacalar. Keep in mind that, among pirates, weapons were the property of each individual, and in that line of work, there were no more precious and cherished personal possessions than

firearms. We can infer, as any of their contemporaries would have done, that Ramírez and his men were carrying guns of their own property, which they had kept close at hand and carefully cared for ever since joining the pirate crew. In fact, there is clear mention of this possibility in Ramírez's story when he tells how "they proposed to me, as they had done before, that if I swore to accompany them always they would give me weapons."[35]

Surely, in the fifty-two days they were marooned in the coast of Yucatan, Ramírez had plenty of time to think about how to justify himself and settle on a common story with his crew. As I argue in the essay that accompanies the bilingual edition of the *Infortunios/Misfortunes*, it is quite possible that crew members who did not go along with the story or could not be trusted to put on a good performance were murdered by Ramírez's hand or under his orders.[36] Over the five months that passed from the day of the rescue to his brief audience with the viceroy, Ramírez also had countless opportunities to fine-tune his version of the story, as he was constantly pressed to explain himself. Judging by the characterization made by the censor Ayerra, it seems Ramírez found that making his story as convoluted and unintelligible as possible was the best way to avoid any and all accusations. In the end, the contradictions would cancel themselves out in what Ayerra characterized as a long concatenation "of so many dismally confused events."[37] After all was said and done, Ramírez's own survival and the graces he would receive from the Count of Galve are proof that there is no better storyteller than the consummate impostor.

Now, for the first time, we have considerable documentary evidence that points to the very real possibility that Ramírez joined the English in their roving and raping ventures through the South Seas. It comes from the statements taken from prisoners of the English pirates, including former members of Ramírez's original crew, who upon their release were questioned by the Spanish authorities in Manila. There are major inconsistencies among these documents, found in the Archive of the Indies, and Ramírez's version of the story as reported and quite clearly is enhanced by Sigüenza. Central to these discrepancies is the character and person of the pirate Miguel, who is mentioned in the *Misfortunes* as an evil Spaniard from Seville. Ramírez accuses Miguel not only of being a pirate but, worse still, of having committed apostasy by renouncing the Catholic faith to join the English in their Protestant rituals. Indeed, in the *Misfortunes* Miguel occupies the very limits of the continuum of loyalty to the crown and the church opposite Ramírez, who (we are led to believe) suffered through this "pitiful pilgrimage"[38] as a devout Spanish Catholic, molding

his life to the three theological virtues of faith, hope, and charity. The description of Miguel's self-hating and sadist ways is the loudest of all denunciations in Chap. 4, where Ramírez's character "remembers what he endured as their captive."[39] Keep in mind that this chapter details scenes of torture, cannibalism, and even coprophagia. Nonetheless, Miguel's erred ways, as described in the last paragraph, are presented as the most horrific and impious of all the dealings that ever went on aboard the pirate ship:

> The necessary conclusion of all that has been stated here is that these pirates can compete in cruelty and abominations with all of those whose names have made it to the top of the list in this trade. But I believe they would not have been so bad as they were to us if there would not have been among them a Spaniard who prized himself on being Sevillian and whose name was Miguel. There was no intolerable chore they gave us, there was no single time in which we were mistreated by them, there was no hunger we suffered, nor risk to our lives we endured, that he did not personally administer and supervise, taking pride in showing himself to be merciless and abandoning the Catholic faith into which he was born in order to live as a pirate and to die as a heretic. He would join the English—and this was the most regrettable for me and my shipmates—in their festivities, which were on Christmas and on Sundays throughout the year, reading and praying like them out of their own books. May God enlighten his understanding so that, mending his ways, he may attain forgiveness for his unrighteousness.[40]

This version stands in sharp contrast to the one offered in the documents where all the crewmembers in Ramírez's frigate set free by the pirates in Ibuhos speak of the Sevillian Miguel in their statements. Just as they tried to cover for their former captain and the seven mates who sailed off with the pirates by stating, instead, that they had been abandoned in Pulau Condon, they all spoke of Miguel as being a prisoner of the English and not as a pirate and a heretic. In fact, the tone of the testimonies confirms that far from being the Spanish-hater and sadist he is made out to be in the *Misfortunes*, it was Miguel who spent the greatest amount of time with the crew of Ramírez's captured frigate. Thus Juan del Pilar, who was the servant of the boatswain Francisco Acosta, stated that "he got to know four prisoners who were with said enemy, of one of them named Miguel, whose last name he did not know, only that he was by nation Sevillian, and the other three natives of the Kingdom of Chile, one named also Miguel, and the other Andrés, and the other also named Miguel, all of whom this

witness spoke with frequently during the course of the time he was captive."[41] It is clear from the testimonies that the one among these four Spanish-speakers who did most of the chatting was precisely the Sevillian. There are repeated references to this, as in the testimony of Diego Vendón, one of the sailors of the Spanish frigate: "And so states this witness that said Miguel told him."[42]

Of the many things that Miguel told his fellow Spaniards, the curious and resourceful Ramírez no doubt included, was the story of how the pirates "had sailed from the Kingdom of England but that he did not know when and that it had been on the coasts of Peru to where they had set out laden with merchandise and that they had refused them entry in every harbor in said kingdom."[43] The testimony of Mateo Francisco, an expert seaman aged thirty-six, is quite revealing in this sense:

> And in the same way he was told by said Miguel that a number of the Englishmen had come from the Darien by land whereupon they set out to sea in small vessels and came to meet with said ship, and having joined them and seeing that they were not received in any harbor in said Kingdom of Peru they tried to commit acts of piracy, and that said ship had always sailed by itself, and that its captain as far as this witness can recall was named Capisuan [sic], and that it carries seventy two men of the nations mentioned above, and fourteen pieces of artillery of four and six pounds caliber made of iron and four swivel-guns, and many muskets, pistols and cutlasses. And in the same way said Sevillian Miguel and the other three Chilean prisoners told this witness that said ship had been in the Kingdom of Mindanao for six months, and that the captain with other forty-nine men had stayed behind in said Kingdom.[44]

There is no mention in any of these statements of how Miguel had come to be aboard the pirate ship. If the conversations between the Sevillian and Ramírez's crew were as cordial as the documents suggest, there is no doubt that one of the first questions any curious Spanish subject would have asked Miguel would have been precisely how and why he had come to be sailing among English pirates off the coast of the very strategically important Spanish city of Manila. Coupled with the fact that all the witnesses expressly stated to have been unable to remember the surname of their gracious interlocutor and host aboard the pirate ship, there is no other option but to conclude that there was a joint attempt on the part of the sailors to conceal from the authorities the true identity of the otherwise renegade Spaniard. How are we to believe that they could

recall the last name of Charles Swan, the English captain of the Cygnet who was marooned in Mindanao and who they never met but, somehow, they had all forgotten that of Miguel, the Sevillian with whom they had been living in close quarters and conversing with on a regular basis?

The Peoples of the Seas and Their Compact of Silence

Here we find a clear and documented example of what was already by the end of the seventeenth century a well-established culture of universal projections whose mores and institutions had been laid down over the previous century and a half in the struggles of resistance and survival against the *encomienda*, slavery, evangelization, and forced conversion on the open seas and the frontier world of the Caribbean archipelago. The way in which these sailors protected the identities and actions of both Miguel and Ramírez's crew speaks of the pact of silence that at the time bound together the "peoples of the sea" or *gentes de mar*, as they were known in Spanish.[45] That compact was organized around a shared code of loyalty and solidarity that revealed a deep-seated suspicion of all land-based powers and authorities. The rise of the British Empire and of nation-states such as the United States of America would soon lay down a different law of the seas, rapidly reducing those spaces of extralegal solidarity and freedom in the open seas and turning ships into floating prisons for indentured sailors and a growing number of Africans with the exponential rise of the Atlantic slave trade.

Yet, even if Ramírez's men never betrayed the Sevillian, the statement of Mateo Francisco is particularly curious, as it mentions events that occurred well before the English pirates crossed the Pacific Ocean pertaining to the attack on Panama. According to Miguel, they met up with Captain Townley and his 180 men on February 25, 1685. Ten days later, this force would be enlarged by the arrival of 280 men under captains Groniet and L'Escuyer. In May, Captain Harris would join the group, raising to ten the total number of ships in the squadron. The Battle of Panama took place between June 7 and 9. Being able to capture neither the city nor the Spanish fleet, the group dispersed. Miguel the Sevillian was probably present and a willing participant in these actions and in the subsequent rapes and burns of León and Realejo in Nicaragua on July 22 and August 3, respectively. If he was not, he was to join the pirates soon before leaving for the East Indies on April 10, 1686. Regardless of this, the

information he disclosed was not the type of thing to be shared with prisoners. Rather, it is one more sign that Ramírez and most of his crew willingly joined the pirates shortly after they came aboard the Cygnet and, through this action, were able to protect the comrades who did otherwise and would choose to stay in Spanish territory.

The contrast with the version in the *Misfortunes* is fascinating. According to this, the first thing that Ramírez did upon being brought aboard the Cygnet was to try to trick the pirates into heading for the island of Capones, where he hoped they would fall into Spanish hands: "My intent was that, if they were to go there they would be caught off guard and taken prisoners, not just by its natives but by the Spanish soldiers stationed there."[46] This alleged plan had no logic whatsoever. The pirate ship was a floating fortress with more than 150 well-armed men who would have encountered very little resistance from the small garrison in Capones. According to the book, Ramírez paid a high price once the pirates discovered his ploy:

> Pistols and cutlasses at hand they started to search me again and even to torture me. They tied me and one of my shipmates to the main mast and, since I did not give them any useful information on the places where they could find the gold and silver they were asking about, seizing my shipmate Francisco de la Cruz, a mestizo Chinese, they left him unconscious and almost dead on the foredeck after submitting him to the most cruel mancuerda. They placed me and my crew in the ship's hold and from there I heard great screams and a shot… unsheathed cutlasses at hand, they fell upon me with great shouting and vituperation. Never was I so frightened in my fear of death as in this moment. But they commuted it [the death sentence] for the many kicks and blows with which they fell on me, such that they left me unable to move for many days.[47]

Running with the Wind

Clearly Ramírez was telling everyone what each one wanted to hear. He told the Spaniards that he never gave up any valuable information to the English and that "even though [he] tried hard, [he] was never able to find out where they were fitted to go out to sea."[48] Yet we know from the testimonies of his crew taken at Manila that one of the first things they found out from Miguel was that they had sailed out of London. Innumerable alternative readings can be put forth from this point, including a discussion of how the characterization of the Sevillian Miguel in the *Misfortunes*

could be a reflection of Ramírez's personal insecurities—and also of his own proclivities, as well as possibly being a literal testimony of his actions aboard the pirate ship—and not simply the product of a colorful imagination. In other words, the Miguel described in the *Misfortunes* could very well speak more of Alonso Ramírez's demeanor aboard the Cygnet than of the Sevillian who is described as talkative and friendly in the Spanish documents. The accusation of cannibalism, as well as the allusions to sodomy in the description of the torture he and his men were submitted to every Monday, is particularly intriguing in this sense, as are also the allegations that Juan de Casas was made to eat Captain Bel's excrements dissolved in water.[49] If he had joined the pirate society, then he must have participated in the rituals of homoerotic sadistic amusement practiced aboard the Cygnet. The descriptions of these, even when preceded by an apology, are among the most striking passages in the *Misfortunes* to somehow have eluded censorship:

> Monday was the most dreaded day for us because, placing a cable of liana around the mizzenmast and tying our left hands to it they put a ratline on our right hands, and having undressed us, they forced us with daggers and pistols pointed to our chests to flog one another. The shame and pain we felt was matched by the cheer and applause with which they celebrated it.
>
> My shipmate Juan de Casas being unable to be present at the apportionment of the continuous work to which we were subjected, and Captain Bel attributing it to what he called feebleness, he said he would cure him and with a simple remedy. Forgive me for bringing this up [in spite of] the decency and respect owed to the reader, but he resolved to make him drink his own captain's excrement dissolved in water, placing a knife to his throat to hasten his death if he showed any reluctance.[50]

It is worth wondering that if Ramírez participated in these pastimes, he could have also joined his new comrades in their religious practices every week on the day prior to the alleged mutual floggings at knifepoint, as he attributed to and severely condemned in the figure of the Sevillian Miguel.

There is evidence in the text that Ramírez failed to convince everyone of not having been a pirate, particularly the first Spanish officials he came upon in the town of Valladolid. Yet his story proved useful not just to him, in the form of the payment and employment he received from the viceroy, but to the Count of Galve himself, who ordered that it be immediately transcribed, printed, and a good number of copies shipped to Madrid. Apparently, the use value of Ramírez's story rose in an inversely

proportional relation to the diminished measure of its credibility. This in turn increased the level of complicity of those who could have expected to gain something from the story, chiefly among them Sigüenza and the censor Ayerra who, faced with the task of making the castaway's testimony readable in court and thus useful to the viceroy's agenda, worked furiously to tie all the loose ends in the mariner's account. In the process, both of them became deeply entangled in the forms of knowledge that Ramírez had engaged in and in the precious know-how he had acquired and brought back from his voyage around the world.

Liberty as the Pirate's Loot

Now that we can corroborate as a well-documented series of events the path he followed in search of fortune, Alonso Ramírez attains the stature of one of the great icons in the history of circumnavigation in the mostly unknown to English language readers and otherwise largely understudied *Misfortunes.* That feat is doubly relevant when measured against his clever ways, taking into account the formidable skills he acquired during a voyage full of very real dangers and alleged torments. In contrast to those whose names appear before his in the list of circumnavigators, Ramírez's voyage was not a well-financed enterprise. Rather, it was a very personal affair in pursuit of a "life without having to work for a living."[51] Thus the greatness of the feat was owed exclusively to his intelligence and cunning and to what must have been an impressive set of verbal and histrionic skills. Only this explains how he not only was able to make the most of his captivity by rendering good service to the English pirates but also had no qualms whatsoever to prostrate himself before the viceroy and claim the part of the loot he had obtained while sailing with them halfway around the globe.

To explore the ways in which Ramírez managed to profit from the most adverse situations is to begin to reveal the merits and perils of the most beguiling plot of subversive intrigue. In fact, the *Misfortunes* invites its readers to embark on a fluid baroque opera of innumerable ebbs and clashing currents that, on both large and small scales, aim to deactivate reductionist approaches to this otherwise brief narrative by sending them in a roundabout voyage of endless questions and suppositions. In the end, because all stories, by definition, require the suspension of judgement, only the consummate impostor can tell the best stories. That much could be said of William Dampier's works but also of Sigüenza's *Misfortunes,*

insofar as in being ordered to write down Ramírez's novelized version of his life and times, Sigüenza managed to quickly craft a work in which fact and fiction can never be brought into the "good order"[52] that the censor Ayerra rather disingenuously confessed to have found in this narration.

As such, the *Misfortunes* is a highly unstable and destabilizing story in the most piratical sense. Given what we know now, it is possible to state without any hesitation that the claim to the European "discovery" of Australia made in Mexico City during the summer of 1690 on behalf of Alonso Ramírez, a native of the city of San Juan on the island of Puerto Rico, predates by seven years the first narrative in English taking credit for the same feat made by the pirate writer William Dampier in *A New Voyage Round the World*, published in London in 1697. That claim is made all the more pronounced when we consider that, as I can now prove, Ramírez, as a good man of the sea, also withheld from Sigüenza the real names of his alleged captors. This precludes them from getting any type of credit in the 1690 edition, irrespective of whether Ramírez's intent was to cover his tracks and avoid being associated in any way with the Lutheran sea rovers.

Yet Sigüenza knew from the very beginning that this was first and foremost a pirate's story. Indeed, young Alonso had set out in search of fortune at the age of twelve by sailing with the Corsican captain Giovanni Michele, also known as Juan Miguel, Juan Miguel Corso, or Juan Corso.[53] He is mentioned in the text as Juan del Corcho, a trick that more than a pun is intended to hide the obvious fact that we are dealing with a privateer. The apparent literary license in using Corcho, or "Cork," for Corso was meant to throw off track a Spanish peninsular reader who would have taken the pawn as a picaresque frivolity—being the one who never sinks—while signaling right from the start to a reader in Mexico City, who would have been well aware of Corso's reputation as a privateer, that there was a deeper meaning to this entire story.

The subversive undercurrent that the *Misfortunes* brings into the nascent tradition of American letters in the story of Ramírez's trials must be understood, first and foremost, as a product of the culture of the peoples of the sea in the *mare liberum*—that is, as a reflection of a world where it was still possible to experience a true sense of freedom on the open seas. It is almost impossible to separate the alternative ways and customs of the peoples of the sea from the savoir faire of subjects throughout the colonial and plantation world, from the Caribbean to the Philippines and beyond, as they mirror each other in the same coded language and partly secretive rituals that a careful reading of the *Misfortunes* can begin to reveal. That

particular way of being and of knowing, which I call mulataje,[54] is a counter hegemonic discourse and culture that, since the earliest times in modernity, has moved against, but mostly around, all colonialist calculations.[55] Being one of the principal theaters where modern civilization was first staged, the praxis of mulataje has been the most significant contribution of the Caribbean world to colonial modernity. And it was, without a doubt, the ways of being through mulataje, immeasurable and confounding to a great extent, what Sigüenza found most valuable in Ramírez's booty. As such, even more than a first-person account of a pirate's life, the *Misfortunes* is the first piratical and novelized narrative to document the deep impression made by life on the open seas and beyond the confines of empire on the American ideal of liberty.

Notes

1. Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, *Libra astronómica y filosófica* (Mexico: Viuda de Bernardo Calderón, 1690), 33. "Ni se yo como será universalmente una cosa que tal vez, segun afirma, se falsifica; ni tampoco alcanço, como puede servirle de razon para convencer mi sentir lo que a mi me sirvio de prueba para afirmar mi opinion."
2. Sigüenza y Góngora, Carlos de. *Infortunios que Alonso Ramírez, natural de la ciudad de San Juan de Puerto Rico, padeció, así en poder de ingleses piratas que lo apresaron en las Islas Filipinas, como navegando por si solo, y sin derrota, hasta varar en la Costa de Yucatán: consiguiendo por este medio dar vuelta al Mundo.* Mexico City: Herederos de la Viuda de Bernardo Calderón, 1690.
3. See José F. Buscaglia Salgado, introduction to *Historias del Seno Mexicano*, by Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, ed. Reynier Pérez Hernández (Havana: Casa de las Américas, 2009). Two years prior, in 2007, Fabio López Lázaro disclosed a momentous finding citing a letter of July 1, 1690, where the Count of Galve, Viceroy of New Spain, tells his brother, the Duke of Infantado, that he had met a man by the name of Alonso Ramírez who claimed to have sailed from the Philippines to Yucatan. See Fabio López Lázaro, "La mentira histórica de un pirata caribeño: El descubrimiento del trasfondo histórico de los *Infortunios de Alonso Ramírez* (1690)," *Anuario de estudios americanos* 64.2 (July–December 2007): 100–101. The finding by López Lázaro, while no doubt of the outmost significance, could not be seen as incontrovertible proof of the existence of the protagonist of this story. Like I was able to show in the Spanish edition of the *Infortunios* of 2011, Ramírez had taken a different name while in the Philippines. See Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, *Infortunios de Alonso Ramírez,* ed., intro.,

José F. Buscaglia (Madird: Polifemo/Consejo Superior de Investigaciones Científicas, 2011), 92–96, 144–145. As he refashioned his story to suit his interest at every turn, even with the passing reference in Galve's letter there would always remain doubt of whether Alonso Ramírez was the actual name of the protagonist. The finding of the marriage certificate dispelled that doubt once and for all.

4. See Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, *Infortunios de Alonso Ramírez*, ed. J.S. Cummins and Alan Soons (London: Tamesis Texts, 1984), 6.
5. Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, *Infortunios de Alonso Ramírez, The Misfortunes of Alonso Ramírez*, ed., trans., José F. Buscaglia Salgado (New Brunswick, New Jersey: Rutgers University Press, 2019). (Hereafter Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*). This article is a shortened and revised version of the first part of the essay that accompanies the bilingual edition under the title "The History of the First American of Universal Standing: How Alonso Ramírez, a.k.a Felipe Ferrer, Turned the World on Its Head by Circumnavigating the Globe."
6. Keep in mind that at all times I use the term American to refer to the inhabitants of the entire continent, just as Sigüenza did in the very first sentence of the story when he pointed to the location where Alonso Ramírez was "stranded in the coasts of Yucatan, here in America." To avoid confusion, I prefer to name those Americans from the United States of America with the neologism of Usonians. See José F. Buscaglia-Salgado, *Undoing Empire, Race and Nation in the Mulatto Caribbean* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2003), xviii.
7. See Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, "Infortunios de Alonso Ramírez," in *La novela del México colonial.* ed. Antonio Castro Leal, vol. 1. (Mexico, D.F.: Aguilar, 1964), 51.
8. The original treatise making a case for keeping the seas open to all nations and vessels dates from 1609. See Hugo Grotius, *The Freedom of the Seas* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1916).
9. Again, since 2003 I have been using the neologism of Usonian (and Usonian imperial ideology) to refer to the American peoples from, and all things pertaining to, the United States of America. See Buscaglia-Salgado, *Undoing Empire*.
10. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 102.
11. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 87.
12. Barbara Fuchs and Yolanda Martínez-San Miguel find the origins of this tendency to conceive of Mexico City as what they call a "colonial metropolis" already at the start of the seventeenth century with Bernardo de Balbuena's *La grandeza mexicana* (1604). See Barbara Fuchs and Yolanda Martínez-San Miguel, "*La grandeza mexicana* de Balbuena y el imaginario

de una 'metrópolis colonial," *Revista Iberoamericana* 75.228 (July–September 2009): 675–695.

13. For a detailed discussion concerning the notion of the European Ideal and of the movement of what I call *mulataje* see Buscaglia-Salgado, *Undoing Empire*, xiv–xviii.
14. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Libra*, 1. "Nunca con mas repugnancia, que en la ocacion presente tomé la pluma en la mano."
15. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Libra*, 2. "El perjuyzio en que todos estaban, pensando que solo por ser recien llegado de Alemania a esta Nueva-España el RP havia de ser consumadísimo Mathematico."
16. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Libra*, 5. "Nuestra criolla nacion."
17. In the *Libra*, Sigüenza is clear when he refers to "we the Americans…who from Spanish parents by chance were born in them" (in the countries of America). See Sigüenza y Góngora, *Libra*, 83. "Nosotros los Americanos….los que de padres Españoles casualmente nacimos en ellos."
18. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Libra*, 147. "no solo a mí, sino a mi Patria y a mi Nacion."
19. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Libra*, 5, 147. "Trabajoso juicio."
20. For a contextualized discussion of racialist ideology see José F. Buscaglia Salgado, "Race and the Constitutive Inequality of the Modern/Colonial Condition," *Critical Terms in Caribbean and Latin American Thought: Historical and Institutional Trajectories* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2015): 109–124.
21. For the most poignant example of Sigüenza's temerity in this regard, see Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, "Alboroto y motín de los indios de México," in *Don Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, un sabio mexicano del siglo XVII*, edited by Irving A. Leonard, trans. Juan José Utrilla (Mexico: Fondo de Cultura Económica, 1984).
22. Juan Sebastián Elcano sailed with Ferdinand Magellan and was captain of the Victoria when it returned to Spain thereby completing the first circumnavigation of the globe (1519–1522).
23. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 120.
24. In act 2, Ariel wonders at the sight of Caliban: "What have we here? A man or a fish?" only to conclude: "This is no fish, but an islander." William Shakespeare, *The Tempest,* 2.2: 25–37. Stephano enters into the scene thereafter to protest: "This is some monster of the isle, with four legs, who hath got, as I take it, an ague. Where the devil should he learn our language?" Shakespeare, 2.2: 66–68. In act 3, Ferdinand admires Miranda: "But you, O you, so perfect and so peerless, are created of every creature's best." Shakespeare, 3.1: 46–49.

25. See here the pioneering work of Álvaro Félix Bolaños, "Sobre 'relaciones' e identidades en crisis: el 'otro' lado del ex-cautivo Alonso Ramírez," *Revista de Crítica Literaria Latinoamericana* 42 (1995): 131–160.
26. Words used by Miranda to describe Caliban's kind. See Shakespeare, 1.2: 358–359.
27. See Daniel Defoe, *Robinson Crusoe*, (New York: Random House, 2001), 246.
28. Defoe, 259–260.
29. Defoe, 158–159.
30. See Fabio López Lázaro, *The Misfortunes of Alonso Ramírez: The True Adventures of a Spanish American with 17th-Century Pirates* (Austin: University of Texas Press, 2011).
31. Here, Yolanda Martínez-San Miguel's reading of "Ramírez's testimonial as a parody and criticism of the epic hero, a key icon of European imperial imaginaries" is particularly relevant in broadening the interpretative possibilities in the work. See Yolanda Martínez-San Miguel, "Colonial No More?: Limits of the Transatlantic Episteme," in *From Lack to Excess: "Minor" Readings of Latin American Colonial Discourse* (Lewisburg: Bucknell University Press, 2008): 146–184.
32. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Libra*, 4. "Lo lleve a mi casa, lo regalé en ella, lo introduge con mis amigos."
33. Francisco de Ayerra Santa María (1630–1708) was born in San Juan de Puerto Rico and, like Ramírez, abandoned his country for Mexico City at an early age. There he attended the Royal and Pontifical University of Mexico and was ordained as a priest. He would come to be well known as a poet and become a good friend of Sigüenza who was younger than him by fifteen years. When Ramírez came to Mexico City in 1690, Ayerra was about to turn seventy years of age.
34. This was most evident in Yucatan where the city of San Francisco de Campeche had suffered a devastating attack in September 1685 at the hands of Michel de Grammont, also known as Chevalier de Grammont, and Laurens Cornelis Boudewjin de Graaf, known to the Spaniards as Lorencillo. The rape of Campeche lasted three months. It included the burning of much of the city and the razing to the ground of the nearby town of Lerma. In human costs, it led to the loss of one-third of the population of the city, including countless prisoners whom de Grammont summarily and systematically executed while waiting for the ransom.
35. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 127.
36. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 199.
37. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 92.
38. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 90.
39. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 129.

40. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 135.
41. "llego a saver de quatro pricioneros que estavan con dicho enemigo del uno de ellos llamado Miguel que no supo su apellido solo si que era sevillano de nacion, y los otros tres naturales que eran del Reyno de Chile llamado el uno tambien Miguel, y el otro Andres, y asi mismo el otro llamado Miguel con quienes comunico este declarante muchas vezes en el discurso del tiempo que estubo pricionero." Archivo General de Indias, Seville, Spain (A.G.I.), *Filipinas* 12, R. 1, N. 60/4/41–42.
42. "Y asi mismo dize este declarante le dijo el dicho Miguel." A.G.I., *Filipinas* 12, R. 1, N. 60/4/23.
43. "habia salido del Reyno de Ynglaterra pero que no supo quando y que havia estado en las Costas del Peru para donde havian traido su derrota cargado de mercaderias y que no les havian querido admitir en ningun puerto de los de dicho reyno." A.G.I., *Filipinas* 12, R. 1, N. 60/4/13.
44. "Y assi mismo le dijo el dicho Miguel que por el andariel [sic] havian venido y passado por tierra numero de Yngleses los quales con embarcaciones pequeñas salieron al mar y se encontraron con este dicho navío, y incorporados con el viendo que no eran rezividos en puerto alguno de dicho Reyno del Peru trataron de piratear, y que siempre havia andado solo dicho navio, y que el Capitan de el a los que se quiere acordar este declarante se llamava Capisuan, y que trae sesenta y dos hombres de las naciones que arriba lleva referidas, y catorce piezas de artillería de fierro de a quatro y seis libras de calibre y quatro pedreros, y mucha escopeteria pistolas y alfanges. Y asi mismo le dijo a este declarante el dicho Miguel sevillano y los otros tres prisioneros chilenos que havia estado dicho navio en el Reyno de Mindanao tiempo de seis meses, y que se avia quedado en dicho Reyno el Capitan Principal de el con otros quarenta y nuebe hombres." A.G.I., *Filipinas* 12, R. 1, N. 60/4/13–14.
45. For more on the concept of the people of the sea, see Pablo E. Pérez-Mallaína, *Spain's Men of the Sea: Daily Life on the Indies Fleets in the Sixteenth Century*, trans. Carla Rahn Phillips (Baltimore, Md.: The John Hopkins University Press, 1889).
46. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 116.
47. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 121.
48. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 116–117.
49. I have given some tentative consideration to both the question of sodomy and coprophagy in *Undoing Empire*, 163–165.
50. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 133.
51. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 102.
52. Sigüenza y Góngora, *Misfortunes*, 92.
53. By 1682 Giovanni Michele had been granted a privateer license by the governors of Yucatan and Havana with permission to attack English and

French pirate ships and seize their cargoes. See César García del Pino, *El corso en Cuba. Siglo XVII* (Havana: Editorial Ciencias Sociales, 2001), 189–191. In a letter dated March 13, 1683, the governor of Havana, Tomás Fernández de Córdoba, mentions the prices captured by "Captain Juan Corso." (A.G.I., *Santo Domingo*, 107, R. 2, N. 41) Five years later, in a letter of November 7, 1687, the military governor of Havana writes of a deceased Juan Corso, "who served well fighting the enemies that infest this sound" (A.G.I., *Santo Domingo*, 109, R. 2, N. 29). The letter deals with the attack perpetrated by Juan Miguel's brother, Biagio Michele, or Blas Miguel Corso, against the French in Petit-Goâve, Saint-Domingue, in August of that year. See also Archivo General de la Nación, Mexico City, Mexico (A.G.N.), *GD100 Reales Cédulas Originales*, Vol. 22, exp. 40, fs. 2.

54. See Buscaglia-Salgado, *Undoing Empire*, xiv–xviii.
55. See also Buscaglia-Salgado, *Circumventing Racialism through mulataje. Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Literature* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2018). http://literature.oxfordre.com/view/10.1093/acrefore/9780190201098.001.0001/acrefore-9780190201098-e-395

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CHAPTER 7

Pantitlán or *Desagüe*: Technology and Secularization in Colonial Mexico City

Ivonne del Valle

Michel Serres begins his book *The Natural Contract* [Le Contrat Naturel] by inviting us to imagine what might be happening in Goya's painting *Duelo a garrotazos* [Fight with Cudgels] (Fig. 7.1) in which the two adversaries, sunk up to their knees in the sand, are about to strike their next blows. The situation—the sand—should limit the violence of their movements. Their rage, on the other hand, overcomes this, and with each blow they sink a little further, so that the winner—were there to be one, and were it possible to call such an outcome victory—would end up, like his adversary, defeated by the ground that is swallowing him up. Serres invokes Goya to invite us to do something else, too: to imagine not the familiar history of combat and bad blood between enemies but rather the setting where the battle takes place.[1]

Serres's suggested change of focus is ideal for speaking about the water that surrounded the island of Mexico-Tenochtitlan. First, because from 1519 until some indeterminate date the basin of Mexico was the setting

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Fig. 7.1 Francisco Goya, *Duelo a garrotazos* (1820–1823). Museo del Prado, Madrid

for a struggle between two very different opponents. Second, because this war, which depending on the circumstances was variously high and low intensity, involved nature, in the form of water that refused to be tamed, expelled, or contained.

As in a *tableau vivant*, water became a third, seemingly neutral and indifferent contender in the struggle that took place on its surface, requiring first the Mexica and then the Spaniards and Creoles to take it into account, although perhaps in diverse ways. In this sense Serres is right: we need to pay attention to a nature that has never ceased to express itself. In the case of Mexico City, every summer, every new episode of flooding, and every new branch that has to be added to the multiple canals of the *desagüe* (drainage system), exposes an agency that cannot be ignored. As Ernesto Aréchiga has suggested, it would appear that "the lakes refuse to disappear" despite the enormous and costly efforts which, since 1607, have been made to this end (65).

Nevertheless, Serres is mistaken in speaking about *one* setting. In the case of Colonial Mexico City at least, we cannot speak about a single place: the groups who established themselves there had such different conceptions of the surrounding environment that it would be impossible to speak of a single setting. I will try to demonstrate this difference and how it meant that eventually after a lengthy period of time the semi-aquatic pre-Hispanic city became the picturesque—if brown and dusty—Mexico City

Fig. 7.2 Pedro Gualdi, *Vista suroeste de la Ciudad de México* (ca. 1842). Museo Franz Mayer, Ciudad de México

of the early nineteenth-century paintings of Pedro Gualdi (Fig. 7.2). Pantitlán and *desagüe* thus appear as signs, the names of the two opposing conceptions of the geographical conditions and climate of the basin of Mexico, specifically the water of its rain, lakes, and rivers. The two are separated by radical ruptures involving the totality of the region's life and practices. Primarily, there was the violence of the Conquest, which destroyed not only a great number of the city's inhabitants, but also its hydraulic infrastructure and which served to secure the later establishment of religious, cultural, and epistemological paradigms that were in marked tension with their pre-Hispanic predecessors. If Pantitlán involved an approach that tried to control and manage water, *desagüe* opted to get rid of it.[2] Both models can be understood as technologies but nevertheless, as I have already suggested, they are connected to conceptions of the world and forms of life that go beyond the knowledge, tools, and work necessary to undertake them. They are *total* forms, sustained by the religions from which they emerge and that make them logical and necessary, and in their

effects by political decisions that imply particular relationships with nature and the population.

This is the other aspect I wish to emphasize in this chapter: the political and religious components of the two conceptions in order to think through the supposed change in the eighteenth century to a more scientific and technologized conception of the world. If diverse eighteenth-century thinkers (Adam Smith, Condorcet, Edward Gibbon, for example) manifest a markedly optimistic belief in man's technological capacity to take control of his destiny through the modification of the environment and of himself, that is, if they think of their era both as a moment of culmination and as a new beginning that would guarantee the expansion and development of what they understood as civilization, this principle is already sketched out in Hispanic colonial practices (del Valle). I suggest that in the "case" of Mexico City, the *desagüe*, the monumental technology installed and put into operation to modify one of the recently acquired colonies, allows us to think *ab initio*, and despite the army of friars and religious figures, of a secularized Christianity, that is, of Christianity as technology. It is not just that in persecuting pre-Hispanic religions Christianity attacked the very basis of indigenous technology (Restrepo 180), but that Christianity involved a particular notion of technology: in addition to opposing indigenous religions, it established an instrumental relationship with nature in which everything appeared possible. This transformative potential, latent in Judeo-Christian texts, was made possible by the encounter with places like Tenochtitlan which operated with a fundamentally different logic. Thus, the Spanish Colonial experience inaugurated new possibilities in the universe of the feasible—the "feat" of destroying and/or transforming old worlds and creating new ones—giving rise to the optimism that later in the eighteenth century would be linked to the creation of audacious plans and projects to change citizens and the environment by means of disciplinary, technological, and hygienic norms to guarantee the "well-being" of populations who were not necessarily colonial.[3] In this sense, the massive transformation of the pre-Hispanic world into European colonies is the eighteenth-century revolution's condition of possibility.

I

Control of water was so important for Mesoamerican societies that even a warrior people like the Mexica dedicated no less than nine of their eighteen ritual months to some aspect of it. Whether to mark the dry season, the rainy season, or the period of the corn harvest, the Mexica worldview rested on careful attention to its material basis, which depended on water being present in appropriate quantities and forms during each cycle (Arnold 78). The series of techno-religious rituals and practices around Tláloc, the religious complex that brings them together, already formed the axis of life in the region when the Mexica established themselves there in 1325. The Templo mayor (Great temple), erected at the center of the island with its two altars at its summit, one dedicated to Tláloc and the other to Huitzilopochtli, the tutelary warrior deity of the Mexica, testifies to the importance that the newcomers gave to the logic that regulated the possibility of life in the new place: war, yes, but also water, and with it the protection of the corn crop, as visible signs of a dual and contradictory order, but one made functional over the course of time (Fig. 7.3).[4]

Pantitlán, a natural drain at the center of Lake Texcoco was, along with mountains, caves, and other specific geographical places, one of the sites that were the settings for religious ceremonies dedicated to particular aspects of water control. In Pantitlán, as Bernardino de Sahagún, Diego Durán, and Fernando Alvarado Tezozómoc note, children were sacrificed during the dry season; along with feathers and precious stones, the hearts of the sacrificed were also offered up there to give thanks for the recently harvested crops. This choice was not arbitrary: as I have indicated, Pantitlán was a drain, that is, a site from which, should it be necessary, it was possible to control the water in Lake Texcoco. Tezozómoc notes that both Moctezuma Ilhuicamina and Ahuízotl, two Mexica *tlatoanis* (rulers), had ordered that Pantitlán be closed and fenced off during serious droughts to prevent further loss of water (Tezozómoc 170–171).

In addition to this functioning that we could call "technical," Pantitlán was associated with a choice of destiny. This was the site that marked the transfer of power from the Toltecs to the Mexica, the place chosen by the recently arrived warriors to enact a ritual pact with geography and climate. Here they accepted the gods' challenge and correctly chose corn, whereas the Toltecs had mistakenly chosen *chalchihuites* and other precious stones (Botta). With this gesture they recognized and complied with the knowledge of the peoples who inhabited the area long before them. Pantitlán is

Fig. 7.3 Tomás Filsinger, *Tenochtitlan* ca. 1520 (Artist's recreation of Tenochtitlan). At the center, the Templo Mayor, with its two altars: Tláloc's, and Huitzilopochtli's

thus a site that brings together religio-political and technological meanings that naturalized Mexica power (presenting it as the legitimate heir of the Toltec tradition) even as it forced this power into a relationship with living nature—a violence performed on the Mexica themselves: sacrifice—that would persuade the gods of water to fulfill the tasks required of them: raising the animals entrusted to them, giving the water needed by human beings and their harvests, etc. Pantitlán, then, marked the recognition of a non-human power with which a particular relationship was to be established. It was also, clearly, the place where a sovereignty was made manifest: the sovereignty of those who determined who had to be sacrificed, and in what way. In this sense, Pantitlán was part of an ideology and form of life that went from the most ordinary—such as possible forms of transport, consumption, and labor—to the most important, such as ritual and political conduct, and an understanding of the self and its place in the

social world and cosmic order. Hence, the indigenous groups that reproduced a language and thought associated with Tláloc and Pantitlán could not see the same thing in the "water" and "landscape" of the basin that the Spaniards who had just arrived in the region did. Although important, Pantitlán constituted just one site among the many marked out for rituals related to water; it was not exceptional, nor did it involve a different use of technology, but I choose it here over the Tláloc complex for the connotations that it acquired for the Spaniards and Creoles who, in many ways, reduced indigenous hydraulic knowledge to knowing where the drain was.

In associating *desagüe* with the Porfiriato in the nineteenth century, Manuel Perló Cohen has noted that it forms the basis of a way of doing politics that involves its transformation into the administration of resources, a supposed modernization and, owing to its monumentality, a certain exhibitionism. Technology thus would be politics (a way of affecting the population) by other means. Although this interpretation seems to me to be accurate, the beginning of the model should be pushed back to the sixteenth century, not only because that was when the first arguments for the *desagüe* were advanced (Gudiel 13–25), but also because, just as with the sand in Goya's painting discussed by Serres, and as Hernán Cortés's initial hostility toward the Mexica indicates, the fate of the Conquest was tied up with the modification and control of the environment by means of technology. It would be control of the lake and the destruction of the city's hydraulic infrastructure that would allow Tenochtitlan to be taken. Cortés's account of the war of conquest begins with his decision to build "thirteen brigantines" so that the lake could be dominated militarily (Cortés 311). Later he will dedicate the work of thousands of men to the destruction of the city's canals. On the other hand, as is well known, in the course of the armed conflict, at night the Mexica re-opened the canals that had been blocked by Cortés and his allies during the daytime. As the Spanish captain indicated, and as both adversaries seemed to recognize, "the key to the whole war" lay in the lake and its boats. The Spanish experience during the so-called *Noche Triste* [Sad Night] in which many of their soldiers were drowned and the rest were expelled from the city confirms that it was on the water that both sides would receive the most damage—as Cortés noted (Cortés 364).

For this reason, the *desagüe* along with the idea of destroying the native hydraulic infrastructure is from the start a colonial idea and project, that is, a political project that does not hesitate to choose the dominion of one

group over another, one form of life over another, and the survival of one group as opposed to another. Charles Gibson has demonstrated, indirectly but clearly, how during the colonial period, the *desagüe* amounted to low intensity warfare against the indigenous people, not only because in removing or rechanneling the water it did away with the material basis of their lives, but also because it literally did away with their lives by forcing them to work in the most precarious conditions in the name of saving the city from a new flood. The impact of the *desagüe* on the lives of indigenous peoples was multiple, and thus, as Gibson indicates, toward the end of the eighteenth century "it was quite evident that the most populous barrios were those nearest the water" while those whose water had been removed had experienced a severe and rapid decline (378).[5]

Pushing the paradigm in which technology becomes politics, that Perló Cohen reads in the *desagüe* of the nineteenth century, back to the historical moment in which it was initiated not only has the advantage of a greater fidelity to history itself (this might be a secondary aspect) but also allows us to see the project for what it really was: the signature of colonial government itself. Given that flooding was one of the most important urban problems throughout the colonial period, the responses that attempted to solve the problem therefore represent how the authorities understood the totality of the environment that surrounded them, and the distribution of functions and protection to the different groups that made up a diverse population. The *desagüe* is thus a metaphor for colonial government in various senses: firstly, with regard to the distribution of functions and labor, damage and benefits; secondly, by the way in which it linked the activity of government to a certain epistemology and a particular knowledge; and finally, in the way it was undertaken. In the first two senses, the *desagüe* represents, as I indicated in my reference to Gibson, a direct or indirect attack on the indigenous populations; it also represents an epistemology that, apart from at contingent moments—the danger of torrential rains—refuses to take into account in any real way the knowledge that preceded it. Notwithstanding the efforts of those like Bernardino de Sahagún, who with all his ambivalence (he wanted to destroy the religious axis that gave meaning to the culture that he documented and obviously admired), dedicated years to the study of the Nahua world and its knowledge, indigenous knowledge was of no consequence for most Spaniards and Creoles. As if the basin where Mexico City was located had been created for the first time right before their eyes, the newcomers behaved as

though the knowledge possessed by its previous inhabitants was altogether nonexistent or disposable.[6]

In 1555 Francisco Gudiel, the first to advocate the *desagüe*, claimed authority for his knowledge of the region on the grounds that he was "an old inhabitant" of the land (15). Forgetting that Mexico City and its problems had a historical density that dated back long before 1521, the protagonists of the new situation regarded thirty years as comprising a huge span of experience. As for the third sense, and as is acknowledged in the series of techno-administrative archives that were created to form the memory of the *desagüe*, the latter was carried out in an intermittent and arbitrary way, always subject to the will of the ruling viceroy.[7] Canals, channels, and tunnels were built or their construction stopped abruptly depending on whether there had been little rain or too much, or whether they were considered necessary or not. The canals were always dredged at the last minute; private individuals could channel water for their *haciendas* and all sorts of waste could be thrown into the city's internal canals. As if it were a territory that belonged to everybody and nobody at the same time, as Francisco de Cuevas's 1748 study on the problems of water points out, chaos seemed to prevail—no one did anything for the common good beyond what was strictly necessary. It is also clear from this archive that Spaniards and Creoles did very little until every indigenous sacrifice had proved insufficient. In differentiating which populations would be protected and which not, with their lack of attention to a historical density that largely escaped them, and through the incompetence and lack of interest of the organs of government, the *desagüe*, or politics as technology, is a clear example of the forms of government that, to deauthorize the Spanish presence in the Indies, Bartolomé de las Casas showed to be illegitimate by virtue of their doing absolutely nothing for those they supposedly governed, the majority of which were still indigenous people (512).

II

In *Genealogies of Religion*, Talal Asad explains that the "undeniable importance" of Western history in the constitution of the modern world obliges us to carry out an anthropology of the West, with the aim of understanding a particular form of society that continues to expand throughout the world (1–2). Without explaining it, Asad gives an interesting twist to his argument: from speaking about the West in general, he moves to focus on Christianity in particular, as if this aspect in some way were to represent a

central part, or the central part of the constitution of the West. In turn, Gil Anidjar has shown that Christianity actively splits itself to be reincarnated as secular (in its practices of knowledge) and thus present itself as a civilizing project supposedly unmarked by religion.[8]

We need to locate in the colonies this process through which Christianity became secularized, paradoxically infiltrating the very center of activities that were supposedly separate from religion (del Valle 442, 446). This process is the result of contingent events and circumstances, but also of Christianity's recognition of its own limits, which made it favor viable options that facilitated the enormity of the colonial enterprise.

Faced with the challenge of converting millions of indigenous people to Christianity in a short period of time—months or even years—it seemed more prudent for the Jesuits, for example, to lower expectations and begin by transforming them simply, albeit not completely, into Westernized people by getting them to displace their own practices and to adopt—to the extent that it was possible—different forms of food, housing, ways of living together, etc. In this sense we can say that Christianity performed a certain self-sacrifice in accepting a minimal return in exchange for continuing to have the possibility of control. In order to present itself as a "civilizing" power (one could even say a modern one), Christianity stepped aside, while nevertheless incorporating itself into the very materiality of non-religious practices.

Perhaps as Antony Anghie has noted, an early example of this transformation can be found in Francisco de Vitoria's *Relecciones* [Relections] (1532), in which the Papal donation that was meant to guarantee dominion over the new territories was rejected in favor of a supposed "natural law" universally applicable to all human beings (115). Thus, neither Christianity nor any other religion—a possibility that undoubtedly worried Vitoria—could assume the right to expand throughout the world. He himself wondered what would have happened "if the Saracens had offered their sect to Indians at the same time as the Spaniards did" (Vitoria 270). To avoid these sorts of hypothetical problems in the future, religion could not be the foundation of the rights claimed by the Spaniards. By contrast he does grant the rights to communication and trade. The Spaniards—says Vitoria—have the right to travel to the aforementioned provinces and remain in them since it is "humane and dutiful to behave hospitably to strangers" (278). Nevertheless, in Vitoria's version of the law of nations (what today we call international law) religion is rejected as a principle that guarantees dominion only to re-enter surreptitiously as one of the

elements that the Old World can and must offer to the New. Indigenous peoples are obliged, according to Vitoria, to receive and listen to the evangelists as the fulfilment of an international duty toward "visitors" from other nations: "If they [Christians] have the right to travel and trade among them, then they must be able to teach them the truth if they are willing to listen, especially about matters to do with salvation and beatitude" (284).

This much may be said regarding developments that resulted from a conscious decision that took into account the real possibilities and the political costs of proceeding in a different way—in the case of Vitoria, the unrealistic expectations and political danger involved in continuing to postulate the supposed Papal donation as the guarantee of dominion, or in the case of the New World evangelists, *demanding* a total conversion of the natives. The first case left open the possibility that the maximum authority of some other religion might make a similar claim; in the second, one would need to confront the absolute impossibility of the enterprise. On the other hand, there are decisions that seem more contingent and indirect—though still with substantial long-term structural effects—like modifying the environment to bring it closer to the imaginings, experience, and desires of its new inhabitants, without recognizing that it had already been profoundly altered by other human groups. This is the case with the *desagüe*. Although this particular strand of secularization does not present a linear historical trajectory, it is in the colonies that we can glimpse the first outlines of what would later in the eighteenth century lead Europe to detach the religious sphere from politics, science, and technology, a problematic operation given that, as the case of the colonies shows, religion had already been absorbed into these areas. It is not the case, on the other hand, that the colonies forced Christianity to develop in a way that was alien to it, but rather that in all aspects—law, science, and everyday life—they led one of its internal possibilities to come to fruition and be carried out, all, of course, in the name of the continuity of dominion. Nevertheless, this potential of Christianity—though it was limited at least through the Middle Ages—always existed.

George Bataille, an excellent reader of Sahagún's *Florentine Codex*, but a poor reader of Christianity, is for this reason mistaken in his *Theory of Religion* [Théorie de la religion] when he claims that it is technology, the first tool, which breaks the undifferentiated continuity between the beings of the world, and that it is religion that must be charged with somehow remedying this brutal separation. "The positing of the object which is not

given in animality is in the human use of tools (…) In so far as tools are developed with their end in view, consciousness posits them as objects, as interruptions in the indistinct continuity," says Bataille, signaling that it is the instrumentality of tools—objects whose finality constitutes their *raison d'être*—which with its radical strangeness alters the world of what had existed without a purpose (27). The only thing that can save us from the ruin into which technology plunges the sacred nature of the existent, says Bataille, is religion, the mechanism that would recover lost intimacy. Thus sacrifice, which entails the destruction of the object, only destroys it as object: "Sacrifice destroys an object's real ties of subordination; it draws the victim out of the world of utility and restores it to that of unintelligible caprice" (43).

Undoubtedly this is a possible reading of what the Mesoamerican religions attempt to do through human sacrifice: negate the separation between man and the world. But this interpretation, correct in the Mexica case, and which Bataille generalizes to all religion and all technology, is impossible for Christianity. Every religion implies an ontology and with it a definition of what can and must constitute technology. The logic behind the Mexica sacrifices is clear: they required man to renounce all ontological privilege. If water was used, corn was eaten, and animals killed, why not kill and eat other human beings? Man had no reason to think that the world was at his disposal, there for the taking, his to change, and consume at his whim: the universe did not belong to him and in this sense, he was the same as any other animal or plant. In a similar conception, religion had to incorporate man into this undifferentiated unity from which an instrumental approach separated him. This is precisely what the religiosity of the Nahua peoples did: sacrifice returns man to undifferentiated unity. Christianity functions in a completely opposite way. The myth of creation and that of Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden make it clear that man has sovereignty over everything that exists. God governs men and the universe in its totality, but man—before whom God places all of creation so that he can assign each object and animal its name, that is, its function and destiny—stands in for God in relation to nature. Man's creation seems precisely to have the aim of instituting a transcendental order in the universe: "And God said: let us make man in our own image, after our likeness; and let him have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the fowl of the air, over the cattle and over all the earth, and every creeping thing that creeps upon the earth" (Genesis 1:26) as if man's dominion created a second order, distinct from the given, above or below the divine order,

though in some way similar to it. Thus one of this God's first demands for man, the order to order/the command to command, is precisely that the latter become the lord of all creation: "Be fruitful and multiply; replenish the earth and subdue it; and have dominion over the fish of the sea" (Genesis 1:28).

In comparison to Nahua religiosity, the story of the expulsion from Paradise involves a different breach between man and the world: it is not technology that interrupts the undifferentiated unity about which Bataille writes. What separates man from the world is precisely religion, the order set up by a God who creates Earth and everything in it and places it all at the service of man. Just in case this initial order was insufficient and the attraction of continuity too powerful, new myths appear: the emergence of moral conscience, for example; the distinction between good and evil that, according to the serpent, would make men like gods ("you will be like God, knowing good and evil," Genesis 3:5). This knowledge—the Fall—makes necessary a doubly instrumental relationship with a now-hostile nature: "cursed is the ground for thy sake, in sorrow shalt thou eat of it all the days of thy life. Thorns and also thistles shall it bring forth to thee and thou shalt eat the herb of the field. In the sweat of thy face shalt thou eat bread" (Genesis 3: 17–19). It is the Old Testament God's condemnation that makes work—cultivation—a punishment and technology the art of taming a mean land that otherwise would only produce thorns and thistles.

To reinforce this new prohibition by which the earth fulfills its service to man through the work and pains of the latter—work as punishment and technology as a duty to correct the error—God Himself (the original moral principle of Judaism and Christianity) prevents the return to the Garden of Eden, something that might be interpreted as a return to that undifferentiation in which nature generously gave its fruit to man, in the form of the angel whose flaming sword forever denies access to it. It is the angel of God, and not technology (which here would allow an enemy land cursed by divine wrath to be tamed) that is interposed between man and the continuity of the world. This difference also explains the divergence between Pantitlán and the *desagüe*: one, perhaps excessively timid, having to pay in kind for a violence inflicted on nature, while the second could modify nature or even try to destroy it if necessary. The boldness of the *desagüe* is superlative: that Spaniards would change their lifestyle—from the beginning of the seventeenth century it was acknowledged that cattle raising and agriculture as the Spanish practiced them worsened the

problem of flooding—or move somewhere more supportive of it appeared to be unimaginable (Martínez). On the other hand, it *was* possible to radically change a nature considered to be hostile. For this reason, in the case of the technology that Christianity demanded, it is possible to conceptualize an inverse relationship to the one Bataille indicates: technology attempts to redeem man because of the damaged and adverse relationship that Christianity postulates between him and nature. The strangeness (the hostility that Cortés reads in the water) of the "natural" and "cultural" settings of those territories that would soon be turned into colonies is the new dimension that permits technology to make this idea concrete.

III

The year 1521. The end of the war brought reconstruction, and in moments of crisis, attempts at a pact. This is how we can read the substitution and supplementing of Tláloc and the *tlaloques* by Remedios and Guadalupe; the replacement of the intricate indigenous routes traced across an aquatic geography by the pilgrimages and journeys of the Virgins to the center of the city; Tláloc by Neptune. In any case, these were reductions and simplifications that for the most part turned a complex created to account for quite concrete material needs—food, life, social order—into concerns for security and safety—the guarantee of a water supply and protection against flooding. Be that as it may, these substitutions were based on a previous understanding, and from that understanding perhaps also a desire for a covenant. Pantitlán and what it represented could not be made to disappear by war or decree. In fact, even without the monumentality of religion and the state, the system that sustained Pantitlán persisted for a long time, as is indicated by the indigenous practices documented in the colonial treatises on "idolatries." At an official level, too, in an example of another reduction: throughout the sixteenth century and until the middle of the seventeenth, Jesuits, members of the city council, concerned citizens and engineers tried to locate the drain hole, seeing it as a panacea that would eliminate the threat of flooding with no economic or human cost. This was another simplification, however, because it implied that the whole complex indigenous ritual and technological system was concentrated there. In 1692 the continuing efforts to engage with at least this minimalist version of indigenous knowledge were rejected by the polymath Carlos de Sigüenza y Góngora, who made fun of those still searching for Pantitlán, noting how one of the expeditions had turned back after

finding a spring and not a drain; a discovery that, had it not been for the seriousness of a possible new threat of flooding to the city, would have been "a laughing matter" (167). Behind Sigüenza's irony is the refusal by many Creoles to link themselves to a living indigenous knowledge. For most of the Creole intelligentsia this latter could only have value as archaeological material, not as a relevant practical option. The pact now had to be different: now that the Christian rituals of Virgins and pilgrimages had subjected and reduced this knowledge, it could be catalogued in an hypothetical museum of antiquities to be extracted without risk and put to work in scholarly projects that collected and summarized both indigenous history and knowledge, but without including the subjects to whom they rightly belonged.

Pantitlán was never found and the *desagüe* continued to be the preferred approach to dealing with water. In 1748, one of the technical archives to which I have already referred sums up the situation of the indigenous system: if Pantitlán were found, it could not be used because the drain, if it existed, "would be that in name only, since sedimented with the slime and mud of two centuries, (…) it would not be possible to discover its location, or make use of it" (Cuevas 42). With this declaration the eighteenth-century city council accepted responsibility for the institutional consequences of two centuries of colonization and discarded any possibility of integrating indigenous knowledge, even the version in which technology is only the name of a fantastic possibility that would avoid the need to spend enormous amounts of money to remove the water from the city's environs. If in a certain sense this series of documents from 1748 represented the confirmation of an ambiguous colonial victory—from the position of the city administration and its bureaucrats, Pantitlán could no longer be considered an option—it also entailed a rupture with previous stances.

The confusion surrounding the management of water and hydraulic works was such that the document tried to evaluate matters as if it were dealing with the whole situation for the first time: what was happening in the city itself, in the surrounding haciendas; who was taking water, where and for what reason; who was not carrying out the repair works that they should, etc. The question that emerges from behind this detailed investigation points to the very possibility of such a(n) (dis)order: who was in charge of governing the city and controlling the water and how? Was it a question of simply extracting and getting rid of the water? We can even see a certain astonishment at the way indigenous people were treated

differently from the other inhabitants of some zones of the city: those indigenous groups cultivating 75% of the land in places like Tultepec and Cuautitlán were allowed only 25% of the available water (Cuevas 65).

The impetus and general nature of this approach in 1748 are the beginning of the critique of the *desagüe* system that José Antonio de Alzate would develop some years later in his *Gaceta de literatura* [Literature Gazette]. This critique, dating from the end of the eighteenth century, was now completely scientific but not thereby, as I hope to have demonstrated, less Christian in its foundations. Nevertheless, it differed in important, if not radical, ways from the European Enlightenment and the Creole knowledge that preceded it. In contrast to both, Alzate had a much more *universal* perspective on what he thought constituted scientific knowledge and the scope of any project that attempted to improve the life of a population *in general*, rather than only certain ethnically differentiated segments. When Alzate thought about the relationship between theory and practice and between what were considered to be centers and peripheries, as well as when he reflected on what he referred to as sources of knowledge (*letrados* but also any other members of society: indigenous people, women, peasants isolated in small settlements, etc.) he believed this knowledge to be constructed eclectically by and for many people.[9] It is in this sense that Alzate's work incites a rethinking of the foundations of colonial practices.

Although in the case of Mexico City, nature, or water, had been an "obstacle," Alzate suggested that the *desagüe*, a project necessary in his time given the circumstances, had an air of the absurd. If the first Spaniards had not insisted on founding the city in such an inappropriate place ("an enterprise that cannot be forgiven"), there would have been no need to subject its future inhabitants to the massive costs incurred to protect them from excessive amounts of water: "the public would not then have suffered the many burdens that have been indispensable to make and preserve a work worthy of the Romans: had the city been established somewhere else, there would have been no need even to think of them" (II. 4: 33–34). The *desagüe* and the city itself were the product of incompetence.

Alzate was against a complete *desagüe*, not because it endangered the indigenous world view (a possibility he did not consider) but simply because it endangered the lives of the indigenous population, who continued to be dependent on the water and its resources, and the well-being of people in general. In the areas of health and alimentary production along

with labor, Alzate affirmed that there was a relationship between water—even swampy water—and the life of the population, in particular of indigenous people. A generalized *desagüe* would be counterproductive because of the composition and mechanics of the soils: on the one hand, drying out would ruin buildings whose foundation and stability required moisture, and on the other, it would produce lands that were useless—as useful as the "sands of Libya," Alzate remarked ironically—for agriculture because of their high alkaline content, and would damage the health of the city's inhabitants (II. 11: 97). Alzate's more open and inclusive disposition led him to contemplate the possibility that not all indigenous decisions were necessarily erroneous. If, despite all logic, the Spaniards had chosen to live in such a place (Alzate explained that the Mexica had founded their city there for military reasons), a life that included water as well as indigenous practices—in agriculture, labor, nutrition and so on—was simply reasonable.

To attack the water was to attack the indigenous population and its way of life. In this sense, Alzate suggests a retracing of steps: a consciousness that permitted conceiving a continuity of water and with that a continuity of the lives of indigenous people. More audacious even than this, perhaps, is the fact that he also imagined the general benefits that would flow from adopting indigenous practices—drying out would ruin the city's architecture and the health of its inhabitants in general. Although this stance was disconnected from the pre-Hispanic religion in which the water in the lakes had specific meanings, that is, even though Alzate had a secular vision of indigenous life—which he interpreted as practices that were logical or not—in this case he did not wish to further accelerate what was already under way (*desagüe*) but rather to stop and rethink the situation. If Pantitlán was never found, the current absence of the lakes demonstrates that Alzate's words were never heeded.

IV

Pantitlán, then, persists only as the name of a useless and stagnant tradition. Perhaps the Metro station that bears its name would be a sort of enigmatic monument to that fissure that consumed all that was most precious—water, the blood of children, and the hearts of sacrificial victims—but also, as the failure to find it suggests, that which the indigenous population refused to share with the invaders. Whether through the blind and rushed use of the new technologies or through the negative will of the

conquered, with Pantitlán something was lost that perhaps may never be recovered.

In 1954, surely inspired by the dramatic city floods of the 1950s, Carlos Fuentes offers through *Chac Mool* a sort of fictional essay that lays out possible approaches to the water problem. The story recounts how the protagonist, a bureaucrat who collects pre-Hispanic objects, is drowned after a series of supernatural incidents that finally bring to life his most recent acquisition, a statue of Chac Mool, the Mayan god associated with rain. While the story engages with the problematic logic of sacrifice as a real possibility—the protagonist's death guarantees the life of the ancient deity—the god nonetheless appears as a figure out of place, clumsy and grotesque for the Mexico City of the period. The disconnection is radical: although the story suggests that the power of Chac Mool remains latent, a potential awaiting the resurgence of the system that makes it operative, once it comes to life again, it becomes an anomaly that is difficult to deal with—how about asking the god to offer his services to the Secretary of Hydraulic Resources to make it rain in the desert? the story comments ironically (21)—beyond relegating it to the realm of monstrous fantasies along with Frankenstein's monster and Borges's Golem.

Perhaps the conjunction of seemingly uncontrollable torrential rains and post-revolutionary *indigenismo* led Fuentes to this pessimistic reflection. Nevertheless, as we have seen, at least in a strictly technical sense, from the eighteenth century onward there was already an institutional determination to follow another course, to show that it was impossible to revive an *alternative* system for water control. The multiple contemporary projects that propose to liberate the rivers, to reconstruct the lake, and effect a sort of return to the lacustrine city do so, after all, from a perspective that does not share the same ontology and worldview of the inhabitants of the original island, but rather comes from a Western ethical vision—like that of Serres—that continues to place man at the center of the universe. If in this sense one of the contenders seems to have been defeated (at least on the terrain of ontology and hydraulics), outside of the ancient system that gave it foundation and form, the water insists on regaining its territory and every summer continues to fight, albeit in smaller spaces, against the *desagüe*. It was not beaten in 1607 when the first system of expulsion was begun, nor at the end of the eighteenth century with its expansion; nor again with the monumental channel built at the beginning of the twentieth century, under Porfirio Díaz, nor in the 1970s with deep drainage.

Perhaps the gargantuan Túnel Emisor Oriente, initially programmed to be completed by 2013, but only inaugurated in 2020, will succeed and will, once and for all, put an end to this extended struggle. I would like to think that this triumph (perforce an ambiguous one: the costs have been very high) that has indirectly created a truly single setting for the enormous majority of the population—Pantitlán is now just a Metro station—will not be an immensely paradoxical one for the winner.

Notes

1. Serres's proposal is very interesting in so far as with regard to colonialism he argues the closure of one period and the opening of another. In the same way that the specter of expansive colonial violence explains the attempt by Thomas Hobbes in *Leviathan* [1651] to exorcise the possibility of civil war through the idea of a social contract that would establish a new political foundation—a possibility restricted to the European countries and not extended to their colonies—Serres, like Hobbes avoiding a discussion of colonialism, proposes a contract with nature that would halt the violence of exploitation and destruction, that, as I suggest in these pages, began in 1492 in colonial settings.
2. The *desagüe* was begun in 1607 and only sought to remove the water from the north so that it did not end up in Lake Texcoco, the closest point to Mexico City. However, with regard to water in general (rain, lakes, rivers), this principle of expulsion or removal was slowly expanded over time and forms the paradigm that prevails to this day.
3. Claudia Agostoni studies some of these hygienic measures connected to the environment in general and to water in particular in Mexico City in the eighteenth century.
4. Alfredo López Austin's *Tamoanchan y Tlalocan* is an indispensable reference for an understanding of what is brought together in the Tláloc cult complex. For reasons of space I do not discuss here the way in which the Mexica managed the powerful contradictions between a war economy and an agricultural one; suffice it to say that this foundational tension is manifested in numerous ways and at many moments of their history.
5. Gibson's reading of the *desagüe* is not found in one place: the notes that indicate its devastating effect on the indigenous population in at least two senses—the destruction of an ecological balance with adverse consequences for the populations affected and the severity of labor involved in constructing and maintaining the drainage (the Indians lived "in dread of the desagüe," 240) are scattered throughout his book. In this sense, it is worth calling attention to more recent works that try to show that indigenous

people could adapt to the changes imposed by *desagüe* as long as they were not too drastic or sudden. This type of research tries to demonstrate that this technology, whose consequences had to be paid for by a particular group of the population, was less destructive than had been imagined. But trying to "measure" its effects is an exercise in calculating the incalculable. Vera Candiani, for example, seems to tell a story of adaptability and survival as if the fact that the project of *desagüe* had not entirely done away with the life of the indigenous people of the region, were a demonstration that, despited its negative effects, the drainage project was not a completely destructive technology.

6. Undoubtedly Bernardino de Sahagún tried to understand the religious system and history of the indigenous peoples in their own terms. Despite this and other similar efforts I contend that it was never the general case—I am not speaking here of isolated instances—that the Spaniards considered indigenous knowledge as equal to Spanish knowledge. The ambiguous objective of Sahagún, a Franciscan whose knowledge of the Nahua world was greater than most, either before or since, and who nevertheless, as he himself indicates, began his labor of knowledge with the aim of eradicating the very practices that he was investigating, is an indication of how the indigenous world was rejected even by its admirers (257–258).
7. There are various government compilations (small archives) of documents concerning the management of water and flooding in Mexico City: two produced during the Colonial period by the city's town council—in 1637 and in 1748—and another two drawn up during the period after independence—the first during the Porfiriato in 1901 to accompany the inauguration of the Gran Canal del Desagüe [The Great *Desagüe* Channel] and the second in 1976, produced at the same time as the work of Deep Drainage.
8. Although secularism can and, in many cases, does represent an important self-criticism of assumptions and practices that were originally Christian—and in this sense it is crucial to maintain it as an internal horizon of critical analysis—it is undeniable that it has avoided a fundamental re-examination of its origins and presuppositions and, by that very fact, of the bases of what, in spite of everything, it still shares with Christianity. Anidjar suggests that secularism is at root Orientalism (the creation of disciplines of knowledge linked to colonialism) and that it thus represents a chance for Christianity "to forget" itself and invent religion (that of non-Christians) as something to be found and rejected in other cultures/religions. In Sahagún's work we can see an early indication of this. It is in the name of Christianity—correct evangelization—that the Franciscan created one of the most impressive and complete ethnographic documents of the culture of the Nahuas, whose religion made them appear to be less than civilized or an example of a "perverse" civilization that needed to be modified. Apparently leaving Christianity

to one side, it is in the name of civilization or that of a better civilization that particular religions—those of the Nahua in this case—had to be eradicated.

9. *La gaceta de literatura* had precisely the aim of serving as a place of encounter between European, Spanish, and indigenous knowledge and thus of producing a synthetic system that would be useful to the whole population. One example (among many) of its recognition of the value of indigenous knowledge is to be found in its description of the medicinal practices (II.5: 41–43). Fiona Clark has shown that for Alzate, in what she refers to as productive networks of knowledge, there were multiple centers of geographical, social, and intellectual authority (252).

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CHAPTER 8

"Water, Only Water on All Parts": Re/imagining the Middle Passage in Teresa Cárdenas' *Mãe Sereia*

Miguel A. Valerio

Libraries have been written about slavery on land (and so much more remains unexplored). Far less has been written about slavery at sea. Two seminal studies, Stephanie Smallwood's *Saltwater Slavery* (2008) and Sowande' M. Mustakeem's *Slavery at Sea* (2016), are the only book-length, single-authored investigations of the subject. Besides these two books, Maria Diedrich, Henry Louis Gates, Jr., and Carl Pedersen's edited volume *Black Imagination and the Middle Passage* (1999) is another important reference. The volume *Spirits of the Passage*, edited by Rosemarie Robotham, is the only other book-length reference I could find. These studies show that sources are not lacking. Yet the experience of the Middle Passage is the least explored aspect of the Atlantic slave trade. This is even truer in Latin America, where far less attention has been paid to African slavery than in the US.

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Water is central to every culture. In fact, it could be said that water made society possible. So, colonization of and through water is as old as society. More significantly, however, water holds spiritual powers. In Christianity, the waters of baptism cleanse the baptized of original sin and admit them into the Christian community. In Yoruba culture, water orishas protect and provide for waterfarers (Karade 1994; Murphy and Sanford 2001; Parrinder 1961). In Kassena culture, another African culture, newborns are bathed in cold water to wake them up to the world (Olupona 2000). These African practices point to the meanings African societies have assigned to water from time immemorial. So, what did the waters of the Middle Passage mean to enslaved Africans? This seemingly simple question may hold the key to a central question of the Middle Passage: how did the terrible crossing affect the enslaved psyches and subjectivities? We know that enslaved Africans continued to practice African religions in the diaspora. Were religious beliefs put on hold during the Middle Passage or did they sustain enslaved Africans through the most horrible experience of their lives? This chapter turns to these questions through the analysis of a children's book about the terrible crossing.

Middle Passage studies have principally focused on the horrors aboard the slave ship. Focus on the water surrounding the ship has mainly dealt with the ocean as a graveyard of those who perished during the crossing, succumbing to disease, violence, or melancholia. In this chapter, I wish to take Middle Passage studies overboard the ship to explore the relations between the captives and the living waters outside their hell. Did the waters that enslaved them also sustain them? I do so through an analysis of the Afro-Cuban Teresa Cárdenas' *Mãe Sereia* (Mother Mermaid, 2018), a children's story that tells of a slave voyage undone by Yemanjá, the Yoruba orisha of the sea, and the "Mother Mermaid" of the text.[1] Cárdenas' re/imagining of the Middle Passage is one of the few Latin American texts to broach the subject and belongs to a growing subgenre of Afro-Latin American children's literature, of which the editor of *Mãe Sereia*, Cristina Warth, and her press, Pallas, through its imprint, Pallas Mini, are the main architects in Brazil. Beyond Latin America, the book is in a small company of works that treats (Western) modernity's founding trauma, as the Canadian critic Rinaldo Walcott (2018) has called the Middle Passage. The book is thus unique in myriad ways.

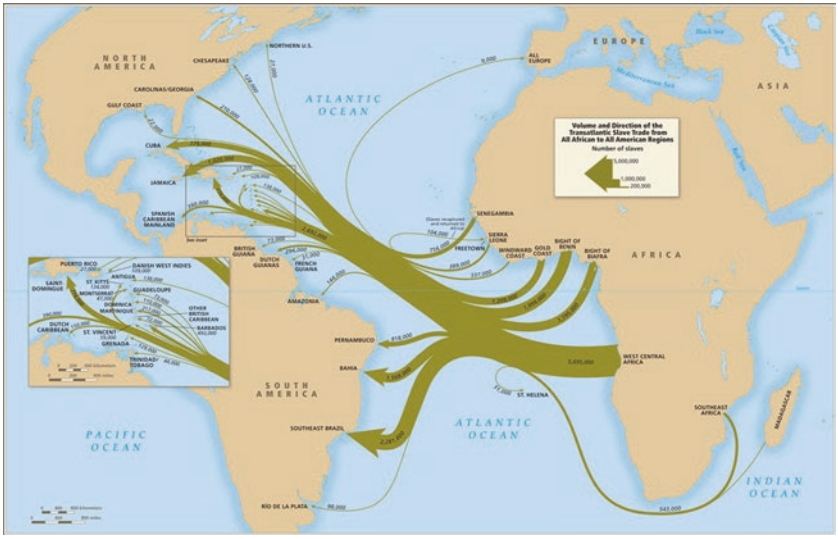
The aim of the chapter is to study the Middle Passage through the apparatus of the emerging critical approach of hydrocriticism. Hydrocriticism seeks to explore human relations to water (Blum 2010; Chambers 2010;

Cohen 2010; DeLoughrey 2007, 2010; Raban 1992; Steinberg and Peters 2015; Shewry 2015). Under this umbrella, hydrocolonialism investigates colonization of and through water (Bystrom and Hofmeyr 2017). The purpose of the chapter thus is to offer a decolonial approach to hydrocriticism, where rather than focus on the mechanisms of hydrocolonialism, we focus on how the colonized related to water. In this sense, the worldview *Mãe Sereia* draws on can teach us a great deal about how African and Afro-diasporic societies have related to water. In particular, the chapter will show how Afro-Latin American communities relate to water and the trauma of the Middle Passage.

Mãe Sereia is beautifully illustrated by the Brazilian artist Vanina Starkoff. In tandem, the text and the images make a whole that opens a whole new universe into the Middle Passage for children's eyes. Yet, like all children's books, it is most instructive to adults, and, not least of all, as we will see here, it is a supremely instructive book for hydrocriticism and Middle Passage studies.

The book draws on African and Afro-diasporic worldviews to offer children and adults alike a hypothetical Middle Passage non/crossing, where Yemanjá comes to the rescue. The book, then, belongs more to a sacred canon than to historical fiction. Thus, unlike previous re/imagining of the Middle Passage (see Walcott 2018; Gates et al. 1999; Morgan 2016), Cárdenas weaves a story where the Mother of the Waters saves her children from the greatest evil. So, like sacred texts, or *Black Panther*, *Mãe Sereia* tells an exemplary myth, where the waters of death become the waters of life.

While hardly any attention has been paid to the Middle Passage in Latin American fiction and scholarship, Cárdenas and Starkoff remind readers of the region's centrality to the history of slavery as the destination of at least two-thirds (over seven million) of all enslaved Africans during the Atlantic slave trade (1501–1886; see Map 8.1; Klein and Vinson 2007; Eltis and Richardson 2008, 2010). Thus, the region's population today is nearly 25%, if not more, Afrodescendant (compared with 7.3% indigenous; Telles 2014: 26).[2] It is this population, historically excluded from Latin American national imaginaries, that Afro-Latin American fiction seeks to bring to the forefront of Latin American debates. The children's strand of this genre aims to give children and adults alike stories in which Afro-Latin American children, historically absent from Latin American children's literature, especially in a positive light, see themselves, take pride in their ethnoracial identity, and learn their history. Cárdenas and Starkoff's book



Map 8.1 Map of the Atlantic slave trade with estimates, 1501–1886 (Courtesy of Slave Voyages Database)

is a major contribution to these goals. At the same time, it is unique in the subgenre as the first one to tackle the Middle Passage.

A children's story about the Middle Passage is a daunting challenge the author and illustrator took on exceptionally well. I do not know of any other children's book—in any language—about the Middle Passage (see Osa 1995; Lester 2011; Bishop 2009). While artists have tried to allude to the horror of the terrible crossing with abstractions that remain inaccessible to children, and even most adults (see Walcott 2018), Cárdenas and Starkoff manage to communicate to children that this unimaginably horrible thing happened to our ancestors, without abandoning the central tenets of children's literature, to wit: to "authentically depict and interpret children's history, build self-respect and encourage the development of positive values, and leave them with a sense of hope and direction" (Thompson 2007 [1995]: 13). This mandate has led many authors of children's literature to think subjects such as the Middle Passage or the Holocaust as inappropriate for very young audiences. Cárdenas and Starkoff show that it can be done and done well. Finally, while Jennifer L. Morgan (2016) praises artists who represent the Middle Passage as

void, Cárdenas and Starkoff present it as an experience full of meaning—indeed, full of an array of meanings that covers the spectrum of human experience. They thus invite us to imagine the Passage as a rich experience—naturally, not only in its positive sense, but in the sense of complete ontological fullness.

The story begins with the very first slave voyage: "quando da costa africana partiu o primeiro navio carregado com escravos" [when the first slave ship left the African coast] (np; Fig. 8.1).[3] At this point Yemanjá (Mãe Sereia) takes the form of a mermaid and decides to follow the ship: "Mãe Sereia, a deusa iorubá dos peixes e das águas salobres, mergulhou a imensidão das ondas transformada emu ma enorme sereia anil e seguiu a

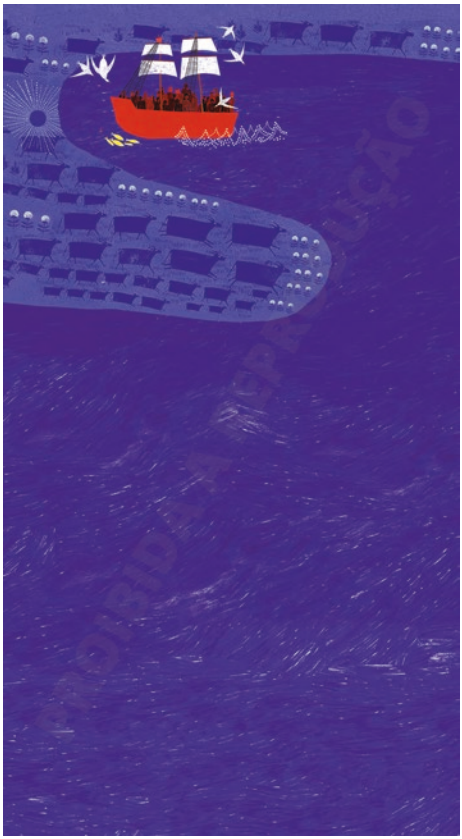


Fig. 8.1 Vanina Starkoff, Slave ship leaving the African coast, 2018 (Courtesy of Pallas Editora)

esteira de espuma a lágrimas através do oceano" [Mother Mermaid, the Yoruba goddess of the fishes and saltwater, jumped into the depth of the waves transformed into a blue mermaid and followed the wake of foam and tears across the ocean]. By starting with first slave voyage, Cárdenas re/un/does the origin and subsequent history of the Middle Passage. After this undone voyage, there will be no more. This is certainly a hope-dream harbored by many descendants of the trade.

Next Cárdenas describes the ship's captives as "the children of the forests and the warm plains, hunters of gazelles and antelopes, magnificent warriors, shamans and wet nurses, children that played in the mountains, heirs of ancestral kingdoms." This description humanizes the captives and calls the reader to think of them as human beings with pasts, not just this horrible present. By this simple gesture, Cárdenas avoids the pitfall found in many historical accounts of the Middle Passage, to wit: "it may appear that the Middle Passage can only precede. Nothing comes before it" (Morgan 2016: 193). Cárdenas here tells us that the Middle Passage, like slavery, is a mid-point with a happy before and a happy after somewhere in the horizon. This is why it is possible to write a children's story about the Middle Passage that moves beyond its horrors, that defies its terror.

The story now moves to the horrors of the ship, which "moved the mermaid's shell heart with pain." The ship's sojourn truly seems to have no end in sight. The terror of the voyage comes alive in one passage: "Vomitavam uns sobre outros, e seus olhos inutilmente buscavam a mancha apaziguente da terra no horizonte" [They threw up on each other and to no avail searched for some reassurance of earth in the horizon]. The story, then, does not shy away from the horrors of the passage (Fig. 8.2). It thus tells the story of the Middle Passage in an authentic fashion, with 50% of the story dedicated to communicating its ineffable horrors to both young and adult audiences. Both text and images achieve this in ways that show that this is the worst thing that could happen to a human being. But the story's happy ending will not give children nightmares, instead reassure them that no matter how bad things look, they are protected. Adults can parse this and take from the story a vivid understanding of the Middle Passage. Children will know a crucial, foundational moment of black history in the West.

As Yemanjá continues to follow the ship, the captives begin to lose faith in the "stories their ancestors told them" and mock them as "children's stories." But Yemanjá is by their side and understands why they are losing faith. Indeed, similar to victims of the Holocaust, many enslaved Africans must have lost faith in their ancestral ways. But by telling us that Yemanjá

Fig. 8.2 Vanina Starkoff, Captives on the slave ship, 2018 (Courtesy of Pallas Editora)

understands and does not abandon the captives as they lose faith, Cárdenas reassures young, and even adult, readers that others do not lose faith in us because we lose faith in them. This is a positive message that fosters faith in protection in the young and adult readers alike. Indeed, it is a girl in the ship that sees Yemanjá rock the ocean one night. And it is this girl that prays for deliverance. The captives are saved by a child's (not childish) faith.

And so Yemanjá comes to the captives' rescue and capsizes the slave ship (Fig. 8.3). At this point the captives do not understand what is going on and fear this will be their end. But Yemanjá holds them in her embrace as they fall to the sea, transforming them into sea creatures (sharks,

Fig. 8.3 Vanina Starkoff, Yemanjá capsizes the slave ship, 2018 (Courtesy of Pallas Editora)

dolphins, etc.; Fig. 8.4). The ex-captives are thus renewed and restored to life by Yemanjá's waters. Their hell was in the ship, their salvation in water.

Rather than read *Mãe Sereia* as a children's story full of children's fantasy, we should read it within the Latin American narrative tradition of magical realism. Like Alejo Carpentier's *The Kingdom of this World* or Gabriel García Márquez's *A Hundred Years of Solitude*, *Mãe Sereia* narrates a fundamental moment in Latin American history from the cosmology of the protagonists. In other words, just as voodoo was central to telling the story of the Haitian Revolution in Carpentier's *The Kingdom of This World* and folk superstitions to telling the history of Latin America in García Márquez's *A Hundred Years of Solitude*, so too are African and

Fig. 8.4 Vanina Starkoff, Yemanjá transforms ex-captives into sea creatures, 2018 (Courtesy of Pallas Editora)

Afro-diasporic worldviews to telling the story of the Middle Passage to a young audience. Young, and even adult, readers are gathered around the town storyteller to hear the story of how our goddess of the waters saved us from the greatest horror that could have ever visited us. I cannot think of a better text to teach children about the Middle Passage.

If we turn to the role of water and Yemanjá in the story, we can see how the story draws on how Afro-Latin American communities relate to water. By placing Yemanjá at the center of a story about the Middle Passage, Cárdenas underscores the central role African waterways must have played in enslaved Africans' experience of the Middle Passage. Unfortunately, we do not have any account of this. However, if we look to the role water and

Yemanjá play in Afro-diasporic religions, such as voodoo, santería, and candomblé, we can see how those waterways survived the Middle Passage, may have sustained the enslaved through it, and were transformed by it.

Water orishas play a prevalent role in Caribbean culture (Drewal and Houlberg 2008; Olupona 2000). In santería, where African divinities were disguised as Catholic saints (hence its name), Yemanjá became the Virgin of La Regla. Like Yemanjá, she is the mother/giver of life (Karade 1994; Dorsey 2020; Murphy and Sanford 2001; Parrinder 1961; Cabrera Thompson 2015). In candomblé, water rituals are central to the religion. On Yemanjá's feast day, February 2, practitioners carry her statue to the sea (Fig. 8.5). This is both a ritual of cleansing and memory. The practitioners are cleansed of evil forces by the saltwater. The ceremony is also a memorial to the ancestors who perished at sea, who are commended to Yemanjá (Lacerda 2006 [2003]). Finally, Lasirén (the Mermaid) is a central figure in Haitian voodoo, sustaining an island culture at the mercy of the sea (Fig. 8.6). In these religions, then, water is a bridge to the ancestors and the past, a conduit of life, as well as a reassurance that water is not our enemy, that a water spirit protects us. Perhaps many of the enslaved

Fig. 8.5 Candomblé practitioners carry a statue of Yemanjá to the sea on her feast day in Salvador, February 2, 2017 (Courtesy of Viator)

Fig. 8.6 Nancy Josephien, *La Sirene*, 2002 (Courtesy of Indigo Art Gallery, New York)

felt this way aboard the slave ship and thanked Yemanjá for surviving it upon arriving on land.

Cárdenas may have been also inspired by the origin story of Cuba's Marian patron, the Virgin of Charity of El Cobre. According to local legend, in the seventeenth century, three men, two taínos and one African, but all named Juan, went for salt to a nearby smaller island. The three Juanes were caught in a hurricane. One of the Juanes (the legend—recorded in a seventeenth-century document—does not say which) had a medal of the Virgin. This Juan began to pray and suddenly sky cleared up. The Juanes then saw an image of a woman in the sky, whom they eventually recognized as the Virgin, which came to be called El Cobre, as the

town the Jaunes were from, Santiago, was known at the time (Fig. 8.7). This story may have served Cárdenas as a model for *Mãe Sereia*, where the Virgin of El Cobre is replaced by the Virgin of La Regla/Yemanjá. In any event, there are abundant parallels between the two stories.

As we have seen, water holds special spiritual powers for African and Afro-diasporic communities. Such understanding of water has been recorded in all sub-Saharan African societies (Karade 1994; Dorsey 2020; Murphy and Sanford 2001; Parrinder 1961; Olupona 2000). These

Fig. 8.7 The Virgin of Charity of El Cobre appears to the Juanes (Popular Cuban image)

relations to water must have played a role in how Africans experienced the Middle Passage. Perhaps the slave voyages undone by revolt were inspired by Yemanjá. And the millions who survived the terrible crossing may have been sustained by her. This is not to take a naïve approach to the Middle Passage but to seek to understand how African subjectivities informed the enslaved experience of its horrors. This approach can thus reorient hydrocriticism into asking questions not about how peoples and waterways were colonized but how those peoples and waterways responded to colonization, and how their subjectivities shaped those responses.

In sum, then, Cárdenas and Starkoff's book opens new avenues for re/imagining the Middle Passage. They invite us to imagine what solace the enslaved may have found in their ancestral waterways as they lived the most horrific days of their lives aboard the slave ship. In other words, they bid us to imagine what hopes they may have harbored for deliverance from their water deities. In so doing, they urge us to imagine the Middle Passage from the perspective of the enslaved in a new way, one that also accounts for their hopes and dreams while imprisoned in the slave ship. By enunciating these hopes and dreams from Latin America, the authors invite Latin American readers to remember the region's place in the history of slavery and, more importantly, Africa and Africans' imprint on the region. Beyond the Middle Passage and Latin America, Cárdenas and Starkoff's book also call hydrocritics, especially students of hydrocolonialism, to consider the phenomenon from the perspective of the colonized. To put it another way, they prompt hydrocritics to consider how those who were colonized through water understood and interacted with the element prior to, during, and after colonization.

Mãe Sereia taps into water's polysemy in remarkable ways. The waters of death become the water of life, of rebirth, of resurrection. The relation of the enslaved to the other-than-human, water, through Yemanjá, yields the fruit—deliverance—they longed for the most.

Beyond the Middle Passage, inland waterways should also be explored in connection with slavery. The French Jean-Baptiste Debret depicted several scenes of slave labor on inland waterways in his *Voyage pittoresque et historique au Brésil* (Picturesque and historic voyage to Brazil, 1816–31), published in Paris in three volumes between 1834 and 1839 (Figs. 8.8 and 8.9; see Debret 2014). Figure 8.8 shows enslaved Afro-Brazilians carrying goods across a river. Figure 8.9 is richer, showing all sorts of labor, from washing clothes to mining gold. In this image, blacks are engaged in labor possibly as free people and for their own purposes, regardless of legal

Fig. 8.8 Lower image. Debret, River crossing, *Voyage pittoresque et historique au Brésil*, Paris, 1834–39, vol. 2, plate 47 (Courtesy of the New York Public Library)

Fig. 8.9. Upper image. Debret, Work at the river's edge, *Voyage pittoresque et historique au Brésil*, Paris, 1834–39, vol. 2, plate 48 (Courtesy of the New York Public Library)

status. Together with Cárdenas and Starkoff's book, these images, and others, show that water is central to the black experience, from freedom to slavery and back to freedom—the conduit of life that has sustained them through it all. Thus, more attention should be paid to water in the black experience in Latin America and beyond. In the absence of textual evidence, stories and images can help us do this work.

Scholars are already looking at visual representations of slavery (Lugo-Ortiz and Rosenthal 2016; McInnis 2013; Wood 2013—to cite just three). Turning to Debret and other artists who depicted—however biased—the interaction and relation of the enslaved to water will help move this field of study into a new terrain.

Notes

1. The book has been subsequently published in Spanish as *Madre Sirena* (2019). For English readers, there is now a children's book in English, Nikole Hannah-Jones, Renée Watson, and Nikkolas Smith's *Born on the Water* (2021), available.
2. A major challenge to knowing the exact number is self-identification in the mixed-race population, which can be identified as white depending on numerous factors, such as national race ideology, social class, etc.
3. Unless otherwise noted, all translations are my own.

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